Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Isaiah

Isaiah 1:1

- This is the vision: This term introduces the book as a unified whole, covering Isaiah's prophecies over about fifty-five years, from around 740 to 685 BC.
- Isaiah son of Amoz: Nothing else is known about Isaiah's family.
- Jerusalem, the capital city of Judah, was the center of Isaiah's ministry. Some of his prophecies also relate to the northern kingdom, Israel (called Samaria and Ephraim, Isaiah 9:8–21; 28:1–13), which Assyria destroyed in 722 BC (see 2 Kings 17).

Isaiah 1:2

heavens ... earth: All of creation is called to witness the trial that God has convened against Judah (compare Deuteronomy 31:28; 32:1).

Isaiah 1:3

The ox knows its owner: Even an animal recognizes the one who feeds and cares for it. But Judah did not recognize or obey the Lord in this way.

Even so, despite their rebellion, God still spoke to them as "my people." This shows his continued grace (undeserved kindness) toward them.

Isaiah 1:4

The term Holy One of Israel often appears in Isaiah as a title for the Lord. God is:

- the righteous and just King of heaven and earth (Isaiah 6:3–5),
- the incomparable God, meaning no one is like him (Isaiah 40:25), and
- the Redeemer (the one who rescues and saves) of his people (Isaiah 43:14).

Because of this, it was a serious and foolish sin for Judah to reject him.

Isaiah 1:5

God sent famine, war, disease, and death as punishment. However, God often wanted to change stubborn behavior rather than just punish.

Because of their ongoing rebellion, the people's "head" is described as injured and their "heart" as sick. This language shows how serious their condition had become.

The nation suffered physical harm from Assyrian attacks. At the same time, they were spiritually defiled and overcome by sin (Isaiah 64:6).

Isaiah 1:6

neither cleansed nor bandaged nor soothed with oil: Judah's national condition was like an injured person who had not received medical care.

Isaiah 1:7

land ... cities: By 701 BC, the Assyrians had destroyed the infrastructure, captured cities, and devastated the fields (see Isaiah 64:10). This fulfilled Isaiah's prophecy (Isaiah 6:11–13).

Those who survived the Assyrian attack learned to heed later warnings of exile to Babylon (Isaiah 39:6–7). God fulfills his promises, so his warning of judgment on all nations is certain.

Isaiah 1:8

the Daughter of Zion: Zion, one of the hills on which Jerusalem stands, often served as another name for Jerusalem.

Zion symbolized God's presence (Psalm 46), his protection of his people, and Jerusalem's strength against enemies. Now, however, the opposite is true. Jerusalem has become weak, like a helpless city under siege and like an abandoned shelter or a shack.

Isaiah 1:9

the LORD of Hosts: This title refers to the countless angels under the Lord's command (see 2 Kings 6:16–17; Matthew 26:53).

During the exodus, Moses described God as a warrior who fought for his people (Exodus 15:1–21). Ironically, in Isaiah's time, God fought against Judah because of their wickedness (Isaiah 1:24; 3:1–5).

Isaiah 1:10

- Hear the word of the LORD: Here, listen means to obey the law (or teaching; Hebrew torah) of our God (see Isaiah 2:3; 5:24).
- rulers ... people: All levels of society were guilty.
- Like Sodom and Gomorrah, Jerusalem faced divine judgment for rebelling against God's laws. Jerusalem might have been completely destroyed like those cities if not for God's grace (Isaiah 1:9; see Genesis 19).

Isaiah 1:11–15

The people had sinned so much that God no longer found joy in their sacrifices. The Lord wanted Judah to stop the religious practices he had commanded them to do rather than to continue them in a manner that was sinful and false (Isaiah 1:13). Ceremony cannot replace true godliness.

Isaiah 1:13

- The incense with offerings was meant to be a sweet fragrance to the Lord (see Exodus 30:7–8). However, when offered with hypocrisy, it became a disgusting smell and an offense to God.
- The Lord had designated special fasting days at the temple (Leviticus 16:31; 23:32; Numbers 29:7), but Judah's sinfulness ruined them (see Isaiah 58:1–7; Matthew 6:16–18).
- solemn assembly: These holy days were associated with the new moon and other festivals (see Leviticus 23).

Isaiah 1:14

- New Moon celebrations took place on the first day of each lunar month (Numbers 28:11–15). These days included sacrifices, special meals, and rest from work.
- The annual festivals included:
- Passover,
- the Feast of Unleavened Bread,
- the Feast of Weeks, and
- the Feast of Tabernacles (Numbers 28:16–29:39; Deuteronomy 16:1–17).

Isaiah 1:15

I will hide my eyes from you ... I will not listen: The Lord does not answer prayers from those who live in constant wrongdoing. In this situation, God accused the people of twisting his laws to commit violence against innocent victims.

Isaiah 1:16

Wash and cleanse yourselves: The people were made unclean by their sin and impure sacrifices. To be clean in God's eyes, they needed to change their behavior, remove their sins, and abandon their evil ways (see also Isaiah 1:18).

Isaiah 1:17

Seeking justice means following God's standards of fairness and supporting the rights of the oppressed, orphans, and widows—those who are weak and marginalized in society (see also Jeremiah 7:5–7; 22:3; Zechariah 7:10; Matthew 23:23; 25:31–46; James 1:27).

Isaiah 1:18

- God called his people to come and settle their dispute so that he could restore his covenant relationship with them. Judah had to choose between obedience and rebellion (Isaiah 1:19–20). Isaiah says their sins are "like scarlet" and "red like crimson," the color of blood, which Judah had shed unjustly (Isaiah 1:15).
- white as snow ... like wool: The people would be radically transformed. God would cleanse, purify, and make them holy (see also Psalm 51:7; Daniel 7:9).

Isaiah 1:19–20

Repentance leads to life. Resisting God's will and turning away from him leads to death (see Deuteronomy 11:26–28; 28:1–62).

Isaiah 1:20

For the mouth of the LORD has spoken: This statement shows the seriousness of God's promise. The phrase appears 11 times in Isaiah.

Isaiah 1:21

The image of Jerusalem as a prostitute symbolizes Judah's unfaithfulness to God (see Jeremiah 3:6–14; Ezekiel 16:25–26; Hosea 1–3).

Isaiah 1:24

The Lord GOD of Hosts, the Mighty One of Israel, was usually Israel's protector (Isaiah 31:5). However, in this context, God was coming to take revenge against his own people. Their wickedness had turned them into his enemies and foes.

Isaiah 1:25

- I will turn My hand against you: God, who was usually Israel's protector, would now act against them as a judge. However, his purpose was not only to punish. He planned to correct and restore his people.
- I will thoroughly purge your dross; I will remove all your impurities.: God would use the exile in Babylon to remove the wicked from among his people and to refine those who would return.

Isaiah 1:26

The restoration of the community would include new leaders. These leaders would uphold justice instead of twisting it (see Isaiah 1:23).

Jerusalem would once again be like pure silver (see Isaiah:22). The city would again be called the City of Righteousness and the Faithful City.

Isaiah 1:27

Here, Zion refers to the remnant (the small group who remain faithful) within the community. Only those who repent (turn away from sin) would receive God's salvation and cleansing. They would live in his presence.

Zion was meant to be a strong place of justice and righteousness. God loves what is right. He expected the covenant community (the people bound to him by promises) to reflect his holy standards in the way they lived.

Isaiah 1:29–30

The rebels (Isaiah 1:28), who worshipped idols in sacred oak groves and gardens, would become like oaks and gardens suffering from drought. They would miss the life-giving presence of the true God. Those who followed the Canaanite fertility religion of Baal considered gardens and trees sacred, thinking they brought blessings. Instead, they led to spiritual death.

Isaiah 2:1

message (literally word): This heading (see Isaiah 1:1) likely introduces the revelation of chapters 2–12. The main focus is on Judah, but some passages also include:

- the nations in general (Isaiah 2:2–4),
- all humankind (Isaiah 2:6–22),
- Syria and the northern kingdom of Israel (Isaiah 7–9), and
- the Assyrians (Isaiah 10).

Isaiah 2:2

- In the Old Testament, the phrase the last days generally refers to a future time (see Jeremiah 49:39; Ezekiel 38:16; Hosea 3:5). In the New Testament, it refers to the period that started with the arrival of Jesus (Hebrews 1:2). More specifically, it refers to the time just before the end of the current age (2 Peter 3:3).
- The mountain of the Lord's house refers to the Temple Mount. This place symbolizes God's glorious exaltation (see Isaiah 6:1) and his kingdom on earth. Isaiah's focus on God's supreme kingship comes from his famous vision of God (Isaiah 6).
- Isaiah's prophetic hope was not a narrow nationalistic dream. It included people from all over the world, beyond Judah and Jerusalem.

Isaiah 2:2–4

One day, God's generous salvation will reach beyond Israel and Judah. This will lead nations to come to Zion, not for war, but to receive blessings and live by God's rules.

Isaiah urged Judah to see the benefits that other nations would gain. He wanted to inspire the people of Judah (Isaiah 2:5) to feel motivated and follow the Lord, so they would not miss out on that day.

This section is almost exactly repeated in Micah 4:1–3.

Isaiah 2:3

- Human society will change as people follow God's revelation and his ways.
- Judah had already received God's teaching and word, but they did not obey it (Isaiah 1:10–15). However, the nations will be ready to do God's will.

Isaiah 2:4

- The kingdom of God becomes clear when conflict and violence stop. It is characterized by peace (Romans 14:17). People will either choose to cooperate or be compelled to stop fighting (Psalm 46:9). Nations will choose divine judgment instead of war (see Isaiah 1:18–20).
- The words judge and arbitrate describe God's actions here, but later verses show the Messiah as the one who delivers justice (Isaiah 11:3–4). When this happens, war will end, and nations will turn their weapons into farming tools.
- swords into plowshares: Compare Joel 3:10, where nations are urged to beat their plowshares into swords.

Isaiah 2:5

- Come ... let us walk: Walking in God's light (his revelation) leads to a glorious role in his kingdom (see Isaiah 60:1; 1 John 1:7). God is the only light that defeats the darkness of sin and evil (Isaiah 9:2).

People cannot create this light on their own (Isaiah 59:9). They must walk in the light God provides, trusting him and obeying his will (Isaiah 50:10).

- The phrase house of Jacob refers to Israel's special historic relationship with the Lord and their history of sin and rebellion (see Isaiah 14:1; 48:1).

Isaiah 2:5–22

The prophet warned of judgment and mocked human pride. All human systems (religious, economic, military, and social) will face God's examination and be found lacking on the Day of the Lord. This is the

final day in history when God will judge the wicked once and for all (1 Corinthians 1:8; 1 Thessalonians 5:2; 2 Thessalonians 2:2; 2 Peter 3:10; Revelation 20:7–15).

Sometimes, prophets used the phrase the day of the Lord (or others like it, such as that day) to describe specific times when God judged wickedness throughout history (see Isaiah 13:6, 9; Ezekiel 13:5; 30:3; Obadiah 1:15). On the Day of the Lord, only God will be honored. All human wickedness and pride will be defeated. This glorious day of God's arrival will fill wicked and arrogant people with fear (Isaiah 2:10, 19, 21).

Isaiah 2:5–4.1

Isaiah condemned Israel and Judah for their pride and self-importance. He warned them that only God should be honored. All attempts by humans to lift themselves up will actually result in humiliation.

Isaiah 2:6

- The Lord had rejected his people to discipline them (Isaiah 8:17). Although not permanent, this rejection seriously threatened their hopes for a glorious future.
- soothsayers: These were people who practiced pagan religion and magic. God had clearly forbidden this practice in Israel (Deuteronomy 18:10–11).
- The Philistines were ancient enemies of Israel (Isaiah 9:12; 11:14; 14:29, 31).

Isaiah 2:7–8

Isaiah listed the things people used as substitutes for the true God. These included material wealth and security, such as silver and treasures. They also included military strength, such as warhorses and chariots. People also trusted in idols, which were objects they loved and valued.

This kind of wealth and military power marked the reign of King Uzziah (2 Chronicles 26:6–21). However, Isaiah showed that trusting these things was wrong.

In other places, Isaiah explained how foolish it is to worship something made by human hands (see Isaiah 44:9–20; 45:16).

Isaiah 2:10

- On the day of God's judgment, people will try to hide in caves and among the rocks. These were natural hiding places in the rocky land of Judah. Instead of repenting with humility before the almighty God, they will try to escape his judgment.

Kings and leaders, as well as slaves and free people, will all look for protection from this judgment(see also Revelation 6:15).

- The terror of the LORD rrefers to God's full and powerful wrath against wickedness. This wrath will be revealed on the day of the Lord's judgment. At this point, the prophecy moves from speaking mainly about Israel (Isaiah 2:5–6) to speaking about all humankind.

The Lord opposes anything and anyone to speaking about all humankind (Isaiah 2:11–12, 22).

Isaiah 2:11–12

- A key theme in Isaiah is that the Lord will be exalted and humble people will be restored (Isaiah 57:15), while proud and powerful people are humbled (26:5).
- The day of judgment and the day of reckoning are also called the Day of the LORD. There are seven references to this in Isaiah 2–4 (2:11, 17, 20; 3:6, 18; 4:1, 2).

Isaiah 2:13

- The cedars of Lebanon were valuable trees used to build Solomon's Temple and palace (1 Kings 5:6) and other important buildings (Ezra 3:7). The cedars symbolized wealth and power (2 Chronicles 25:18; Psalms 92:12; 104:16), but these mighty trees were as nothing before the Lord (Isaiah 10:34; 33:9; see the boast of Sennacherib in 37:24).
- The oaks of Bashan were also an image of strength and splendor (Ezekiel 27:6). They, too, will disappoint (Isaiah 33:9; Nahum 1:4; Zechariah 11:2).

Isaiah 2:13–16

The prophet used several images of human strength to explain Isaiah 2:11–12.

Isaiah 2:16

every stately vessel: This refers to large, decorated sea-going ships. These ships were a sign of wealth and economic success.

They showed that a nation was strong in trade and rich in resources.

Isaiah 2:17

that day: This refers to the Day of the LORD (see Isaiah 13:4–13).

Isaiah 2:20–21

Animals such as rodents and bats live in dark, underground places. They avoid the light and stay hidden.

In the same way, those who worship idols will try to hide from the Lord's judgment. They will seek dark places instead of turning to God in repentance.

Isaiah 2:22

- The prophecy of judgment in Isaiah 2:6–21 between two related calls to action. First, the people are urged to trust the Lord (Isaiah 2:5). Then they are warned not to trust in human beings (Isaiah 2:22).
- Human strength does not last. It is weak and short-lived, like a person's breath (see Psalm 90).

Isaiah 3:1

remove ... food and water: Long ago, God warned of famine. It could lead to terrible conditions and desperate acts as a judgment for wickedness (Leviticus 26:26–29).

Isaiah 3:1–12

These verses continue discussing judgment against Israel's leaders (see Isaiah 1:23–25). Removing leaders at all levels would let the mob take over. Chaos and famine would turn Judah and Jerusalem into a social wasteland.

Isaiah 3:2–3

On the day of judgment, all military, civil, judicial, and religious leaders will be removed (Isaiah 39:7; 2 Kings 24:14–16). God will eventually provide good leaders again (Isaiah 1:26), but not those who use pagan methods of revelation (47:9, 12–13; see Deuteronomy 18:10–12).

Isaiah 3:4

Conditions would be so severe that even boys and toddlers could become candidates for office. Isaiah might have meant that adult leaders would be so reduced in number that only children would be left to take on the role.

Alternatively, he might have meant that the new leaders would be as immature, unwise, strong-willed, and inexperienced as children.

Isaiah 3:6–7

Things would be so bad (this heap of rubble) that no one would want to lead. The people would become so desperate that anyone offering food or clothes could lead them (Isaiah 3:7). However, no one would actually have food or clothing (see Isaiah 4:1).

Isaiah 3:8–9

- The weakness of human strength and society can be seen as a form of divine judgment.
- His glorious presence: The people of Judah were openly wicked, like the people of Sodom (Isaiah 3:9; see also 1:9–10).

Isaiah 3:9

The expression on their faces: At this time, the people openly defied God.

Isaiah 3:10

The godly, that is, the righteous remnant (the faithful people who remain loyal to God), will receive God's reward (see Isaiah 40:10).

Isaiah 3:11

Those who do wrong and act unfairly will face God's just punishment.

Isaiah 3:13

The Lord is both the prosecutor and the supreme judge in this trial against his people.

A prosecutor is someone who brings charges in court. A judge is the one who decides the case. In this passage, the Lord fills both roles.

Isaiah 3:14

- elders and leaders: Wicked and abusive leadership by ungodly and incompetent leaders hinders God's purpose for his people (see also Isaiah 3:12). Therefore, leaders face stricter judgment because they are responsible for the well-being of those they lead.
- the vineyard: See the Song of the Vineyard (Isaiah 5:1–7).

Isaiah 3:15

The Lord cares for the poor. These were the marginalized and oppressed (people pushed aside and treated unfairly; see Isaiah 1:17). But God is their protector (see 25:4).

God asked his people to share his concern for the poor. But instead of helping the poor, many Israelites exploited them to gain wealth (see Isaiah 3:14). They used their power to take advantage of those who could not defend themselves.

Isaiah 3:16

- The dramatic descriptions show how the people of Jerusalem loved their refined way of life. They proudly showed their self-reliance, power, and prestige.
- daughters of Zion: See “Zion” Theme Note.

Isaiah 3:16–4.1

TThis passage applies the prophet’s teaching on arrogance (see Isaiah 2:11–12) to the people of Jerusalem. An alternate understanding is that this passage applies specifically to the women of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 3:17–25

take away their finery: In a reversal of fortune, the affluent (wealthy) and proud people of Jerusalem would suffer disgrace (public shame). Wealthy women often wore expensive and beautiful clothing or jewelry (Isaiah 3:18).

This finery probably included amulets (small objects people believed could protect them from evil). The people wore these items to keep harm away. But these objects could not prevent the disaster of judgment.

These beautiful items were also status symbols. They showed wealth, importance, and financial security. The people trusted in these outward signs of success.

Isaiah 3:25

Your men will fall ... in battle: Part of the city’s hopeless destitution (extreme poverty and loss) would be the deaths of the men.

Isaiah 4:1

During Isaiah’s ministry, Jerusalem’s population was greatly reduced. War, famine (lack of food), and disease caused many deaths (Isaiah 3:1–3; 6:13; 14:30; 22:2; 37:4).

So many men died that few were left in the city. This created a serious absence of leadership (see Isaiah 3:1–12). Without strong leaders, the city became weak and unstable.

Even worse conditions were coming. In 734–732 BC, Judah faced war with an alliance(a military agreement) between Syria and Israel (2 Chronicles 28). Later, from 605 to 586 BC, Babylon conquered Judah. Jerusalem was destroyed and fell to its enemies.

Isaiah 4:2

- The Branch likely refers to the remnant (the faithful people who remain) who would form Israel’s new beginning after the exile (see Isaiah 6:13). Some understand the branch as the ideal descendant of David, the Messiah (God’s chosen king; see Isaiah 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5; 33:15–16; Zechariah 3:8; 6:12).
- Isaiah describes a beautiful and glorious change. The people had experienced shame and disgrace (Isaiah 3:17–25). Now they would experience fertility (fruitfulness) and beauty. This change would show God’s presence and blessing among the remnant (4:6).
- Even the land would change. The fruit of the land and nature itself would move from desolation (emptiness and ruin) to glory. Isaiah compares this future to the garden of Eden (see Isaiah 51:3; 65:22). The message of renewal finds its ultimate fulfillment in the new creation (see Romans 8:19–27; 2 Corinthians 5:17; Galatians 6:15; Ephesians 2:15; 4:24; Revelation 21:22–27).
- Those who survive in Israel (the remnant) would be the true citizens of Zion. They would belong to the renewed people of God and share in his promised restoration.

Isaiah 4:2–6

In bold contrast to the desperate picture in Isaiah 3:16–4:1, this prophecy brings salvation and hope. Instead of shame and loss, it promises cleansing, consecration (being set apart for holy use), and renewal. God would cleanse his people from their sin. He would make the remnant holy. He would restore his presence among them.

The imagery in Isaiah 4:5–6 alludes to Israel’s exodus from Egypt. At that time, the Lord guided and protected the people with a pillar of cloud by day and a pillar of fire by night. Isaiah uses this picture to describe Israel’s future restoration. Just as God once led his people out of Egypt, he would lead them out of exile. Their return would be like a second exodus.

Isaiah 4:3

- To be holy was the requirement for citizenship in Zion. Zion is the place where God dwells in his glorious majesty (see Isaiah 6:3; Hebrews 12:14).
- The remnant would have their names recorded among the living in the Book of Life (Exodus 32:32; Daniel 12:1; Malachi 3:16; Revelation 3:5; 20:12).

Isaiah 4:4

God’s judgment has a purifying effect on his covenant people (see Malachi 3:3). Justice must be satisfied before restoration can be offered.

Isaiah 4:5

The references to a canopy of cloud and smoke and flaming fire recall God's continuous presence and protection during the exodus from Egypt (Exodus 13:21–22; 14:21–22).

Isaiah 4:6

shelter (literally shadow): See Isaiah 32:2; God's protection would keep the remaining people safe from enemies and the destruction he would bring upon the wicked (Isaiah 33:14–16).

Isaiah 5:1

- my beloved: This refers to the Lord. The prophet was singing this song on the Lord's behalf.
- At first, the song seems like a love song. But by Isaiah 5:3, readers realize it is actually a complaint.
- For more on Israel as God's vineyard, see also Isaiah 3:14; Matthew 21:33–46; John 15:1–17.

Isaiah 5:1–7

The Song of the Vineyard is a poem where God criticizes the bad leaders who have hurt Israel, his vineyard. Like some wisdom literature, it first describes a confusing situation (Isaiah 5:1–2) and then explains its spiritual meaning (5:3–7). The theme of the vineyard's change appears again in Isaiah 27 and in Jesus's teachings (Matthew 21:33; Mark 12:1).

Isaiah 5:1–30

The prophet delivered judgment through a song (Isaiah 5:1–7) and prophecies of sorrow (5:8–30). Although Israel's future will be pure and in fellowship with God (Isaiah 4:2–6), it must address the current sinful state of the people and their leaders.

Isaiah 5:2

The Lord cared for his vineyard like an expert farmer. He watched it closely, planting the best vines for sweet grapes. God expected much from Israel as his people (see Exodus 19:5–6), so their bitter grapes (their unrighteous deeds) were useless and disappointing (compare Galatians 5:22–23).

Isaiah 5:3–4

- Clearly, the Lord had kindly done everything possible for the vineyard. He was not responsible for the bitter grapes.
- I extort you to judge: Isaiah wanted the audience to condemn the vineyard before revealing that they were the vineyard themselves (Isaiah 5:7). This rhetorical tactic is similar to the one Nathan used to confront David (2 Samuel 12:1–5).

Isaiah 5:5–6

The Lord promised to turn his vineyard, Israel, into a desolate place because it was only fit for destruction. Later, Isaiah prophesied that Israel would transform from desolation to fruitful vitality (see Isaiah 55:13).

Isaiah 5:6

Sometimes, the lack of rain was seen as a divine judgment (Deuteronomy 28:23–24; Haggai 1:11; 2:16). This was particularly harmful to a society that relied heavily on farming.

Isaiah 5:7

- The identification of Israel as the vineyard is a surprise. It resolves the riddle of the passage.
- Here, a clever play on Hebrew words is used to accuse Israel. The Lord expected justice (Hebrew mishpat) but saw only oppression (mispakh) of the needy. Instead of righteousness (tsedaqah), there were cries of violence (tse'aqah) against the poor (see Isaiah 1:21–23). These similar-sounding words make the message memorable.

Isaiah 5:8–10

Woe: The first warning of judgment was against oppressive greed. People took properties, like houses and fields, illegally. The new owners were bullies who used every method to get richer at the expense of the poor (see 1 Kings 21:1–29; Amos 2:6–7).

Isaiah 5:8–23

This section contains six pronouncements of sorrow. They are six warnings of dreadful judgment (Isaiah 5:8, 11, 18, 20, 21, 22). These sorrows highlight some of the "sour grapes" produced by the vineyard of Israel (5:1–7).

Isaiah 5:10

As with drought (Isaiah 5:5–6), the reduction of crops was at times a divine judgment (see Haggai 1:6, 9; 2:16).

Isaiah 5:11–17

Woe: The second threat of judgment concerns indulgent lifestyles (lives centered on pleasure and excess). The language in this section shows a life of moral corruption. The people live for pleasure while ignoring justice and righteousness.

Isaiah 5:12

These people are self-indulgent and content. They do not think about the Lord. They are too busy enjoying their drunken parties to consider why things went wrong. They do not reflect on why God sent no rain or why they lost a battle.

Isaiah 5:13

- Israel and Judah would go into exile to Assyria in 722 BC and to Babylon in 586 BC.
- The people did not respond to the Lord because they did not truly know him (see Isaiah 1:3). They likely knew about him, but their behavior showed that they did not have a close relationship with him.

Isaiah 5:14

The grave (Hebrew Sheol) represented the place of the dead in ancient Near Eastern thinking (see Isaiah 14:9).

Isaiah 5:16

God's rule is always fair and right, and he will be honored for his justice. When he is honored, oppressors will face judgment (see Isaiah 1:21–23).

Isaiah 5:18

God's ropes were "cords of kindness, with ropes of love" for Israel (Hosea 11:4).

Isaiah 5:18–19

Woe: The third threat of judgment was against those who mocked and openly disrespected God's authority.

Isaiah 5:19

- The people challenged God to hurry and act. They wanted him to prove that he truly exists and rules the world.

The verb hurry translates two Hebrew verbs:
- maher ("be quick")
- khush ("be speedy")

These same words appear in the name Maher-shalal-hash-baz (Isaiah 8:1).

- God had revealed his plan to Isaiah. The people did not understand that God's purposes would turn against them. Instead of bringing the kind of help they expected, God's action would bring judgment.

Isaiah 5:20

- Woe: The fourth threat of judgment was against a lack of integrity.
- evil good ... darkness to light ... sweet with bitter: This distorted view of life corrupts God's holy order.

Isaiah 5:21

Woe: The fifth threat of judgment was about the folly (foolishness) of self-deception. Self-deception means lying to oneself. The people believed they were wise and clever. They trusted their own understanding instead of trusting the Lord.

Isaiah 5:22–24

Woe: The sixth threat of judgment was against the indulgent lifestyle of the wicked.

Isaiah 5:24

- The image of rotting roots reflects human transience (the short and fragile nature of human life; see Isaiah 11:1; 27:6; 37:31).
- To despise the Lord's word means to reject or ignore it. It means living without concern for obeying what God has said.

This attitude leads to folly (foolish living) and ruin (Proverbs 1:30; 5:12; 15:5).

Isaiah 5:25

mountains quake: This describes God's wrath against sinners. The prophets often express God's anger as the shaking of the earth's foundations (Isaiah 13:13; 23:11; 24:18–19; 29:6; 54:10). God's appearance in judgment or salvation through natural events is called a theophany (a visible display of God's presence). In these moments, God reveals himself through smoke, darkness, lightning, or earthquake (see Isaiah 6:1–4, 6; 13:13; Exodus 19:18–19; Psalm 18:7–15; Micah 1:3–4; Revelation 8:5; 16:17–18; 18:21–22).

Isaiah 5:26

- The signal was a banner raised on a long pole. It was often placed on a high hill so people could see it from far away (see also Isaiah 13:2; 18:3; 30:17).

In Isaiah, the phrase a banner for the distant nations appears many times. Sometimes it calls nations to join in battle, as in this passage. In other places, it calls them to share in salvation (Isaiah 11:10, 12; 49:22; 62:10).

- The distant nations here refer to the Assyrians and Babylonians. God used them as instruments (tools) of judgment. Assyria conquered Israel in 722 BC. Babylon destroyed Judah and Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Isaiah describes them as wild animals called in to trample the vineyard (Isaiah 5:1–7). They would fiercely

attack Israel and Judah until God's judgment was complete (Isaiah 5:27–30).

Isaiah 5:30

- that day: see study note on Isaiah 2:5–22.
- In Old Testament prophecy, darkness often represents God's alienation (separation), wrath, and judgment (see also Isaiah 8:22). By contrast, light stands for God's holy presence and blessing (see especially Isaiah 60:2, 19).

Isaiah 6:1

- When King Uzziah died, the Assyrians began to regain control in the ancient Near East. This started a period dominated by major world powers:
- Assyria,
- Babylonia,
- Persia,
- Greece, and
- Rome.
- I saw the Lord: The term Lord (Hebrew 'adonay) can refer to human rulers or to God. God is the ultimate King over all nations and rulers.
- on a throne: The apostle John also had a vision of God's heavenly throne (see Revelation 4:2; 7:10; 21:5).
- Isaiah says that the train (the flowing edge) of the Lord's robe filled the temple. If only the train of his robe filled the temple, this suggests how great and majestic the Lord himself must be. The robe is only a small part of what Isaiah sees. Yet even that part fills the sacred space.

Isaiah 6:1–13

Isaiah's great vision of the Lord as King on his throne was a turning point in his life. This vision shaped his work as a prophet.

Scholars understand the historical setting of this event in two main ways:

1. Some see Isaiah 6 as Isaiah's original call to ministry. This would mean Isaiah 1–5 and 7–12 belong to the time of King Ahaz. Ahaz began to rule after King Uzziah died(Isaiah 6:1).

If this is correct, Isaiah's call did not appear at the beginning of the book for literary reasons. Perhaps the author placed the call in chapter 6 to end chapters 1–5 and introduce chapters 7–12.
Isaiah's personal cleansing and commissioning show what the whole nation needed. The people also needed to turn back to God if they were to fulfill their calling to be God's light to the world.

1. Others believe that chapters 1–12 follow a chronological order (in the order events happened).

In this view, chapter 6 does not describe Isaiah's first call. Instead, it describes a recommissioning. This means God sent Isaiah again to serve in a new way.
This new stage of ministry took place during the time of Ahaz. During this period, people would reject Isaiah's message.
Supporters of this interpretation refer to Isaiah 2:7–9; 3:16–24; and 5:8–14. They argue that these sections describe a time of wealth, military strength, pride, and luxury. These conditions fit the reign of Uzziah but not the reign of Ahaz.

Isaiah 6:2

The mighty seraphim are heavenly beings not mentioned elsewhere in Scripture (though similar living creatures appear in Revelation 4:6–9; 15:8). The Hebrew term seraphim may be related to a word that means "to burn." This suggests an association with fire. Their name may point to their shining or fiery nature.

In Isaiah's vision, each seraph had six wings. With two wings they covered their faces. This showed reverence and humility. Even these powerful heavenly beings did not look directly at God's glory.

Isaiah 6:3

- The repeated use of the word holy shows that the Lord is completely set apart from all creation.
- all the earth is full: The Hebrew text does not include a verb in this line. Because of this, translators understand the seraphim's words in two possible ways.

1. The earth may already be filled with God's glory through creation, even though sin has damaged it.
2. The earth may be filled with the Lord's glory in the future, when he fully establishes his rule as King over the earth.

Both understandings point to the same truth. One day, the Lord's glorious presence will be known more fully on earth. This will happen even though humankind is sinful and wicked nations are powerful.

God also revealed His glory in a greater way through the incarnation, when the Son of God became human (John 12:41; 2 Corinthians 3:18; 4:4–7).

Isaiah 6:5

Woe is me, for I am ruined: The prophet felt unworthy of the vision. He was painfully aware of his personal uncleanness (unclean lips) when compared to the holiness of God. Isaiah knew that he was unworthy to speak the pure word of God, as were his people.

Isaiah 6:7

your iniquity is removed and your sin is atoned for: The prophet's experience of forgiveness anticipated Israel's need for national forgiveness and cleansing (Isaiah 43:25; 44:22; see study note on Isaiah 39:6–7).

Isaiah 6:8

- Who will go for Us?: The Lord spoke in the presence of his angels. The Bible sometimes describes this gathering as a heavenly council (a group of heavenly beings who stand before God; see also 1 Kings 22:19–22; Jeremiah 23:18, 22).
- Here am I: Isaiah answered quickly and willingly. God had just forgiven and cleansed him from sin. Because of this grace (God's undeserved kindness), Isaiah was ready to serve.

He committed himself to a lifetime of ministry (service for God).

Isaiah 6:9

never understanding … never perceiving: The prophet's words revealed the true feelings of his audience. The people were so deep in sin that hearing the truth pushed them further from God instead of closer (for example, Ahaz, Isaiah 7). Yet, the truth needed to be spoken.

Jesus also used this principle in his own preaching (Matthew 13:14–15; Luke 8:10; 19:42; John 12:40; see also Acts 28:26–27; Romans 11:8).

Isaiah 6:10

- Isaiah was God's messenger. Through his message, the wicked became more blind and deaf (they refused to see and hear the truth). But those who honored God gained spiritual sight and hearing (they understood and obeyed; see also Isaiah 29:9–10, 18; 35:5; 42:7, 16–19; 43:8; 56:10; 59:10).
- turn and be healed: The Lord was ready to heal those who truly repented, but not those who only wanted to avoid judgment while continuing their sinful ways.

Isaiah 6:11

How long … until … the land is desolate and ravaged: During the prophet's ministry (740 to 685 BC), wars, famines, and devastation plagued the nation.

Isaiah 6:13

- Even if a tenth, a remnant, survives, the judgment would continue until almost all are destroyed. Isaiah often spoke about near destruction or decimation (almost complete destruction; Isaiah 9:18–21; 10:20; 22:4; 48:19; 51:18). But Isaiah also kept hope alive. A remnant would survive and begin again (7:21–22; 29:23; 37:31; 44:26; 49:19; 54:1).
- the holy seed will be a stump in the land: The stump is like the base of a tree that remains after it is cut down. It represents a remnant of holy people (see Isaiah 4:2–3). From this small beginning, a new leader would come who pleased the Lord (11:1).

Isaiah 7:1

- Rezin was king of Syria. Damascus was Syria's capital city.
- Pekah was the king of Israel from 740 to 732 BC. He was a famous warrior (2 Chronicles 28:5–8).
- Pekah and Rezin began to attack Jerusalem while Jotham was king, from 750 to 732 BC. They increased their attacks during the early years of young King Ahaz (2 Kings 15:37; 16:5).

Isaiah 7:1–25

At one point in his reign, Ahaz faced a serious crisis. The kings of Syria and Israel attacked Judah. They planned to remove Ahaz and force Judah to join them in resisting Assyria.

Instead of trusting the Lord, Ahaz asked Assyria for help (2 Kings 16:7–10). By doing this, he rejected Isaiah's call to trust in God (Isaiah 7:12).

The Assyrians defeated Syria and Israel. In time, both nations fell. However, Assyria later turned against Judah and sought to control it completely.

Isaiah 7:1–12.6

These prophecies occurred when Assyria rose to power. Syria and Israel formed an alliance against Judah (Isaiah 7:1–2; see 2 Kings 16:5). God used Assyria as a tool to punish Syria, Israel, and Judah (Isaiah 7–10).

Isaiah 7:1–39.8

In this long section of the book, the nation of Israel was confronted with a vision of God, similar to how Isaiah was confronted in chapter 6.

Isaiah 7:2

hearts ... trembled: This means they were very afraid. In contrast, Ahaz's son, King Hezekiah, faced the Assyrians about 30 years later with strong faith. In 701 BC, he trusted the Lord when Assyria threatened Judah (see Isaiah 37:6–7, 14–20).

Isaiah 7:3

The aqueduct was a place where political negotiations took place later during Hezekiah's reign (see Isaiah 36:2).

Isaiah 7:4

- Do not be afraid: This was a "do not fear" prophecy, which appears often in Isaiah. In these messages, the Lord assures his people that he is with them and will carry out his plan.
- two smoldering stubs of firewood: This image shows that Rezin and Pekah were weak threats. If Ahaz had trusted God's view, he would have seen that they were about to disappear.

Isaiah 7:6

The son of Tabeel, otherwise unknown, was obviously sympathetic to Israel's and Syria's resistance against Assyria.

Isaiah 7:8

- The Assyrian kings Esarhaddon and Ashurbanipal had Israel resettled with people from other places within 65years (by 670 BC; see 2 Kings 17:24–34).
- Damascus was defeated and destroyed by 732 BC. Samaria was also defeated by 722 BC.

Isaiah 7:9

The last sentence is a play on two Hebrew words: If you do not stand firm (te'amenu) in your faith (ta'aminu), you will not stand at all. Firm trust in the Lord is essential, especially for a leader of God's people (see also 2 Chronicles 20:20). Leaders must act on their faith to show it exists.

Ahaz and the people of his time trusted Assyria, their enemy, instead of trusting God. They looked for help from a foreign power rather than from the Lord.

Later, King Hezekiah faced a similar threat. In that situation, he showed faith in the Lord (see Isaiah 36–38).

Isaiah 7:11

God would give Ahaz a sign to confirm his promise. This sign would take place before Ahaz's eyes. It would show that God's word was true.

Later, Ahaz's son Hezekiah also received a sign from the Lord (see Isaiah 37:30).

Isaiah 7:12

I will not test the LORD: Ahaz's answer sounded respectful and faithful (based on Deuteronomy 6:16. However, Ahaz was likely already speaking with the Assyrians. He had probably already decided to trust them for help in this war. His response sounded spiritual and proper, but his actions showed that he did not plan to trust the Lord.

Isaiah 7:14

- This prophecy was fully realized with the birth of Jesus Christ (Matthew 1:18–24). It is likely that it also partially came true in Isaiah's time, possibly with the birth of the godly King Hezekiah, son of Ahaz, or one of Isaiah's children. The similar verb sequence in Isaiah 7:14 and 8:3 (be with child ... give birth ... call) and the connection between Immanuel and Maher-shalal-hash-baz in 8:5–10 suggest they were the same person.
- The name Immanuel means "God with us." This name symbolized God's presence and protection. God was with Judah:
- during the attack by the alliance of Syria and Israel in 734 BC,
- during the Assyrian crisis in 701 BC, and
- throughout their existence until their fall in 586 BC.

The kingdom of Israel fell during Isaiah's lifetime, in 722 BC.

Even after that disaster, the promise "I am with you" remained important. God spoke these words to his people during the exile and after they returned home (Isaiah 41:10; 43:2, 5).

The fullest meaning of this promise appears in Jesus Christ, the incarnate Son of God. Incarnate means that God took on human flesh. Jesus is called Immanuel (Matthew 1:23; see also Revelation 12:5).

Isaiah 7:15–16

- By the time He knows enough: The crisis with the alliance of Syria and Israel against Judah occurred in 734 BC. By 732 BC, Damascus, the capital of Syria, was destroyed. Israel, the northern kingdom, was also defeated.

- to reject evil and choose good: This was to happen by age 12, when a child was considered an adult. In 722 BC, Israel went into exile.
- He will be eating curds and honey: The land would lose so many people that food would become easy to find. Even rich foods, once rare, would be available to everyone.

Isaiah 7:17

- Israel separated from Judah in 931 BC (see 1 Kings 12:19–20).
- He will bring the king of Assyria: Ahaz asked Assyria for help (2 Kings 16:8–9). However, Assyria later turned against him. Judah became a vassal state, which means it was forced to serve and pay tribute to Assyria.

Isaiah 7:18–25

The phrase on that day refers to the future Day of the LORD, when God acts to judge and to save.

Judah would first experience the judgment Isaiah had announced. This would be a warning of a greater judgment still to come. That greater judgment was the exile in Babylon from 586 to 538 BC.

Isaiah 7:19

Desolate valleys, caves, and thorny areas were often places where people hid in times of danger (see Isaiah 2:10). People who were afraid would run there for safety.

However, Judah's enemies would still find them. These hiding places would not protect them from judgment.

Isaiah 7:20

shave your head and the hair of your legs, and to remove your beard as well: In the ancient Near East, forced shaving was a disgraceful act (see 2 Samuel 10:4–5). Here, it served as a metaphor for the destruction of the country.

Isaiah 7:23–25

Farmers faced almost complete disaster. Fertile fields and lush vineyards would turn into wild grazing lands filled with useless plants like briers and thorns (see Isaiah 5:6).

Isaiah 8:1

The name Maher-shalal-hash-baz means "Swift to plunder and quick to carry away." This name applies to both Judah's enemies (Isaiah 8:4) and Judah itself (8:7–8). Judah trusted Assyria instead of God, and now Assyria would turn against them and nearly destroy them. God was with them (Immanuel; see Isaiah 7:14), but his presence would be harmful if they refused to trust him (see 8:14).

Isaiah 8:3

Like the name Immanuel (Isaiah 7:14), Maher-shalal-hash-baz is symbolic. This child might have partially fulfilled the Immanuel prophecy (see study note on Isaiah 7:14). The ultimate fulfillment of the Immanuel prophecy happened with the birth of Jesus (Matthew 1:22–23).

Isaiah 8:4

- before the boy knows how to cry: See also Isaiah 7:16.
- Damascus and Samaria were ruined and destroyed in 732 BC. This event fulfilled this verse along with Isaiah 7:8, 19–20.

Isaiah 8:5–10

This prophecy connects the sign of Maher-shalal-hash-baz with the sign of Immanuel (Isaiah 8:8, 10).

Isaiah 8:6

- The gently flowing waters of Shiloah provided Jerusalem with water. They symbolize God's loving presence and care (see Psalm 46:4).
- Ahaz rejected God's sign and promise of protection. He lacked faith (Isaiah 7:9). Now the people followed his example by hoping Assyria would save them from King Rezin and King Pekah (compare Isaiah 7:7–9, 16).

Isaiah 8:7

The mighty flood from the Euphrates River symbolizes the invading Assyrian army (see Jeremiah 47:2). The river would overflow its channels when the Assyrians advanced into Judah. This was a stark contrast to the gently flowing waters of Shiloah (Isaiah 8:6).

Isaiah 8:8

- up to the neck: Judah barely survived the Assyrian attacks in 701 BC (see Isaiah 36–37).
- its spreading streams will cover your entire land: From north to south, Judah was almost destroyed, except for Jerusalem (see Isaiah 1:8–9; chapters 36–37).
- Immanuel: Despite their lack of trust and the resulting disaster, God remained with his people (see Isaiah 7:14).

Isaiah 8:9–10

God's plan to save his stubborn people would eventually succeed. God intended to destroy Assyria, just as he does with any proud nation that rejects him or brags about its own power.

Isaiah 8:10

God is with us: See Isaiah 7:14 and 8:8.

Isaiah 8:11–15

This text reveals Isaiah's main message. The issue was fear of the Lord versus fear of people (see Isaiah 7:9; 8:6). When someone fears people, the Lord becomes a trap and destruction is certain (compare Proverbs 29:25; see "Fearing People" Theme Note). For those who fear the Lord, he becomes a sanctuary and their salvation is assured.

Isaiah 8:12

People saw Isaiah's message of staying out of Assyrian affairs as treason and part of a conspiracy. However, Isaiah was not engaging in political games. He was sharing God's message.

What scared them was the alliance of Syria and Israel attacking Judah (see Isaiah 7:1, 4).

Isaiah 8:13

you shall regard as holy: This means to give God first place in life and recognize that nothing is greater than he is.

He should be feared: This means honoring God with deep respect (Proverbs 1:7). The people of Judah were not to fear Israel and Syria or the Assyrians (Isaiah 7:9; 10:24).

Isaiah 8:14

- He will be a sanctuary: God is a place of refuge.
- stone ... stumbling ... rock ... offense: By trusting Assyria instead of God, the people of Jerusalem would fall into a trap as the Assyrians turned against them. However, for those who trust in the Lord, he is faithful and strong (Isaiah 28:16; see Psalm 118:22–23; Luke 2:34; Romans 9:32–33; 1 Peter 2:6–8).

Isaiah 8:16

law (Hebrew torah): The Torah described how Israel was to live in covenant with God. However, the people quickly forgot these instructions (see also Isaiah 1:10).

Isaiah 8:16–17

The command to preserve Isaiah's teaching suggests that many people did not accept his message. Some may have wanted to silence him and stop his words from spreading.

However, faithful disciples kept his messages safe. They protected and passed on the prophet's words to future generations.

Isaiah 8:17

- I will wait for the LORD ... I will put my trust in Him: Isaiah's message about Syria, Israel, and Assyria came true in later historical events. This fulfillment encouraged the faithful to wait for the end of all unjust power structures (see Isaiah 8:9–10).

Waiting for the Lord involves submission, prayer, hope, and faith (see Isaiah 25:9; 26:8; 33:2). This leads to a calm spirit and renewed inner strength (40:31).
The book of Hebrews connects these words to Jesus Christ (Hebrews 2:13).

- God had turned away. The people of Israel and Judah were separated from the Lord because of their sin.

Isaiah 8:18

Here am I, and the children the LORD has given me as (see the reference to Jesus Christ in Hebrews 2:13): The names of the prophet Isaiah and his children held important meanings as signs and warnings.

Shear-jashub (a remnant will return; Isaiah 7:3) symbolized God's faithfulness to Judah.

Maher-shalal-hash-baz (swift to plunder and quick to carry away) indicated the destruction of Damascus and Samaria (Isaiah 8:1–4) and the desolation of unfaithful Judah (8:5–8).

The name of Isaiah (Yahweh is salvation) itself signifies that salvation is from the Lord alone. These three names also represent major themes in the book:

- the remnant (the small group of people who remain faithful),
- the coming desolation of Judah (the land becoming empty and ruined), and
- salvation (God's rescue of his people).

Immanuel (God is with us) brings together all of these themes. It also shows that Judah would be protected if the people trusted in the Lord. God's presence with them was their true safety.

Isaiah 8:19–22

- Isaiah contrasted his message with the advice of ungodly people around him. His message brought light and truth. The message of spiritists led to darkness and death.
- Mediums tried to discover the future through divination (seeking hidden knowledge through rituals). Some claimed to speak with the dead (see Isaiah 19:3). However, God had forbidden these practices because they were empty and harmful (Isaiah 47:9; Deuteronomy 18:9–11).

Isaiah 8:20

God gave instructions and teachings through the law and through his prophets, such as Isaiah (see Isaiah 8:16).

Isaiah 9:1

- Zebulun and Naphtali were northern tribes in Israel (Judges 6:35). The Assyrian invaders, led by Tiglath-pileser III, humbled them in 734 and 732 BC. During the lifetime of Jesus, people connected this prophecy to his coming out from Galilee (Matthew 4:14–16).
- Galilee of the Gentiles was the area of Israel between the Sea of Galilee and the Mediterranean Sea. The surrounding Gentile nations heavily influenced it culturally, religiously, and politically.

Isaiah 9:1–7

After judgment and destruction, there would still be hope. God promised that the Messiah (God's chosen one) would come and rule.

In the Messiah's kingdom, darkness would end and great light would begin. This light would first appear in Galilee. Then it would spread to the whole nation of Israel and finally to the whole world.

The Messiah would defend those who suffer and are treated unfairly. He would bring an end to cruelty and injustice. He would rule with justice (what is right and fair) and righteousness (living in a right way before God). His kingdom would be a kingdom of peace, and it would last forever.

Isaiah 9:4

- The people experienced the rule of other nations as a yoke of slavery and a heavy burden. A yoke is a wooden bar placed on animals to control them. Here it describes harsh control and forced labor (Jeremiah 30:8).
- the rod of their oppressor: In Isaiah 10:5, the Assyrians are called "the rod of [the Lord's] anger." This means God used Assyria to punish his people. But God's anger would not last forever. When his anger ended, Assyria's cruel rule over Judah would also end (Isaiah 14:5).
- The Lord had destroyed the army of Midian through Gideon (see Judges 6:35; 7:22–25).

Isaiah 9:5

Burning the boots and uniforms marked the end of the need for instruments of war.

Isaiah 9:6

- unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: This child, the Messiah, would be David's descendant (Isaiah 11:1).
- He will be called: These titles describe the kind of king this child would be. They can be understood as four royal names that show the nature of his rule:

1. The Wonderful Counselor rules with God's wisdom (Isaiah 11:1; 25:1; 28:29; 40:13). His wisdom is different from the weak and foolish leaders of Judah (1:26; 3:3).
2. The Mighty God is an affirmation of the Messiah's divine nature. It shows that he shares in God's power and authority.
3. The Everlasting Father cares for his people like a father. His care never ends (compare Isaiah 22:21; 63:16).
4. The Prince of Peace is a ruler who brings peace, not war.

- Some scholars understand the titles as two longer names instead of four:

1. "A Wonderful Counselor [is] the Mighty God"; and
2. "the Everlasting Father [is] a Prince of Peace" (on his nature, see Isaiah 11:1–9).

- The New Testament identifies Jesus Christ as this promised Son of David (Matthew 1:1; Luke 1:32; see also Isaiah 7:14; 8:3, 18). He will establish his kingdom of peace (Revelation 19).

Isaiah 9:7

This ruler, like Ahaz, will be a descendant of David. However, unlike Ahaz and the rulers of Jerusalem (Isaiah 1:21–23), he will trust God and rule with justice and righteousness (11:1–3). Jesus the Messiah reigns forever (Luke 1:32–33).

Isaiah 9:8–12

This prophecy of judgment was against the northern kingdom of Israel. Even though God warned that the Assyrians would defeat them (Isaiah 7–8), the people of Samaria were foolishly confident they could survive the siege.

Isaiah 9:10

Israel believed they could replace what they lost with more costly items (see Isaiah 2:13–16; Amos 5:11).

Isaiah 9:11

Rezin's enemies were the Assyrians (Isaiah 7:4, 17; 8:4). Rezin was the king of Syria (see Isaiah 7).

Isaiah 9:13–17

God used punishment to call his people to repentance. Repentance means turning away from sin and turning back to God. His goal was not to destroy Israel, but to correct them and bring them back to himself.

However, Israel had become apostate. This means they had turned away from the Lord and rejected him. They refused to repent or to seek the Lord.

Isaiah 9:17

Widows and orphans are usually special objects of God's compassion and care (Isaiah 1:17, 23; 10:2). However, when they remained unrepentant, they also faced God's wrath. This means they experienced his judgment. God's judgment was not based on social position, but on whether people turned back to him.

Isaiah 9:18–21

After the leaders were destroyed, the nation would fall into chaos. With no strong leadership, people would turn against one another.

Civil war would then destroy the nation. It would spread quickly and cause great damage, like a brushfire that no one can control.

Isaiah 9:21

Manasseh and Ephraim represent the northern kingdom because they were its largest tribes. These tribes stood for the whole kingdom of Israel.

The two largest tribes of Israel and Judah fought against each other. This likely refers to the war between Judah and the alliance of Syria and Israel. This war is often called the Syro-Ephraimite War (Isaiah 7:1–12). During this conflict, people from the same family fought against one another. In other words, brothers fought against brothers (2 Chronicles 28). This civil war brought great suffering to God's people.

Isaiah 10:1

Woe: This introduces a threat of divine judgment.

Isaiah 10:1–4

This prophecy was spoken against the leaders of Judah. They used their positions of authority for personal gain.

Instead of serving the people, they made themselves rich. They did this at the people's expense. God spoke this message to confront their injustice and wrongdoing.

Isaiah 10:3

- Isaiah asked several questions, but he did not expect an answer. The implied answer was clear. When God punished Judah, there would be no one to help them.
- Disaster first came from the distant land of Assyria. Later, it came from Babylon. These nations became the instruments of God's judgment.

Isaiah 10:5

The Assyrians were God's instrument in judging Syria, Israel, and Judah. The prophet describes them as a rod and a club. These are tools used to strike or discipline someone.

God used Assyria to punish these nations. However, Assyria acted with pride and cruelty. Because of their own wickedness, they would not escape judgment.

Isaiah 10:5–19

God announced judgment on Assyria for several reasons:

- They destroyed other nations without mercy (Isaiah 10:7).
- They spoke with pride and dishonored God. They boasted about their own power (Isaiah 10:12).
- They oppressed other peoples and took what did not belong to them (Isaiah 10:13–14).
- They believed they were acting on their own. They did not recognize that God was using them (Isaiah 10:15).

Isaiah 10:5–11.16

Isaiah 9:8–10:4 shows that the Lord's moral law is supreme. This means God's standards of right and

wrong stand above every nation and ruler. The next section explains what this truth means:

1. Assyria was only a tool in God's hands. Because of this, Assyria was also responsible to God. Like every other nation, it would face judgment for its sin (Isaiah 10:5–19, 28–34).
2. Those among God's people who trusted in him and obeyed his covenant would be rescued (Isaiah 10:20–27).
3. God would establish his kingdom on earth (Isaiah 11).

Isaiah 10:6

- Judah had a special calling as God's covenant people. A covenant is a binding agreement between God and his people. However, Judah turned away from the Lord and became a godless nation.

Because of this, they became the object of God's anger (Isaiah 10:4). God's judgment came not because he broke his covenant, but because they did.

- The word plunder translates two Hebrew words, shalal and baz. Both words mean to take goods by force after victory in battle.

These words recall the name Maher-shalal-hash-baz (see Isaiah 5:19; 8:1, 3, 5–10).

Isaiah 10:7

The Assyrians did not understand that they were carrying out God's purpose. God used them to punish Israel and Judah.

However, the Assyrians acted on their own desires. They killed and looted other nations with cruelty. They did more than God intended.

Because of their pride and violence, God would hold them guilty. They would also face his judgment.

Isaiah 10:9

By 717 BC, Assyria controlled the regions north of Judah. These areas had fallen one by one.

Calno was a city in northern Syria. It is called Calneh in Amos 6:2. The Assyrian king Tiglath-pileser III captured it in 738 BC.

Carchemish stood on the Euphrates River. King Sargon II captured it in 717 BC.

Hamath was located on the Orontes River. Assyria brought it under control in 738 BC and again in 720 BC.

Arpad was a city south of Calno. Damascus and Samaria were the capital cities of Syria and Israel. Assyria captured Damascus in 732 BC and Samaria in 722 BC (Isaiah 7:8; 8:4).

Isaiah 10:10

whose images surpassed those of Jerusalem and Samaria: Assyria would make this argument while threatening Jerusalem (Isaiah 36:19–20; 37:12).

Isaiah 10:11

Assyria destroyed Samaria in 722 BC. This happened during the reigns of Shalmaneser V and Sargon II (2 Kings 17:3–6).

Samaria and Judah both worshiped the same God. Because Assyria had already defeated Samaria, the king of Assyria believed he could also defeat Judah.

Isaiah 10:12

Any royal power that exalts itself against the Lord is proud and arrogant. The Lord is the Great King over all rulers.

When kings lift themselves up against him, they set themselves in opposition to God. Such pride will not last.

God will humble and crush every ruler who stands against him (see Isaiah 2:11–12).

Isaiah 10:13

By the strength of my hand ... and by my wisdom (compare Isaiah 10:5): Only God is all-powerful and wise. He plans the future and decides which nations will rise to power and which will be defeated.

Isaiah 10:15

axe ... saw ... rod ... staff: These tools are only as effective as the person using them. Assyria thought it was independent of God's influence. However, their victories were possible only with his permission and to fulfill his purposes (Isaiah 10:5).

Isaiah 10:16

This prophecy was fulfilled in 701 BC. In that year, 185,000 Assyrian soldiers died.

They were struck down by a plague and by flaming fire. This event marked a sudden and dramatic defeat for Assyria (see Isaiah 37:36).

Isaiah 10:20

the survivors: This refers to a small group who remained alive. This group is called a remnant. A rem-

nant is a small number of people who survive after great destruction.

A remnant from Jerusalem barely survived. However, their safety was secure because God had promised to preserve them (see Isaiah 1:8–9; 4:2; 6:13; 37:31–32).

These wars taught the remnant an important lesson. They were not to depend on powerful nations such as Assyria for help.

Instead, they were to trust faithfully in the Lord alone (see Isaiah 8:13; 17:7).

Isaiah 10:20–27

In the middle of Assyrian oppression, there was still hope for the remnant. This passage explains more clearly the meaning of the name Shear-jashub. The name means "a remnant will return" (Isaiah 10:21; see 7:3; 8:18).

The promise showed that God would not destroy all his people. Some would return to him and live under his care.

Isaiah 10:22

- God had promised Abraham that his descendants would be as numerous as the sand on the seashore (Genesis 22:17).
- Destruction has been decreed, overflowing with righteousness: God's decision was right and just. It was a response to the people's continued and stubborn wickedness. God's judgment did not cancel his promise. He remained faithful, even while he punished sin.

Isaiah 10:24

as the Egyptians did: See Exodus 1:8–2:25.

Isaiah 10:24–34

God promised his people that he would be with them and had a plan for them.

Isaiah 10:26

He struck Midian: See Judges 7:25.

Isaiah 10:27

Israel's captivity ended in 539 BC. At that time, many of the people returned from exile. This return is sometimes described as a new exodus because God brought them out of a foreign land again.

Isaiah 10:28–34

Assyria has entered Aiath: Isaiah 10:29–32 describes the march of the Assyrian army in poetic language. The cities are listed in order from the north toward Jerusalem.

The army moves closer and closer to the city. When they reach Jerusalem, they are forced to stop and retreat.

God was with Jerusalem. Because of this, Assyria would not succeed. In time, Assyria itself would be destroyed.

This passage may refer to Sennacherib's invasion in 701 BC (see Isaiah 36–37). However, it could also describe an earlier or later invasion.

Isaiah 11:1

shoot ... stump ... Branch from his roots: This new growth represents the continuation of David's royal family line, even after it almost ended during the exile in Babylon (see also Isaiah 6:13; 39:7; Rev 22:16). This new growth from the old roots will not resemble the previous weak and unjust descendants of David (see Isaiah 4:2). Jesus, the Messiah (God's chosen one), is the final fulfillment.

Isaiah 11:1–16

The kingdom of the Messiah, first mentioned in Isaiah 9:1–7, is now explored in more detail. Isaiah questioned the Israelites about their trust in other nations when God had far better plans in mind.

Isaiah 11:2

- The Spirit of the Lord will rest on the Messiah. The Spirit ensures David's line continues. The Messiah's arrival will bring:
- justice and righteousness (Isaiah 11:4),
- peace (Isaiah 11:8), and
- the extension of God's kingdom to all nations (Isaiah 11:10; see also 32:15–16).
- The promised Messiah will have great wisdom and understanding, like King Solomon. He will also have knowledge and reverence for the Lord (1 Kings 3:28; 4:29; Proverbs 1:1–7; 2:6–7).
- The Spirit of counsel and strength refers to Isaiah 9:6. The Messiah will be wise and have the power to rule righteously.

Isaiah 11:3

the fear of the LORD: This means having deep respect and reverence for the Lord. It does not mean being afraid in a frightened way (see also Isaiah 11:2 and Proverbs 1:7).

Isaiah 11:4

- The poor and the exploited would receive the justice due to them, which the wicked leaders of Judah had previously withheld.
- the rod of his mouth: See Psalm 2:9; Revelation 19:15.

Isaiah 11:5

Because the Messiah is righteous in his character, his rule will show justice, righteousness, and truth. These qualities will mark his reign.

This will be very different from the condition of Jerusalem described in Isaiah 1:21. There, the city is described as unjust and unfaithful.

Isaiah 11:6

This prophecy was partly fulfilled during Isaiah's time or soon after. The complete fulfillment will occur when the Messiah (God's chosen one) arrives to begin and fully establish the age to come.

Isaiah 11:9

neither harm nor destroy: There will be no wrongdoers, corruption, or sin on God's holy mountain (Zion).

Isaiah 11:10

- the Root of Jesse: See Isaiah 11:1; Revelation 5:5; 22:16.
- The Messiah will bring salvation to the entire world (Isaiah 2:1–5). People from other nations will serve as priests and Levites (Isaiah 66:20–21), but only if they repent and believe in the true God.

Isaiah 11:11

- The first time the Lord reached out his hand was during the exodus. The second time will be in the future when the Messiah gathers non-Jewish people (Isaiah 11:10) and his own people living among them (11:11).

The exodus remained a symbol of hope for those in exile (see Isaiah 11:16; 35:8; 40:3; 43:19–20; 48:21).

- The remnant of his people included Israelites who survived the Assyrian and Babylonian invasions and were exiled.

Isaiah 11:13

jealousy of Ephraim ... and ... Judah: The two kingdoms became enemies during Judah's war with the alliance of Syria and Israel (see Isaiah 7:1–12). In the future, they would work together in military missions.

Isaiah 11:14

- the Philistines to the west: The Philistines were Israel's historic enemy.
- The nations to the east included the Edomites, Moabites, and Ammonites. All these enemies would be defeated.

Isaiah 11:15–16

Isaiah used images from Israel's past exodus to encourage his listeners. He promised that God would lead his people out of Assyria just as he led them out of Egypt (Exodus 14:29–15:18; see also Revelation 16:12).

Isaiah 12:1

God's comfort is the main topic of Isaiah 40–66.

Isaiah 12:1–6

The prophet's personal song of praise for God's salvation concludes the reflections on trust in Isaiah 7–12. God will show he is trustworthy in his promises to rescue his people, even though they initially refused to trust him. The song anticipates Isaiah 40–66 with its themes of:

- salvation,
- forgiveness,
- praise,
- joy, and
- the nations.

Isaiah 12:2

- God's promise to save includes:
- reconciliation (Isaiah 1:18),
- participation (Isaiah 11:10),
- cleansing and protection (Isaiah 4:3–6),
- peace and confidence (Isaiah 32:16–17), and
- restoration (Isaiah 11:6–9).
- LORD GOD (Hebrew Yah Yahweh): The first word (Yah) is a shorter form of the second (Yahweh).
- the LORD GOD is my strength and my song: See Exodus 15:2; Psalm 118:14.

Isaiah 12:3

God's salvation is like a deep, endless source of water that gives life (see also Isaiah 41:18; Psalm 87:7).

Isaiah 12:4–5

Make His works known among the peoples: The story of salvation should be shared with everyone, not just the people of Israel (Psalms 67:2; 70:4; 98:2).

Isaiah 12:6

See Psalm 48:1; Psalm 96:4; Psalm 99:2.

Isaiah 13:1

At the time of this prophecy, Assyria was the major power. Isaiah anticipated the rise of Babylon as an even crueler kingdom that would destroy Judah and Jerusalem (Isaiah 39:6–7; chapters 46–47).

The universal language in Isaiah 13:1–14:23 suggests that Babylon symbolizes all wicked and arrogant nations, similar to "Babylon the Great" in the book of Revelation (Revelation 18). So, while this description of Babylon's fall refers to the historic fall in 539 BC, it also applies to the final judgment against the ultimate kingdom of evil (Revelation 19).

Isaiah 13:1–23.18

This section contains prophecies of judgment against the nations. By including a prophecy against Judah and Jerusalem (Isaiah 22:1–25) in the midst of prophecies against the pagan nations, Isaiah emphasized that Israel's identity as God's people would not protect them from God's punishment when they sinned as the other nations do.

Isaiah 13:2

- A signal flag or banner, visible from far away, was often placed on a bare hilltop as a call to battle.
- God opposes Babylon as the symbolic representative of all evil kingdoms.

Isaiah 13:5

- Just as Assyria was a weapon of God's wrath (Isaiah 9:4; 10:5, 15), other nations act as the Lord's weapons and carry out his will. The Medes and Persians conquered Babylon in 539 BC.
- God's wrath shows his justice and his intent to restore order by destroying evildoers (Isaiah 10:25–26; see Lamentations 2:22; Ezekiel 7:19).

Isaiah 13:6

When pronouncing judgment that is still in the future, the prophets sometimes spoke as though it had already arrived. This emphasized the urgency of turning back to God (Ezekiel 30:3; Joel 1:15; 3:14; Obadiah 1:15; Zephaniah 1:7).

Isaiah 13:8

writhe like a woman in labor: The day of the Lord brings sudden and overpowering pain and fear for the wicked (see also Jeremiah 30:6; Hosea 13:13; Micah 4:9, 10; 5:3).

Isaiah 13:10

Cosmic upheaval and darkness are common images for the day of the Lord, a time of God's judgment (see also Ezekiel 32:7–8; Joel 2:10, 31; 3:15; Matthew 24:29; Mark 13:24; Revelation 6:12–13; 8:12; compare Isaiah 30:26).

Isaiah 13:11

punish the world: See Revelation 20:11.

Isaiah 13:12

Solomon's imported gold came from Ophir (1 Kings 9:28).

Isaiah 13:13

I will make the heavens tremble, and the earth will be shaken from its place: This language shows that God's judgment will be powerful and world-changing. (see study note on Isaiah 5:25; see also Haggai 2:7, 21; Hebrews 12:26–27; Revelation 16:17–18; 18:21–22).

Isaiah 13:16

These terrible acts of war would happen to Babylon. Babylon was a cruel conquering power (see also Psalm 137:8–9; Jeremiah 6:11–12; Nahum 3:10).

Isaiah 13:17

- The Lord is sovereign and controls history. He can influence kingdoms to carry out his will.
- The Medes from northwestern Iran joined Persian King Cyrus to fight against Babylon in 539 BC.

Isaiah 13:19–22

This image of Babylon as a forever haunted ruin contrasts with its greatness at its height (see Daniel 4:29–30).

Isaiah 13:20

She will never be inhabited ... from generation to generation: In Scripture, Babylon often represents idolatry (worship of false gods), immorality, imperial power, and oppression. It stands for human pride and rebellion against God.

One day, it will come to a complete end (see Revelation 18:2; 19:2).

Isaiah 14:1

- The Hebrew word translated as mercy uses the image of a mother's care for her child to show God's merciful love for his people (see also Isaiah 49:15; 66:13).
- God chose Israel as his special people when he called Abraham (see Isaiah 41:8; Genesis 12:1–3). Although their status did not change during the exile in Babylon, they faced God's anger like any other wicked nation because they rejected him.
- settle them in their own land: This promise began to be fulfilled in 538 BC (see Ezra 1:1–11).
- People from many nations would join Israel as the people of God (see also Isaiah 2:3–4; 11:11–12; 19:18–25; 60:1–14).

Isaiah 14:1–2

This message for Israel separates two prophecies of judgment against Babylon (Isaiah 13; 14:3–23).

Isaiah 14:2

- Just as Israel was subject to the Lord, the nations of the world would also submit to the Lord through Israel (Isaiah 45:14; 49:7, 23; 60:12, 14; 66:23).
- The oppressed nation of Israel will rule over its enemies and gain power and favor with God.

Isaiah 14:3

The LORD gives ... rest (repose; Isaiah 28:12; see Deuteronomy 25:19; 2 Samuel 7:11) from the sorrow, fear, slavery, and chains that Israel experienced under foreign oppressors (see Isaiah 9:4).

Isaiah 14:3–23

This taunting song about the king of Babylon is written like a funeral song. It speaks as if the king has already died.

The song mocks him and announces his downfall (compare Revelation 18).

Isaiah 14:4

A song of contempt is a mocking song. It makes fun of someone by comparing that person to something else.

In this case, the king of Babylon is compared to a dead man going down to the place of the dead. The song imagines him entering that realm in defeat.

Isaiah 14:7–8

- The land and people will be peaceful and calm because the oppression has ended and the king of Babylon has died.
- All of creation will join in praise, able to sing again (see also Isaiah 42:11; 44:23; compare Romans 8:22).

Isaiah 14:9

- The Babylonians viewed the place of the dead, called Sheol in Hebrew, as a place from which no one returns.
- rise from their thrones: The thrones represent the Babylonian belief that the afterlife continues like the present life. It seems the other kings are honoring Babylon's great king, but the following verses reveal a different story.

Isaiah 14:10

weak, as we are: The Babylonian king had no power over anyone after death and could not leave Sheol. The Israelites will mock this great king who seemed strong on earth but had no weaknesses.

Isaiah 14:11

- Babylon's strength, power, and music from the harp ended, and its greatness was destroyed (see also Revelation 18:22).
- Maggots and worms represented death and decay (Isaiah 66:24).

Isaiah 14:12

- fallen from heaven, O day star: These words refer to a well-known Canaanite story. In that story, the god Helel rebelled against the god El, who was the chief god of the Canaanite people. Helel was cast down from heaven.

Isaiah uses this image to describe the fall of the king of Babylon. Some interpret the fall of the king of Babylon as symbolizing the fall of Satan (see Ezekiel 28; Luke 10:18; Revelation 12:9). However, there is little evidence that Isaiah meant this directly. He was speaking about the historical king of Babylon.

- son of the dawn: This refers to the morning star, which appears briefly at dawn and then disappears

as the sun rises. In the Latin Vulgate, this term is translated Lucifer, which means "morning star." In later Christian tradition, Lucifer became a name for Satan. However, the Hebrew text here does not clearly refer to Satan.

Isaiah 14:13

This verse refers to a Canaanite belief about the gods. The Canaanites believed that their chief god, El, ruled from Mount Zaphon. This mountain was in the north (see Psalm 48:2; in the New Testament, similar language appears in Matthew 11:23; Luke 10:15).

Isaiah 14:14

Most High: See Genesis 14:19–22.

Isaiah 14:15–17

This is a restatement of 14:9–11. The spirits in the place of the dead will be surprised and amazed that the Babylonian king, who ruled the world with his merciless might, has absolutely no power in death.

Isaiah 14:18–20

The absence of a proper burial was a sign of great shame and dishonor. Unlike other kings, the king of Babylon would be disgraced in judgment.

Isaiah 14:21

As another sign of disgrace, the king of Babylon would have no children to continue his legacy. Because of their father's sins, God considers individuals in relation to their families and people. Here, the Babylonian king's children shared responsibility for their father's actions (see also Deuteronomy 5:9–10).

Isaiah 14:22–23

Isaiah summarized the earlier taunt (Isaiah 14:3–21) with this prophecy, spoken in the first person. God declares that Babylon will be destroyed and left in ruins.

Isaiah 14:24

I have planned ... I have purposed: No nation can stop or resist God's plans to judge Assyria or his plans overall. The prophets understood and shared God's plan so his people could respond properly.

Isaiah 14:24–27

This prophecy continues to declare judgment on Assyria (see Isaiah 10). Placing this prophecy after the judgment against Babylon suggests a close connection between Assyria and Babylon.

Isaiah 14:25

This prophecy told what would happen when Sennacherib attacked Hezekiah some years later in 701 BC (see Isaiah 36–37).

Isaiah 14:26

The Lord's power over Assyria is just one example of his sovereignty over the whole earth.

Isaiah 14:29

- The king who attacked Philistia was probably Ahaz (Isaiah 14:28).
- a viper: This probably refers to one of the later Assyrian kings, either Sennacherib (701 BC), Esarhaddon (680 BC), or Ashurbanipal (668 BC).

Isaiah 14:31

The advancing army, probably Assyria, would stir up clouds of dust like smoke that were ominously visible in the north.

Isaiah 14:32

The LORD has founded Zion: God was fully willing and capable of defending Judah, and he did not want the kingdom to make alliances with nations such as the Philistines to protect themselves from the invading Assyrians.

Isaiah 15:1

- Moab was located east of the Dead Sea. It was an enemy of Judah.
- in a night!: The destruction would be quick and final.

Isaiah 15:1–16.14

This message of judgment and sorrow was about Moab's fall. The many references to Moabite places show that Isaiah knew Moab well.

Isaiah 15:2

In the ancient Near East, people shaved or cut off their beards to show deep sorrow (see Jeremiah 48:37).

Isaiah 15:4

- Heshbon was once the capital of Sihon (Numbers 21:23–26).
- Elealeh was near Heshbon.
- Jahaz was located between Heshbon and the Arnon River (see Jeremiah 48:34).

Isaiah 15:5

- My heart cries out over Moab: The prophet joined the mourning to show how much Moab suffered.
- Zoar was in the southeastern part of the Dead Sea (Genesis 14:2; 19:23).

Isaiah 15:6

- The exact location of the waters of Nimrim is unknown (see also Jeremiah 48:34).
- dried up ... withered ... the vegetation: For more on natural resources drying up as a form of judgment, see study note on Isaiah 24:4.

Isaiah 15:7–8

The exact locations of the Brook of the Willows, Eglaim, and Beer-elim are unknown.

Isaiah 15:9

- Dimon is a play on the Hebrew word for blood (dam).
- blood: Many people from Moab had already died, but their punishment had just started.

Isaiah 16:1

- Moab was famous for its sheep (see 2 Kings 3:4). The Moabites sent lambs as tribute to Judah, acknowledging Judah's control over Moab.
- Sela (the cliff), a mysterious and distant location, was likely where the Moabites fled through the desert.

Isaiah 16:1–4

Moab is making a request to Judah for asylum (protection in another country).

Isaiah 16:3–4

do not betray ... be a refuge: Moab's situation would become so desperate that they would ask for refuge in other countries.

Isaiah 16:4–5

- This prophecy of salvation spoke about the future of David's royal line. It promised hope for the dynasty of David.
- Acts of oppression and destruction would come to an end. This would happen when the hostility of Moab stopped (see 2 Kings 13:20).

Isaiah 16:5

God would establish one of David's descendants as king (see also Isaiah 9:7; 11:1–5, 10–12).

Isaiah 16:6

The Moabites were too proud, angry, and boastful to humble themselves before God.

Isaiah 16:6–11

The response to Moab's request for asylum (Isaiah 16:1–4).

Isaiah 16:8

- The vineyards at Sibmah were near the Moabite city of Heshbon.
- Moab was like a lush vine spreading far and wide, but Israel's beautiful vine reached the ends of the earth (Isaiah 27:6).
- The location of Jazer is unknown.

Isaiah 16:12

- The hilltops were sites for pagan shrines (see Isaiah 15:2).
- No one will be able to save them, including the idols the Moabites called on for protection (see Isaiah 40:18–19; 44:18–19).

Isaiah 16:14

- In three years, as a hired worker counts the years (see also Isaiah 21:16): A man who sold himself into servitude would calculate the remaining time down to the last day. This verse refers to unknown events.
- The glory of Moab will be ended, probably because of the Assyrian conquest of Moab (late 700s BC).
- those who are left will be few and feeble: Though reduced by war, the Moabites still existed during Nehemiah's time (Nehemiah 13:23).

Isaiah 17:1

Damascus, the leader of the alliance between Syria and Israel against Judah, fell when the Assyrian king Tiglath-pileser III invaded in 732 BC.

Isaiah 17:1–20.6

This section includes predictions of judgment against Damascus, Israel, Ethiopia, and Egypt. The scene shifts from the crisis in 734 BC (the alliance of Syria and Israel; see study note on Isaiah 7:1–25) to the Assyrian crisis in 701 BC (see Isaiah 36–37).

Isaiah 17:2

- The towns of Aroer were east of the Dead Sea (see 2 Kings 10:32–33).
- they will be left to the flocks: The city would serve no other purpose.

Isaiah 17:3

The strategic fortified towns of Israel were the pride of Israel, but they could not resist God's purposes.

Isaiah 17:4

- the splendor of Jacob will fade: God will judge all human pride.
- Israel, once strong, will become weak. The nation will waste away like a sick person.

Isaiah 17:4–11

The vision shifts from Damascus (Isaiah 17:1–3) to Israel's northern kingdom. Damascus and Israel were allies against Judah, but Assyria later destroyed both.

Isaiah 17:5

The Valley of Rephaim was a fertile area in Judah. However, it appeared barren after each harvest.

Isaiah 17:6

Although the God of Israel judged the wickedness of Israel, he was still its God.

Isaiah 17:7

- The people mentioned here are either Israelites or all of humanity.
- look ... turn their eyes: They will once more trust in the Lord.

Isaiah 17:8

Canaanites and then Israelites worshiped the fertility goddess Asherah in wooded areas or, in the absence of wooded areas, by using Asherah poles (see Isaiah 27:9; 65:3; Micah 5:14).

Isaiah 17:9

The Hivites and Amorites were part of the original people living in Canaan. The Israelites were to destroy them when they conquered the land (see Deuteronomy 20:17).

Isaiah 17:10

- The Israelites combined their faith in the Lord with Baal worship. They turned away from the Lord, who is the only God and will not share devotion with idols.
- The term Rock refers to the Lord's ability to provide refuge (see Isaiah 26:4; 30:29; Psalm 18:2, 46).

Isaiah 17:12

At times, the sea represents opposition to God (see Job 7:12; 26:12; Psalms 46:3; 93:3).

Isaiah 17:12–14

God was present with Judah during the crisis.

Isaiah 17:13

He rebukes them: The Lord rules over the nations, just as he rules over the sea (Psalm 65:7).

Isaiah 17:14

In the evening ... Before morning: Trouble may come at night, but it will not last long.

Even in frightening situations, Israel can trust the Lord. He is able to rescue his people quickly (see Isaiah 37:36–38).

Isaiah 18:1

Ethiopia was located to the south of Egypt. It marked the southern border of Egypt's kingdom.

At that time, Egypt was ruled by an Ethiopian dynasty (a family line of kings). One of its rulers was Piankhi, also known as Piye.

Isaiah 18:3

Both the banner and ram's horn were used to organize and send signals to armies during battles (see Judges 3:27; 6:34; 2 Samuel 2:28).

Isaiah 18:4

The Lord is untroubled by human activities. He watches quietly from his dwelling place and acts when he chooses (see Psalm 2:1–4).

Isaiah 18:5

the flower becomes a ripening grape: Ethiopia had made every effort to form alliances to protect itself against Assyria, but its alliance with Judah would not help.

Isaiah 18:7

Conquered or weaker nations often had to pay tribute to a dominant king in the region (see Isiah 16:1; 2 Kings 3:4–5). The Ethiopians brought gifts to honor the Lord for defeating the Assyrians (see also 2 Chronicles 32:23).

Isaiah 19:1

- Riding on a swift cloud shows God's control and power over creation (Psalm 104:3). He is coming to judge Judah's enemies (see Deuteronomy 33:26; Psalms 18:9–10; 68:4; 97:2–3).
- The idols of Egypt tremble because they are weak and powerless, unable to help (see Isaiah 40:18; 45:16; 46:1).

Isaiah 19:1–10

Egypt relied heavily on the Nile for food, fish, and industry. When the Lord struck the Nile, Egypt would face severe difficulties, and its gods would not be able to help.

Isaiah 19:1–20.6

See also Jeremiah 46; Ezekiel 29–32.

Isaiah 19:2

Egypt experienced many civil wars that damaged the country. The nation's fragile unity was falling apart.

Isaiah 19:3

People called upon idols, spirits, mediums, and those who consult the spirits of the dead to try to prevent destruction (see Isaiah 8:19–22; 47:12–13).

Isaiah 19:4

harsh master: In 671 BC, the Assyrian king Esarhaddon invaded Egypt and destroyed Memphis, the royal city. In 663 BC, Ashurbanipal attacked and destroyed Thebes (see Nahum 3:8–10).

Isaiah 19:5

The Nile River was essential for Egypt's survival. Any change in its flooding pattern impacted the entire country. In ancient Egypt, people saw the Nile as a god. However, the true God could easily dry it up.

Isaiah 19:9

The workers in flax ... and the weavers of fine linen will turn pale: The drought destroyed the flax crops. As a result, the linen industry could not continue.

Isaiah 19:11

- Zoan was the capital of Egypt, located in the Nile delta (see Numbers 13:22).
- princes ... wise counselors: The king relied on the strategies and advice of wise men (Isaiah 19:12; see Genesis 41:39–40).
- The officials of Zoan were famous for their wise ancestors, and Egypt often boasted about them.

Isaiah 19:11–15

The prophet mocked the leaders and wise men of Egypt, who could not prevent the disaster.

Isaiah 19:12

Where are your wise men now?: Compare 1 Corinthians 1:20.

Isaiah 19:13

Memphis was an ancient capital in Egypt located south of the Nile Delta. It was destroyed by Esarhaddon in 671 BC.

Isaiah 19:15

- There is nothing Egypt can do: No leader, idol, or human wisdom can stop God's judgment.
- The head and the tail represented all of Egypt's leaders, from the most important to the least important (see Isaiah 9:14–15).

Isaiah 19:16

The uplifted hand (literally waving the hand) was a threatening gesture.

Isaiah 19:18

- five cities in the land of Egypt: This likely means "a number of cities" (see also Isaiah 17:6; 30:17).
- Jews living in Egypt after Jerusalem's destruction spoke Hebrew, referred to here as the language of Canaan.
- Heliopolis was dedicated to Re, the sun god. When Judah resisted the Lord, Isaiah imagined the Egyptians following the Lord.

Isaiah 19:19

This altar or monument might refer to the temple built by Jews at Elephantine in Egypt around 500 BC. It could also refer to another Jewish place of worship or a memorial the Egyptians made to honor the Lord.

Isaiah 19:19–25

The new Egypt would receive a place in God's purposes together with Assyria and Israel.

Isaiah 19:20

- The altar (Isaiah 19:19) would be a sign and a witness of the Egyptians' religious connection with Israel (see 19:24–25).

- God answers the prayers of those who ask the Lord for help.
- The Lord is a savior; he would protect the Egyptians just as he protected Jerusalem from the Assyrians.

Isaiah 19:22

- strike Egypt: The Hebrew verb here is the same as the one used for the tenth plague (Exodus 12:13, 23, 27), reminding us of God's actions during the exodus.
- The Lord, who sends a plague, can also heal.
- He will hear their prayers and heal them: This expresses a covenantal relationship between the Lord and Egypt (see Isaiah 65:24).

Isaiah 19:23

- Traditionally, Egypt and Assyria were enemies of each other and of Israel. They were deeply involved in idol worship, but they would abandon their hostility and idols to worship the true God.
- In the rugged terrain of the ancient Near East, a highway allowed for safe and easy travel and trade (see Isaiah 11:16; 35:8; 40:3; 62:10).

Isaiah 19:24

Israel will be a blessing, fulfilling God's promise to Abraham (Genesis 12:3).

Isaiah 19:25

Two titles usually meant for Israel, My people and My handiwork (see Isaiah 29:22; 32:18), are used here for foreign nations. The Lord promised to consider those from other nations who turn to him as his special possession (Isaiah 63:17).

Isaiah 20:1

- Sargon of Assyria is Sargon II, who ruled from 721 to 705 BC.
- Ashdod was one of the five Philistine cities that rebelled against Assyria in 713 BC.

Isaiah 20:1–5

Ashdod's reliance on Egypt and Ethiopia was useless. As a complement to his words, Isaiah walked about exposed and barefoot, a symbolic action for what God would do.

Isaiah 20:2

- Prophets often wore sackcloth or other rough clothing to show mourning for the people's sins (see 2 Kings 1:8; Mark 1:6).
- naked: This means exposed in some way, possibly even completely nude.

Isaiah 20:3–4

This symbolic event happened about three years before Ashdod fell (see Isaiah 20:2). Through this event, Isaiah served as an example for the people (see Isaiah 8:18).

Isaiah 20:5–6

Philistia's downfall was a warning to the people of Judah, who also relied on Egypt and other alliances rather than on God.

Isaiah 21:1

- This is the burden against the Desert by the Sea: This description of Babylon might ironically suggest that the land was physically lush but spiritually empty.
- from the desert, from a land of terror: (compare Deuteronomy 8:15).

Isaiah 21:2

- A dire vision is declared to me: The prophet makes Babylon's experience personal, which strengthens his poetry. The concise language and repeated sounds, like The traitor still betrays (Hebrew habboged boged) and the destroyer still destroys (Hebrew hashoded shoded; also in Isaiah 33:1), add to this effect.
- The Elamites lived northeast of Babylon. They, along with the Medes, were major rivals of the Babylonians.
- I will put an end to all her groaning: Babylon caused suffering by attacking and enslaving many nations. The Elamites and Medes likely helped overthrow Babylon in 539 BC (Isaiah 21:9).

Isaiah 21:3

I am bewildered to hear, I am dismayed to see: Through his vision, Isaiah felt the fear of the Babylonian people (see also Daniel 8:27; 10:16–17).

Isaiah 21:7

The riders were messengers who reported what had taken place on the battlefield.

Isaiah 21:9

- fallen is Babylon!: Assyrian King Sennacherib destroyed Babylon in 689 BC. The final fall of Babylon occurred in 539 BC.

In Scripture, Babylon symbolizes all ungodly power structures, including nations and kingdoms that do not follow God and his word. The apostle John offered

hope with his prophecy that all Babylons will fall (Revelation 14:8; 18:2).
- All the images of her gods lie shattered on the ground!: False gods could not save the Babylonians (see Isaiah 46:1–2).

Isaiah 21:10

- O my people: The focus returned to the people of Judah.
- The Babylonians would oppress (thresh and winnow) Judah, but Babylon would also fall.
- I tell you what I have heard: The prophet faithfully reported what the Lord revealed to him.

Isaiah 21:11–12

- Seir: This refers to the mountainous region of Edom.
- Watchman, what is left of the night: Edom's suffering would last a long time. The Assyrians controlled the ancient Near East during the 700s and 600s BC.

Isaiah 21:11–17

These two prophecies are about Edom and Arabia, located between Babylon and Israel. These regions suffered under Assyrian control. Like Judah, they would not find peace under Babylon's harsh rule.

Isaiah 21:12

Morning is coming, but it will start another difficult time. The Babylonians are approaching, so night will soon return.

Isaiah 21:13

- Dedan was a tribe in Arabia (see Ezekiel 27:20; 38:13).
- Caravans (groups of traders traveling together) would hide in the deserts of Arabia to escape attack. The Assyrians and Babylonians often attacked and troubled the Arabian tribes (see Isaiah 21:1–10; Jeremiah 49:28–29).

Isaiah 21:13–17

Compare Jeremiah 49:28–33.

Isaiah 21:14

Tema was an oasis in Arabia on a main trade route from Babylon.

Isaiah 21:15

Assyrian weapons of war, such as the drawn sword and the bent bow, were highly advanced compared to the simple weapons used by desert peoples.

Isaiah 21:16

Kedar was a wealthy Arabian tribe with many possessions (see Isaiah 60:7; Ezekiel 27:21).

Isaiah 21:17

The remaining archers ... will be few: Compare Isaiah 10:22; 14:30; 16:14; 24:6, 13; 37:32.

Isaiah 22:1

This is the burden against the Valley of Vision: The meaning of the Hebrew phrase is unclear. If it refers to Jerusalem (see Isaiah 22:5), it is ironic. Jerusalem is on a hill, and people did not usually think visions came from a valley. Similarly, Jerusalem was proud of its supposed religious vision, but its people were spiritually blind (see Isaiah 6:10; 42:18).

Isaiah 22:1–4

The prophet scolds the people for celebrating the Assyrian retreat in 701 BC. They did not predict that the Babylonian army would later, in 586 BC, finish what the Assyrians could not: the destruction of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 22:1–25

This message addresses the Assyrian siege of Jerusalem in 701 BC (see Isaiah 36–37; 2 Kings 18:17–19:37). It may also refer to the people's preparation for the later Babylonian siege from 588 to 586 BC.

Isaiah 22:2

- The city celebrated with feasting and drinking (Isaiah 22:13; see 23:7; 32:13), likely because the Assyrians retreated. Now, a new threat approaches: the Babylonian siege in 586 BC.
- The people did not die in battle but from famine and disease. The siege cut them off from food and caused a sanitation and health crisis.

Isaiah 22:3

Leaders might try to flee, but they would not escape (see 2 Kings 25:4–6).

Isaiah 22:4

let me weep bitterly!: Isaiah grieved for the victims and the destruction of his people (see Isaiah 6:13).

Isaiah 22:5

The invading Babylonians broke Jerusalem's walls using battering rams (2 Kings 25:4).

Isaiah 22:5–8

The defeat of Judah would show what the future day of the Lord will be like (see study note on Isaiah 2:5–22). Jerusalem would have no power to save itself in that time of disaster.

Isaiah 22:6

- Elam: Elam was east of Babylon and later helped defeat Babylon (see Isaiah 21:2; also Jeremiah 49:34–39).
- The exact location of Kir is unknown (see also Amos 1:5).

Isaiah 22:7

Your choicest valleys: This refers to the Kidron and Hinnom valleys, which were located to the east and south of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 22:8

to the weapons: This large and impressive building stored weapons. It also stored valuable items (see Isaiah 39:2; 1 Kings 7:2–6).

Isaiah 22:8–11

The people of Jerusalem prepared for war. They counted their weapons, inspected the city walls, and made sure they had enough water.

However, they did not think about God's plans (see Isaiah 13:1–14:23). They focused on their own efforts instead of seeking the Lord.

King Hezekiah played an important role in these preparations. However, the verbs in this passage are plural. Isaiah was speaking to the people as a group, not only to Hezekiah. This is different from the way Isaiah addressed Hezekiah's father, Ahaz (Isaiah 7:1–4).

Isaiah 22:9

- the City of David: Calling Jerusalem the city of David brings to mind Israel's greatest king and God's blessing on him and the nation (see also Isaiah 60:14).
- You collected water from the lower pool: Hezekiah worked hard to ensure a steady water supply (see Isaiah 22:11; 2 Kings 20:20).

Isaiah 22:12–14

Judah's feasting and disobedience resulted in a prophecy of judgment.

Isaiah 22:14

this sin of yours will never be atoned for: The people of Judah kept adding sin to sin. Because of this, God would rightly judge and condemn them.

This warning looked ahead to the exile. The exile happened in 586 BC. However, Isaiah was already warning about it as early as 701 BC.

Isaiah 22:15

- Shebna's actions show that the people do not trust God to save Jerusalem from the Assyrian attack.
- A palace administrator had the top position in the royal court (see Isaiah 22:21–22).

Isaiah 22:15–25

Shebna and Eliakim were two royal officials in King Hezekiah's court (see 2 Kings 18:18; 19:2). Shebna believed the Assyrians would surely kill him. So he planned for a well-decorated burial place (Isaiah 22:16).

Although the rebuke of Shebna happened before Assyria's siege of Jerusalem in 701 BC (see Isaiah 22:19–21; 36:3), it relates well to the warnings in 22:1–13 about the later Babylonian siege.

Isaiah 22:16

Shebna was building an impressive tomb for himself. It was meant to be a monument. This large and costly burial place was designed to last for many generations.

Isaiah 22:18

- sling you into a wide land: Shebna would not find a resting place or have a memorial (compare Isaiah 14:11–20).
- your glorious chariots: In his high position, Shebna lived in luxury.

Isaiah 22:19–20

remove you from office: Shebna (Isaiah 22:15) was demoted to court secretary by the time of Jerusalem's siege. Eliakim (Isaiah 22:20) was the palace administrator (36:3). Eliakim was a true servant of the Lord.

Isaiah 22:21

A leader is like a father to the people when he truly cares for them and addresses their needs. In contrast, Shebna was concerned only for himself.

Isaiah 22:22

- The key to the house of David represents a high position of honor in the royal court (see also Revelation 3:7).
- What he opens… what he shuts: The highest-ranking officer has the sole authority to grant access to the king (compare Matthew 16:19).

Isaiah 22:25

the peg … will give way: Even righteous Eliakim could not save Judah or David's family line from God's judgment. The people of Judah would go into exile over a hundred years later (Isaiah 39:6–7).

Isaiah 23:1

- The ships of Tarshish traveled the sea between the Phoenician coast and the port of Tarshish in Spain (see Isaiah 2:16; 23:6).
- Word has reached them from the land of Cyprus: Cyprus was the last stop for sailors returning from Spain before their final journey to Tyre.

Isaiah 23:1–18

Tyre was a wealthy seaport northwest of Israel. The connection between Judah and Tyre dates back to the time of David and Solomon (1 Kings 5:8–9).

Tyre was near large forests and the Mediterranean Sea. It was a major trade center in the ancient Near East. Its ships were famous, and its colonies gave it great prestige and wealth.

The city faced repeated attacks by the Assyrians, Babylonians, and Macedonians, and Alexander the Great conquered it in 332 BC. Isaiah not only predicted Tyre's downfall but also warned those whose wealth and security lead to pride instead of reliance on God (see Isaiah 2:12–16; Matthew 11:21).

Isaiah 23:2

- Sidon was a Phoenician port located to the north of Tyre.
- Tyre's commercial network of traders was extensive.

Isaiah 23:3

- People harvested fish, crops, flax, and linen along the Nile (see Isaiah 19).
- Tyre was a global marketplace, similar to modern cities like New York, Hong Kong, or London.

Isaiah 23:4

- Part of the great port city of Tyre was on an island. The island city was a sea fortress, but it fell in 332 BC.
- I have not been in labor or given birth. I have not raised young men or brought up young women: This metaphor was a judgment on Tyre's colonial ports around the Mediterranean Sea. In the ancient world, reaching old age without children was considered a terrible fate (see Isaiah 49:21; 54:1).

Isaiah 23:5

Egypt relied on ships from Tyre to export its products (see Isaiah 23:3).

Isaiah 23:8

- The Lord had brought this disaster on Tyre (Isaiah 23:9).
- Through trade, Tyre gained wealth for itself and its partners. In this way, Tyre helped create kingdoms.

Isaiah 23:10

Cultivate your land like the Nile: This difficult phrase means either:

1. that the sailors returning from Tarshish were invited to loot the ruined Tyre; or
2. that the people of Tarshish had to return to farming to earn a living, since Tyre was destroyed and trading was no longer possible.

Isaiah 23:11

Phoenicia was the region north of Israel. Tyre and Sidon were its main cities.

Isaiah 23:13

The Assyrians, led by Sennacherib, stripped and looted Babylonia in 689 BC. Eventually, Babylonia rose to become a mighty empire again.

Isaiah 23:15–18

There was hope for the city of Tyre.

Isaiah 23:17

Metaphorically, Tyre was like a prostitute because it was willing to sell anything to anyone without concern (see Revelation 17:2; 18:3, 12–13).

Isaiah 23:18

- Although Tyre earned money through dishonest trade, the profits will go to the Lord instead of being wasted.
- The Lord's priests will receive good food and fine clothing. The idea of nations bringing their wealth to the Lord in Jerusalem is further explored in Isaiah 60:5–11; 61:6.

Isaiah 24:1

- lays waste the earth and leaves it in ruins: There is a play here on the Hebrew words baqaq (lays waste) and balaq (leaves it in ruins). The devastation will start with Judah and spread to the entire world (see 1 Peter 4:17).
- All the earth will face destruction, including its people and political systems.

Isaiah 24:1–23

Here, the judgments described in Isaiah 13–23 apply to all of creation.

Isaiah 24:1–27.13

This section is often called the Little Apocalypse. It is given this name because it has similarities to the book of Revelation.

In these chapters, Isaiah moves from his present time into a vision of the future. The language is broad and universal. Because of this, it is difficult to connect the events to one specific historical situation.

These chapters are not meant to provide a detailed timeline of future events. They are not a historical blueprint. Instead, Isaiah uses vivid images to describe a dramatic future world that is both similar to and different from the present.

The vision includes elements of both the old age and the new age. For example, the people of Zion are described as righteous (new), yet they still wait for their full redemption (old). This pattern fits with the New Testament teaching that the future age has already begun but has not yet fully arrived (2 Corinthians 4:4; Galatians 1:4).

Peter wrote that believers were already living in the last days (1 Peter 1:12; 2 Peter 3:3). At the same time, he said that the final day of the Lord is still future (2 Peter 3:10). These passages show that the present age and the future age overlap.

Isaiah 24:4

earth ... withers; the world languishes and fades: The prophets often used drought imagery to capture the attention of those who depend on the land (see also Jeremiah 23:10; Joel 1:12; Amos 1:2).

Isaiah 24:4–13

All humanity is guilty (Romans 3:23) and faces condemnation (see Isaiah 59:1–15). Judgment is like a failed grape harvest that stops drinking and feasting.

Isaiah 24:5

Isaiah likely referred to the everlasting covenant that God made with all humanity through Noah (Genesis 9:8–17). The prophet noticed a similarity between the wickedness of his time and that of the world before the flood.

Isaiah 24:6

Sin has such a strong impact that nothing on earth can fully make up for it. Our hope is in God. Through Christ, God has made peace with the world (Colossians 1:19–20).

Isaiah 24:7

People who once celebrated will now sigh and mourn. They depended on wine for their pleasure and joy.

When the wine is gone, their happiness is gone as well.

Isaiah 24:8

Tambourines and the sweet sounds of the harp represent happy times (see Isaiah 5:12; Revelation 18:22).

Isaiah 24:10

city of chaos: The normal problems of city life will grow much worse. Disorder will become chaotic and dangerous.

Because of this, people will hide inside their homes. They will lock their doors to stay safe.

Isaiah 24:11

There is no joy left in the land, not because of an official order, but because the people have no reason to celebrate.

Isaiah 24:13

- like a harvested olive tree: The remnant will include godly people from both Israel (see Isaiah 27:6) and other nations.

- The theme of the remnant is common in Isaiah (see "The Remnant" Theme Note; see also Isaiah 10:22; 14:30; 16:14; 24:6; 37:32).

Isaiah 24:14–16

Despite the cries and destruction, praise comes from everywhere. Even while feeling the pain of the old world's ruin, the faithful look forward with joy to the new world.

Isaiah 24:16

- I am wasting away: The prophets knew the emotional pain caused by their people's sins and its consequences (see Isaiah 15:5; 21:4; Jeremiah 15:10; Micah 1:8).
- Even though parts of the new world have begun to appear, the lies and evil ways of the old world still control people for a time.

Isaiah 24:18

- No one can avoid the day of the Lord (see study note on Isaiah 2:5–22).
- the windows of heaven are open: This image is similar to the great flood in Noah's time (see study note on Genesis 7:11–12).
- the foundations of the earth are shaken: An earthquake often marks a theophany, which is a physical sign of God's presence (see also Isaiah 6:4; 13:13; 19:1).

Isaiah 24:21

The phrase translated as host of heaven comes from the Hebrew tseba' hammarom, which means "armed army of the heavens." This phrase may refer to pagan gods that people believed were represented by the stars.

It may also refer to angels. Some scholars think it could even include demons (Revelation 12:4, 9). The judgment described here will reach every part of creation. It will affect both the earth and the heavens (Isaiah 13:13; 34:5; see Ephesians 6:11–12).

Isaiah 24:22

confined to a dungeon and punished: See also 2 Peter 2:4; Revelation 9:2, 11; 17:8.

Isaiah 25:1–5

Isaiah praises God for protecting those in need (see Isaiah 12:1–6).

Isaiah 25:1–12

The second part of the Little Apocalypse (see study note on Isaiah 24:1–27:13) describes praise for God's judgment (Isaiah 25:1–5, 11–12) and salvation (25:6–9).

Isaiah 25:3

Assyria and Egypt were strong and ruthless nations, but in the future, they will honor God instead of their own power.

Isaiah 25:6

On this mountain: This means the mountain of the Lord (see Isaiah 2:2; 24:23). This refers not to a geographical city but to Zion, the eternal city of God (see Isaiah 1:8, 27).

Isaiah 25:6–8

The banquet is a symbol of God's providing richly for all those who will receive his gracious invitation (Revelation 3:20–21; 19:9).

Isaiah 25:8

- He will swallow up death forever: Isaiah hoped in God's power over sin and its harmful effects. In the New Testament, Jesus Christ fulfills this promise (1 Corinthians 15:54).
- The Lord's presence will provide eternal comfort. He will wipe away all tears (see Revelation 21:4).

Isaiah 25:9–12

The new community of God's people will respond in joy and faith. When the enemy is defeated, God's people will be free forever.

Isaiah 25:10

- on this mountain: This refers to Mount Zion in Jerusalem.
- Moab (see Isaiah 15:1–16:14) represents the nations facing judgment, those who rely only on themselves (see Isaiah 34:5–17).
- as straw is trodden: The people would be helpless and dying in very shameful circumstances.

Isaiah 25:11

Isaiah used the image of a swimmer forcibly kept under water to illustrate that Moab's people are hopelessly doomed and their human pride will be conquered.

Isaiah 26:1

- The city refers to Zion, the eternal city of God, where the Lord is present to protect and bless his people (see Isaiah 1:8, 27; see also Psalm 46). Zion stands in direct contrast with the "fortified towns" of the nations (Isaiah 25:2; 26:5), which are helpless and reduced to "a heap of rubble."
- The walls of God's salvation protectively enclose his people. No one can harm them again.

Isaiah 26:1–6

The new community of God's people is likened to the citizens of a city, securely held together by the Lord. They are righteous, faithful, peaceful, and trusting.

Isaiah 26:1–21

This part of the Little Apocalypse (see study note on Isaiah 24:1–27:13) is a song of praise and a prayer for salvation.

Isaiah 26:2

Open access is given to all who, like God and his Messiah, are righteous and faithful. The citizens of true Zion are committed to the Lord.

Isaiah 26:3

A perfect peace, marked by harmony, quietness, and confidence, is a benefit of the new creation.

Isaiah 26:5

Proud and arrogant people often praise themselves (see Isaiah 2:11–12), but God humbles them.

Isaiah 26:6

Justice finally occurs when the needy walk all over the ruins of the city where the proud have perished.

Isaiah 26:7

God will do what is right for those who follow his path, even if they suffer a bit longer (see Proverbs 24:16). One day, they will find peace and honesty (see Proverbs 2:8–9; 15:19).

Isaiah 26:7–21

The godly pray for the end of oppression and the full establishment of God's kingdom. Isaiah encouraged the godly to persevere as they wait for their final vindication and the resurrection of the body.

Isaiah 26:8

- we wait for You (see Isaiah 26:3–4): Waiting means trusting in the Lord and hoping for his redemption.
- People demonstrate their commitment to God by obeying his laws; just saying it is not enough.

Isaiah 26:9

longs for You ... seeks You: Compare Psalm 63:1.

Isaiah 26:10

God has shown kindness to those who do wrong. Even though they deserve judgment (see also Romans 2:4; 2 Peter 3:9), he has been patient and forgiving and has blessed them. However, one day, time will run out.

Isaiah 26:11

- A raised fist shows anger and a threat of judgment (see also Isaiah 19:16).
- Fire was often an image for God's judgment.

Isaiah 26:15

This verse is a confident expression of thanks for God's blessings. In Isaiah's time, during King Hezekiah's prosperous reign, the borders of the nation of Israel were extended, and people gave glory to God for his great deeds.

Isaiah 26:16

While waiting for God's salvation (Isaiah 26:1), the faithful were in distress and longed for justice. They prayed under the weight of God's discipline. During Hezekiah's time, Judah was in distress when Sennacherib attacked and destroyed the entire nation except for Jerusalem.

Isaiah 26:17

The image of a pregnant woman in childbirth shows the nation's pain when Assyrian King Sennacherib attacked in 701 BC (see Isaiah 37:3).

Isaiah 26:18

Only God can give salvation and bring life (see Isaiah 59:9–15).

Isaiah 26:19

Your dead will live: There is hope for the remnant. Some hold the minimal interpretation that this means the people would be restored to the land after the exile in Babylon (see Ezekiel 37:11–12) or that the Lord would preserve Jerusalem (see Isaiah 29:4, 6–8).

More likely, it refers to the resurrection of the body from the grave (see Isaiah 25:7–8). The Old Testament says little about the resurrection, but this text anticipates more detailed discussion in the New Testament (see 1 Corinthians 15:12–58).

Isaiah 26:20

God will punish the wicked, so the faithful should go home and avoid trouble.

Isaiah 26:21

The wicked hold power now, but their oppressive rule will end on the day of the Lord's wrath. On that day, he will punish them for their sins.

Isaiah 27:1

Israel used the image of Leviathan to represent evil powers that oppose God. Leviathan's death symbolizes the end of evil, Satan, demons, and forces hostile to God (see Isaiah 51:9; Psalms 74:14; 104:7–9, 26; see also the serpent in Genesis 3; Revelation 12; 13; 16:13; 20:2, 10).

Isaiah 27:2–6

In the Song of the Fruitful Vineyard, the vineyard represents God's people (compare Isaiah 5:1–7).

Isaiah 27:3

- God calls himself the Lord of the covenant to assure his people that his words and actions are trustworthy (see Exodus 6:2–3). This phrase appears many times in Isaiah.
- keeper ... water ... guard: The Lord will give even greater care and protection to his ultimate vineyard than he did to Israel, his first vineyard (see Isaiah 5:1–2).

Isaiah 27:5

- God wants everyone to turn to him and trust him for help.
- God offers his people a chance to make peace with him.

Isaiah 27:6

- Jacob's descendants will grow, and the remaining people will increase (Isaiah 37:31; see also 5:24; 14:30; for application to the Messiah, see 11:1, 10).
- fill the whole world: This prophecy goes beyond Israel's return from exile to the second coming of the Lord Jesus. It includes all righteous children of God (Jews and non-Jews) who suffer but stay obedient while waiting for complete redemption (see Isaiah 26:18; John 15:1–8).

Isaiah 27:7

Even though Israel was God's chosen people, they faced punishment like other wicked nations. However, Israel was not entirely destroyed. A small remnant survived.

Isaiah 27:7–11

Isaiah reminded readers of the reasons for the exile and judgment:

- Israel's sinfulness,
- God's righteous judgment, and
- the absence of divine compassion.

Isaiah 27:8

- The Assyrians forced many people from the northern kingdom of Israel into exile when Samaria fell in 722 BC. The Babylonians exiled many from Judah between 605 and 586 BC.
- Storms from the east were famous for their destructive effects (see Job 27:21; 38:24; Jeremiah 4:11).

Isaiah 27:9

- God's justice requires him to punish sin to correct behavior and purify. The exile in Babylon happened to cleanse Israel's wickedness and remove all of Israel's sins (see Romans 11:27).
- This aimed to end all pagan worship in Israel, including the incense altars and the poles used for worshiping the goddess Asherah.

Isaiah 27:10

Places previously associated with human power and accomplishment would be ruined to the extent that animals would graze in them.

Isaiah 27:11

The people were living outside God's covenant care (his special promise relationship with them). They had turned away from him.

This was a foolish choice. They rejected the protection and blessing that came from belonging to God.

Isaiah 27:12

- God's withholding of mercy from Israel (Isaiah 27:11) will be temporary.
- from the flowing Euphrates to the Wadi of Egypt: God's remnant will return from Assyria and Egypt to

the land God promised to Abraham (Genesis 15:18; see 1 Kings 4:21).

Isaiah 27:13

The great ram's horn was blown to gather the people. Its loud sound called them together (see Matthew 24:31).

Isaiah 28:1

- The drunkards of Israel showed pride, spiritual laziness, and disrespect for God and his commands.
- Unlike Jerusalem, Samaria was in a fertile valley.

Isaiah 28:1–29

The glory of Samaria, capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, is here contrasted with the glory of the Lord. This section represents the first of the six woes (Woe to...).

Isaiah 28:1–33.24

This section is connected by a series of six threats of judgment or woes (compare Isaiah 5:8–23). After the initial address to Samaria in Isaiah 28:1–13, the rest of the section addresses Judah. This is mainly because Judah tends to trust Egypt to save them from Assyria (Isaiah 30:2).

Isaiah 28:2

- the Lord has one who is: The covenant God will act against his own people, whose behavior had effectively disqualified them as God's people (see Hosea 1:9).
- one who is strong and mighty: This refers to the Assyrians, who destroyed Samaria in 722 BC.

Isaiah 28:5–6

In the future, after God's judgment has purged his people, he will restore a righteous remnant, transforming the desires and character of his people. Samaria will no longer be the source of Israel's pride. Instead, they will glory in the Lord, their true crown.

Isaiah 28:7

- The priests and prophets led the people astray.
- Intoxicating beverages such as wine and alcohol were prohibited for priests while fulfilling their duties (Leviticus 10:9).

Isaiah 28:7–13

The focus shifts back to the unfortunate current situation in Israel (and Judah). The leaders and people will be trapped by their own plans.

Isaiah 28:9–10

The people had become resistant to God's message (1 Corinthians 14:21).

Isaiah 28:11

- God will communicate through situations like hardship, exile, and death to reach his stubborn people.
- foreign tongues: In the New Testament, Paul used this text to describe the spiritual gift of tongues as a sign of judgment for unbelievers (see 1 Corinthians 14:21–22).

Isaiah 28:12

If his people had listened, God's revelation would have led them to rest (see Isaiah 48:18–19). However, they did not listen because of their stubborn hearts (Isaiah 65:12).

Isaiah 28:13

line on line, line on line; a little here, a little there: The Hebrew text is hard to understand. The words might be intentional nonsense to illustrate the point that the people were so spiritually blind that God's clearest revelation was nonsense to them (see Isaiah 6:9–10).

Isaiah 28:14–22

After giving judgment on Samaria (Isaiah 28:1–13), Isaiah now judges Jerusalem. He accuses Judah's leaders of being as blind as those in Israel's northern kingdom.

Isaiah 28:15

- have made a covenant with death ... fashioned an agreement with Sheol: There are two possible interpretations:

1. The people had pledged themselves to the Canaanite god of death, Mot, for his supposed protection.
2. The prophet was sarcastic. The people believed their political and economic actions ensured their safety, but they had actually harmed themselves.

- lies ... and falsehood: The leaders did not see themselves as deceptive, but they were.

Isaiah 28:16

The Lord is the dependable cornerstone in Jerusalem, a valuable foundation stone of God's true city. There

would be real hope in Jerusalem if the leaders and people turned to Him. By trusting in God, they would be safe during the worst storm or earthquake (see Isaiah 8:14; Psalm 118:22; Matthew 7:24–27; 21:42; see the application to Jesus Christ, Romans 9:33; 10:11; 1 Corinthians 3:11; Ephesians 2:20; 1 Peter 2:4–7).

Isaiah 28:17

The Lord judges people based on their actions, which show if they have true faith (for justice and righteousness, see Isaiah 1:21–23).

Isaiah 28:20

the bed ... the blanket: The leaders were not ready for God's judgment.

Isaiah 28:21

- as at Mount Perazim: See 2 Samuel 5:20.
- God rescued Israel with a hailstorm at Gibeon (Joshua 10:10–12), but now he would oppose them.

Isaiah 28:23

Listen: he analogy that follows was written as a wisdom poem, with Isaiah calling on his audience to pay careful attention and to discern what is right.

Isaiah 28:24–29

A farmer knows that there are right and wrong ways to do things, but the leaders of Judah were not that intelligent.

Isaiah 28:27–28

The Lord uses different tools, such as a heavy sledge or a light stick, to achieve his goals. There are different levels of judgment.

Isaiah 28:28

it is not endlessly threshed: This process would end. After judgment would come redemption.

Isaiah 28:29

wonderful in counsel (see Isaiah 9:6): God's people should learn wisdom about God's ways, as the farmer has done.

Isaiah 29:1–2

Ariel was another name for Mount Zion (Isaiah 29:8). It likely means "altar of God."

Isaiah 29:1–8

During the Assyrian siege, the Lord would fight for Jerusalem. He would eventually make the Assyrians leave the city.

Isaiah 29:1–14

This is the second of the six woes (Woe ...).

Isaiah 29:3

The Lord himself would come against Jerusalem, surrounding and attacking it.

Isaiah 29:4

God aimed to destroy the sinful pride of Jerusalem's people. Their voices would rise as if from the grave. Through the Assyrians, God would humble his people, but he would not abandon them.

Isaiah 29:6

- you will be visited: God will rescue his people.
- thunder and earthquake ... tempest and consuming flame of fire: These events describe a theophany (a visible appearance of God; see study note on Isaiah 5:25).

Isaiah 29:7

The Assyrians suddenly ended the siege, as if in a dream or a vision in the night. God would save Judah and judge Assyria.

Isaiah 29:8

Like a hungry or thirsty person, the Assyrians could taste the victory over Jerusalem. Yet they never became victorious.

Isaiah 29:8–12

Jerusalem's blindness kept its people from understanding God's plan.

Here, blindness does not mean physical blindness. It means spiritual blindness. The people could see with their eyes, but they did not understand what God was doing.

Isaiah 29:10

- a spirit of deep sleep: God reinforced the people's foolishness as a judgment on them (compare Romans 1:24–32; 11:8). They could not see reality.
- People sometimes called prophets visionaries. Neither the people nor their prophets understood what God was doing (Isaiah 6:9–10).

Isaiah 29:13

- These people used religious language in their prayers and conversations (see Matthew 15:8; Mark 7:6–7), but they did not truly honor God.
- In their hearts, they were not committed to the Lord.
- In their worship, they followed human rules and regulations instead of God's word.

Isaiah 29:14

Human wisdom and intelligence will disappear (see 1 Corinthians 1:19). The prophet had already spoken about the failure of Egypt's wise men (Isaiah 19:11–12). Even Judah's wise men would make mistakes.

Isaiah 29:15

- Their plans might refer to the advice that royal counselors were giving Hezekiah, who at first attempted to free himself from Assyria by making alliances with Egypt (in 715 or 701 BC).
- The people secretly planned evil deeds, but God saw everything.

Isaiah 29:15–24

This threat of coming judgment is the third of the six woes (see study note on Isaiah 28:1–33:24). It begins with judgment but moves to a vision of creation being renewed and of the wicked coming to an end.

Isaiah 29:16

- potter ... clay: This picture shows that the Lord has full authority over his creation. A potter has the right to shape clay as he chooses. In the same way, God has the right to guide and rule his people.

Scripture does not forbid people from asking God honest and difficult questions. However, it does not allow people to resist or reject God's will (see Isaiah 10:15; 45:9; 64:8; Romans 9:20).

- He did not make me?: When people speak this way about God, they refuse to admit that God created them. They deny that God is closely involved in every part of their lives.

Isaiah 29:17

The forests of Lebanon usually picture rich and healthy growth (see Isaiah 2:13; 14:8). They are often a symbol of strength and beauty.

But here, the forests represent destruction and emptiness. Instead of life and growth, they show ruin and loss.

Isaiah 29:18

The people were deaf and blind in their hearts and spirits. This means they would not listen to God or understand his truth (see Isaiah 6:10; 42:18; 43:8).

Yet God promised that he would renew humanity and all creation. He would bring healing and new life (see Isaiah 35:1–5).

Isaiah 29:21

The false testimony that led to the oppression of the poor through trickery in the courts of Isaiah's era would end. Because of God's work in their hearts, the people would turn from their sinful behavior of the past.

Isaiah 29:22

- Abraham was the father of all Israel (see Genesis 12:1–3; see also Galatians 3:29).
- Saved from human mistreatment and God's judgment, the people would no longer feel ashamed. Their disgrace came from the failure of what they had trusted (see Psalm 71:1; 1 Peter 2:6).

Isaiah 29:22–24

The prophecy of woe, which began at 29:15, now ends with a prophecy of salvation.

Isaiah 30:1

The people of Judah did not follow God's guidance (compare Isaiah 11:2). They made alliances that God did not approve. The Assyrian attack on Jerusalem was overwhelming. By allying with Egypt, Judah's leaders showed they relied on human help instead of God. Fortunately, Hezekiah later changed his mind (see Isaiah 36–37).

Isaiah 30:1–5

This prophecy warned Judah not to rely on Egypt. It is the fourth of six woes (see study note on Isaiah 28:1–33:24).

Isaiah 30:1–33

After warning Judah of judgment due to their stubbornness and reliance on Egypt (Isaiah 30:1–17), God promised to show compassion to his people and defeat their enemies.

Isaiah 30:4

Zoan: See Isaiah 19:11. The location of Hanes is uncertain.

Isaiah 30:6

- Caravans traveled from Judah through the Negev and the Sinai Peninsula to Egypt. They avoided the main road along the coast because Assyria controlled it.

This desert region was dangerous. Lions and poisonous snakes lived there. The journey put people's lives at risk. Yet they were willing to face this danger to form an alliance that would not help them.

- they carry their wealth ... and their treasures: This may refer to money and valuable goods that Judah sent to Egypt. They likely sent these riches to pay for Egypt's protection and support.

Isaiah 30:6–7

This taunt was against those who were busy trying to please the Egyptians in order to get Egypt's military support.

Isaiah 30:7

Rahab Who Sits Still: In ancient mythology, Rahab was an enemy of the good gods and appeared as a fearsome creature, similar to a giant crocodile (see Isaiah 27:1; 51:9; Job 41:1–34). By calling Egypt futile, the prophet meant it would not help Judah.

Isaiah 30:8–11

God instructed the prophet to write down the vision for future generations. The present generation was rebellious. They chose false prophets' fantasies over God's word (see Isaiah 8:16–17).

Isaiah 30:11

Rid us: The people of Judah did not want to be confronted about sin or judgment.

Isaiah 30:12

The whole society accepted injustice and lies. People encouraged one another to believe things that were not true.

They believed that Egypt would protect them from Assyria, even though that was false. Because many people accepted this idea, it seemed normal and wise to trust Egypt.

It also became accepted to take land from the poor. Leaders treated this oppression as if it were legal and right.

Isaiah 30:12–17

Judgment would suddenly overtake the people of Judah because they were content with their fantasy world, and they refused God's path to rest and quietness.

Isaiah 30:15

- The people of Judah needed to turn away from their sinful ways (Isaiah 30:12–14) and return to the Lord to be saved.
- Trusting in the Lord would bring peace and confidence, unlike their desperate talks with Egypt.

Isaiah 30:16

Judah relied on Egypt for fast horses (see Psalm 33:17), rejecting God's help and risking its downfall.

Isaiah 30:17

- one ... five: This curse is the opposite of God's blessing for obedience (Leviticus 26:8; Deuteronomy 32:30).
- The Assyrians had taken control of most of the land of Judah. Only Jerusalem remained.

The city stood alone, like a single pole on top of a hill. It was isolated and surrounded by enemy territory.

Isaiah 30:18

- A faithful God will restore order to the world by punishing the wicked and saving his people from them (see Isaiah 1:27; Psalm 96:10–12).
- God blesses those who wait. Faithful people do not rush to solve their own problems. Instead, they rely on his power and goodness.

Isaiah 30:18–33

This prophecy of salvation gave promises of hope. It helped Israel look away from their present suffering.

Instead, it pointed them toward the glorious future that God had prepared for his people.

Isaiah 30:19

- This was likely a challenge and promise to Hezekiah during the Assyrian siege of Jerusalem (see Isaiah 36–37). If he trusted in God, his people would not weep anymore.
- The Lord cares for his people's needs. When they ask for something, he will surely respond.

Isaiah 30:20

adversity and the water of affliction: A city under enemy siege for a long time would eventually face starvation and disease. God did not intend for this disaster to destroy the people of Jerusalem. Instead, it was meant to teach them.

Isaiah 30:21

The people's own ears will hear and follow God's instructions (see Isaiah 6:9–10; 29:18; 35:5).

Isaiah 30:22

One aspect of Hezekiah's reforms was to remove silver idols and other idolatry of Ahaz's era and to call the people back to the worship of the God of Israel (2 Kings 18:4–5; 2 Chronicles 29).

Isaiah 30:23–24

The people of Judah would again enjoy covenant blessings rather than curses (see Leviticus 26:4).

Isaiah 30:26

The Lord who struck his people would also heal them and cure the wounds he gave them.

Isaiah 30:27–33

In this prophecy of judgment against the nations, Isaiah foretold that Assyria's power would be broken by God's strong arm, not by the Egyptians.

Isaiah 30:28

like a rushing torrent that rises to the neck: Assyria's destruction would be as devastating as their invasion of Judah (see Isaiah 8:8).

Isaiah 30:30

- His mighty arm: This phrase is a picture of great strength. It reminds readers of how God defeated the Egyptians during the exodus from Egypt (Isaiah 63:12; see Exodus 15:6).
- consuming fire ... hailstones: Fire and hail often appear when God shows himself in power. These signs are connected with a theophany (a visible appearance of God). They show that God is acting in judgment and authority (see study note on Isaiah 5:25).

Isaiah 30:31

scepter: The Lord, the true King, would be victorious over the threatening Assyrian king.

Isaiah 30:32

tambourines and lyres: Instruments once silenced in judgment (Isaiah 24:8) would be used again by God's people. This time, they would celebrate the Lord's goodness instead of becoming spiritually complacent (see Isaiah 5:12).

Isaiah 30:33

Topheth was a pagan altar in the Valley of Ben-hinnom, outside Jerusalem. At this place, some people burned their children as sacrifices to the Ammonite god Molech. This was part of false worship (2 Kings 23:9–10).

Isaiah 31:1

- Woe: This is the fifth of the six woes (see study note on Isaiah 28:1–33:24).
- seek the LORD: This suggests seeking God's guidance with a worshipful attitude (see Deuteronomy 4:29; Psalm 105:3–4).

Isaiah 31:1–3

Isaiah delivered another vision regarding Judah's negotiations with Egypt, which probably took place in 705–701 BC. During that time, the conquering Assyrians were on the move, threatening Judah. At first, Hezekiah tried political and military means to avert being totally conquered (see 2 Kings 18:13–16).

Isaiah 31:4–9

This prophecy concerned God's protection of Jerusalem and its rescue from the Assyrians.

Isaiah 31:9

- princes will panic: This happened when Sennacherib ran to Nineveh after God destroyed 185,000 troops (see Isaiah 37:36–37).
- God was the fire or flame that would consume Assyria.

Isaiah 32:1

- a king will reign in righteousness: This means the Messiah, God's chosen one (Isaiah 11:1). The focus is now on righteous and wise leadership (Proverbs 8:20).
- In Isaiah's time, honest leaders were rare (see Isaiah 3:1–6; 28:7–19).

Isaiah 32:2

like a shelter ... a refuge: These words also describe God's protection (Isaiah 25:4) and his gift of life-giving

water (41:18; 43:19–20). The leaders would act as God's agents to bless his people.

Isaiah 32:5

Only foolish people value fools and scoundrels as heroes (see also Isaiah 19:11, 13; 32:6–8).

Isaiah 32:6

Fools ignore God's standards of justice and righteousness. They do not care about people who are hungry or thirsty (see Isaiah 1:17; 58:7, 10).

Isaiah 32:7

weapons ... plots: See Proverbs 6:12, 18; 16:27; 24:8–9.

Isaiah 32:9

The women of Jerusalem live comfortably. They rely on wealth and status to keep their lifestyle, despite having low morals.

Isaiah 32:9–15

This prophecy warned the complacent women of Jerusalem. God's promises for the future did not excuse ongoing sin.

Isaiah 32:10

In a little more than a year: This refers to events that were about to happen soon.

At that time, the Assyrian Empire was preparing to attack Jerusalem. The siege of Jerusalem in 701 BC was approaching.

Isaiah 32:11

People wore sackcloth to show grief, especially during mourning (see Psalm 30:11). The Assyrian conquest of Judah's farmlands and most cities, except Jerusalem, would cause wealthy city dwellers to mourn.

Isaiah 32:14

The Babylonians, not the Assyrians, eventually destroyed Jerusalem (see Isaiah 39:1–8 for a prediction of this).

Isaiah 32:15

- The Spirit will change the nation into a godly community, starting a time of justice and righteousness (see also Joel 2:28–32). The Spirit is connected to the Messiah, God's chosen one (Isaiah 11:1) and the servant (42:1; 61:1).
- desert ... orchard: When the people are transformed, nature will be too.

Isaiah 32:17

Being right with God and people will bring peace (Hebrew shalom; see Isaiah 26:3; 48:18; 52:7; compare James 3:18). Peace is more than just the absence of conflict. It includes personal wholeness and does not rely on outside circumstances (see also Romans 5:1).

Isaiah 32:18

Living safely and feeling at peace were blessings of Israel's agreement with the Lord (see Leviticus 26:5–6). However, the people's sins had brought curses instead of blessings (compare Isaiah 32:9–11).

Isaiah 32:19

the forest, and the city: The faithful will stay safe, even when signs of God's judgment are everywhere.

Isaiah 33:1

- This was the sixth warning of woe (see study note on Isaiah 28:1–33:24).
- Although the Hebrew text does not specifically name Assyria as the object of the prophecy in this chapter, Isaiah likely referred to Assyria. They were the destroyer closest at the time the prophecy was written. The prophecy applies to anyone who tries to destroy God's people, including the Babylonians (see Isaiah 13–14).
- When you have finished betraying: Wicked nations often break political agreements when these deals no longer benefit them.

Isaiah 33:2

The faithful community prayed for God to be merciful in response to the promise of Isaiah 30:18.

Isaiah 33:9

Sharon, Bashan, and Carmel were all fertile areas. Their desolation represents the destruction Assyria had caused in Israel.

Isaiah 33:11

In most passages, the Assyrians reduced other nations to worthless dry grass and stubble (see Isaiah 17:13; 29:5; 40:24; 41:2). Here, ironically, they experience the same fate.

Isaiah 33:14

- The godless were people who lived without considering God and his laws.
- The image of a consuming fire comes from God's judgment of wrongdoers during the wilderness

journey (Exodus 24:17; Deuteronomy 4:24). God still expects people to worship him with respect and awe (Hebrews 12:29).

Isaiah 33:15

Living a righteous life shows that a person truly knows God (see Colossians 3:5–17; James 2:14–18; 1 Peter 1:14–16; 1 John 1:5–6).

Isaiah 33:17

- The king is the human representative (32:1) of the Great King, God himself (33:22).
- The land belonging to God's people would appear to be without borders because the foreign enemies had been judged (54:3).

Isaiah 33:17–24

This vision is about God's reign in Zion.

Isaiah 33:18

Assyrian officers brought great terror to Judah when the Assyrians defeated various cities around Jerusalem (2 Kings 18:13).

Isaiah 33:19

The strange, unknown language was the language spoken in Assyria and later in Babylon (see Isaiah 28:11).

Isaiah 33:24

- The people of Israel were the people of Zion (compare Isaiah 33:20).
- sick ... will be forgiven of iniquity: See Isaiah 43:25.

Isaiah 34:1–17

This prophecy of judgment was against the nations at the terrifying day of the Lord (see study note on Isaiah 2:5–22; see also Isaiah 63:1–6).

Isaiah 34:2

devote them to destruction: See Leviticus 27:28–29.

Isaiah 34:3

Leaving a dead body unburied was shameful.

Isaiah 34:4

The skies ... stars: See also Isaiah 13:10; Joel 2:30–31; Matthew 24:29; Mark 13:24–25; 2 Peter 3:10–13; Revelation 6:13–14.

Isaiah 34:5

Edom represents what all nations will experience, similar to how Moab was described in Isaiah 25.

Isaiah 34:6

Bozrah was a city in Edom, southeast of the Dead Sea.

Isaiah 34:8

- The Lord's revenge means God's just anger against his enemies and those who oppress his people on the day of the Lord.
- a year of recompense: There will be payback for Edom's wrongs against Judah (see also Psalm 137:7; Lamentations 4:21; Obadiah; Malachi 1:3–5). Edom, known for its betrayal, will meet its end.

Isaiah 34:9

Edom's judgment was similar to the judgment of Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:24; see also Jeremiah 49:17–18).

Isaiah 34:10

See also Revelation 14:11; 19:3.

Isaiah 34:11

The identification of some of these birds is uncertain, but they inhabited wild and deserted places and many were considered unclean (Deuteronomy 14:11–18).

Isaiah 34:11–14

Wild animals, nocturnal birds, and thorny plants with thistles and briars filled the land. These things made the place feel empty and frightening.

Isaiah 34:16

- Search and read the scroll of the LORD: Isaiah's prophecy showed that God's word is true.
- The power of the Spirit makes the Lord's plans happen, ensuring all prophecy is fulfilled as God promised.

Isaiah 35:1

God's land would become a barren wasteland, both spiritually and physically. However, God would transform the desert into a garden (see also Isaiah 32:15), bringing his people from exile to glory.

Isaiah 35:1–10

God will come to defend and change his people. They will no longer be deaf, blind, or lame (see Isaiah 6:10). Instead, they will be pure, holy, and saved.

Isaiah 35:2

- Lebanon … Carmel … Sharon: There will be a reversal of earlier judgments (see Isaiah 2:13; 10:34; 29:17; 33:9).
- glory … splendor of our God: See also Isaiah 2:3; 40:5.

Isaiah 35:3

Limp hands and feeble knees express discouragement and anxiety (see Hebrews 12:12).

Isaiah 35:4

- do not fear!: The Lord assures his people of his presence and purpose (see also Isaiah 7:4; 10:24; 40:9; 43:1; 44:2; 54:4).
- The main message of the good news is that God is coming to save his people (see also Isaiah 40:9; 52:7; 62:11). God's arrival brings spiritual change and rescue from enemies.

Isaiah 35:5

eyes … ears: There will be a transformation from spiritual blindness and deafness to understanding and knowing God (Isaiah 6:10; 29:18; 32:3; 42:7; see also Luke 7:22; Acts 26:18).

Isaiah 35:6

the lame … and the mute: This promise shows that God will remove all disabilities. He will bring healing and wholeness (see Matthew 11:5; 12:22; Mark 7:37; Acts 3:7–8).

Isaiah 35:8

- The image of the highway recalls Israel's crossing through the Red Sea (Isaiah 51:10).
- only those who walk: This means that only those who follow God will walk on his holy path. God's goal in salvation is for humans to share his character and act like him (see Ephesians 5:1–2; 1 Peter 2:21).

Isaiah 35:10

Zion: The prophecy goes beyond Israel's return from exile to the final establishment of God's kingdom on earth. This kingdom will be full of joy and happiness, with no sorrow or mourning (see also Isaiah 25:7; 51:11; Revelation 21:4).

Isaiah 36:1

King Sennacherib of Assyria ruled from 705 to 681 BC. Hezekiah, like many other kings under Assyrian control, declared his independence when Sennacherib became king during a difficult time. By 701 BC, Sennacherib was ready to punish Hezekiah. Sennacherib claimed he conquered 46 fortified cities and many villages, taking 200,146 captives. Hezekiah tried to appease Sennacherib (see 2 Kings 18:14–16), but it was too late.

Isaiah 36:1–39.8

Jerusalem's rescue from King Sennacherib of Assyria is a main event in Isaiah 1–39. The Lord promised to save his people. He would remain present with Jerusalem (see 7:14). He would also keep a remnant, a small group who would survive (see study note on Isaiah 10:20).

Much of the land became empty and the population greatly reduced. This happened because Judah made a foolish alliance with Assyria (chapters 7–8). Even so, the Lord did not allow total defeat. He preserved his people through Hezekiah, a faithful king.

Hezekiah faced the same kind of test that King Ahaz had faced. It was a test of trust in the Lord. In chapter 36, the Assyrian officer repeats the word trust as he challenges the people. But Hezekiah had learned from the earlier warnings in chapters 13–35. At least at first, he trusted God and passed the test.

This story also appears in 2 Kings 18:13–20:19.

Isaiah 36:2

- Lachish was a city overlooking the hills west of Jerusalem. It needed to be captured before attacking Jerusalem.
- The aqueduct that supplies water to the upper pool was on the north side of Jerusalem, not the Gihon Spring in the Kidron Valley.
- Isaiah met Ahaz on this road leading to the field where cloth is washed about 33 years earlier (see Isaiah 7:3). At that time, he urged Ahaz to trust God. However, Ahaz trusted Assyria instead, leading to this desperate situation. Now, the challenge to trust God came from mocking foreign voices (see Isaiah 28:11–13).

Isaiah 36:3

Eliakim eventually advanced in rank, while Shebna was demoted (see Isaiah 22:15–24).

Isaiah 36:4

The title great king is similar to the title emperor.

Isaiah 36:4–22

The Assyrian chief of staff tried to use intimidation to negotiate a peaceful settlement. In his first speech (Isaiah 36:4–10), he correctly argued that Egypt could

not rescue them but incorrectly accused Hezekiah of misplaced trust in the Lord.

Interestingly, the Assyrian did not view the contest as between the gods of Assyria and the Lord, but rather between Sennacherib (the great king) and the Lord.

Isaiah 36:5

In whom are you now trusting: Judah had asked Egypt to help them (see Isaiah 30:1–5).

Isaiah 36:6

- Such is Pharaoh king of Egypt to all who trust in him: Isaiah argued the same case, pointing to the Lord as the only reliable source of help (Isaiah 31:1–3, 7; 39:7).
- A kind of reed that breaks easily grows near the Nile (see Ezekiel 29:6–7).

Isaiah 36:7

- We trust in the LORD our God: Ironically, the Assyrian chief of staff knew about Isaiah's message and used it to his advantage (Isaiah 26:4; 36:15; 37:10).
- Hezekiah showed his dedication to the Lord by tearing down the pagan shrines and altars (2 Kings 18:4). However, the Assyrians mistakenly thought Hezekiah had angered God by doing this.

Isaiah 36:8

At this time, cavalry mounted on horses was the newest military technology. The Assyrian chief of staff was mocking the Judeans because he knew that Judah had no trained men who knew how to ride.

Isaiah 36:10

The LORD Himself said to me: It was common for a king to claim that a god approved of their actions when they destroyed other kingdoms. This matched Isaiah's prophecy in Isaiah 10:5–6.

Isaiah 36:11

Aramaic was the common language of the Assyrian Empire. The elite understood it, but the common people of Judah did not.

Isaiah 36:13–20

In the Assyrian chief of staff's second speech, he claimed that his nation's gods were more powerful than the God of Judah (compare Isaiah 10:9–10). The ability of God to rescue his people was in question. In the following events, the Lord surprised the Assyrian with his power (Isaiah 37:36–37).

Isaiah 36:14

Do not let Hezekiah deceive you: This public accusation against Hezekiah aimed to weaken the people's trust in him.

Isaiah 36:15

Hezekiah showed strong faith in the Lord, unlike Ahaz (Isaiah 7). Hezekiah's faith led to rescue, while Ahaz's lack of faith led to trouble (see Isaiah 7:9).

Isaiah 36:16–17

The Assyrian tried to lure the people of Jerusalem with supplies that the Lord promised to give to his obedient followers (see Isaiah 1:19; 37:30–35; Deuteronomy 8:7–9). It was a tempting offer, but it was fake. It hid the truth of the exile that would have come after (Isaiah 36:17).

Isaiah 36:19

The people of Hamath and Arpad were moved to Samaria, where they worshipped the gods of Sepharvaim (2 Kings 17:24). This argument made sense to an Assyrian. If the Assyrian gods defeated the gods of other nations and the God of the Israelites in Samaria, would they not also defeat the God of Judah?

Isaiah 37:1

- Hezekiah responded to the threats by seeking the Lord's favor.
- The king tore his clothes and wore sackcloth as a sign of mourning and prayer.

Isaiah 37:4

Perhaps ... God will hear the words of the Rabshakeh ... defy the living God: Hezekiah's hope was not based on Judah's or his own goodness, nor on the presence of the temple in Jerusalem. Instead, it was based on God responding to Assyria's disrespect.

Isaiah 37:5–7

God answered that he would deal with the Assyrians and rescue the remnant of his people from their distress (see Isaiah 63:9).

Isaiah 37:8

Libnah was a city on the Philistine plain near Lachish. Sennacherib was preparing to fight both Egypt and Jerusalem when he sent word to Hezekiah.

Isaiah 37:9

King Tirhakah of Ethiopia was then the ruler of Egypt.

Isaiah 37:12

- The argument was that Judah's god, like the gods of other nations already conquered by Assyria, would not be able to save Judah (see also Isaiah 36:18–20).
- Gozan, Haran, Rezeph, Eden, and Telassar were cities in Mesopotamia.

Isaiah 37:14–20

When Hezekiah received Sennacherib's boastful threat, he went back to the temple and prayed for help. His prayer was different from Ahaz's reaction to danger decades earlier (see Isaiah 7).

Isaiah 37:16

- God of Israel: Hezekiah did not believe Sennacherib's false claims that the Lord was powerless. In his prayer, Hezekiah recognized that the Lord, as the creator, is the God of all the earth's kingdoms. The Lord rules over all kingdoms.
- The mighty cherubim were in the temple on top of the ark of the covenant, which was God's throne in his temple (see study note on Leviticus 16:2; see also Psalms 80:1; 99:1).

Isaiah 37:20

You alone, O LORD, are God: Hezekiah cared about the Lord's reputation, which Sennacherib had insulted. Hezekiah understood that if the Lord defeated the Assyrians and their gods, His holy name would be honored worldwide (see Exodus 9:16; 14:4, 17–18; Joshua 2:9–11; 1 Samuel 4:7–8).

Isaiah 37:21

Because you have prayed: Prayer has great power. God heard Hezekiah's prayer and responded.

The Lord answered him with a message of hope.

Isaiah 37:22

The Virgin Daughter of Zion: Jerusalem is described as a young woman who taunts the Assyrian king (see also Isaiah 3:26).

Isaiah 37:23

Against whom: Sennacherib's speech was not so much an insult against Judah as it was against the Lord.

Isaiah 37:24

Isaiah seems to be familiar with the typical royal Assyrian boasts, including that they possessed the highest mountains. These words sound very much like those found in the annals of the Assyrian kings inscribed on the walls of their temples.

Isaiah 37:25

I have dug wells ... I have dried up all the streams of Egypt: Sennacherib's boasts show his attitude of independence. However, the Lord alone is sovereign over nature (Isaiah 42:15; 43:19; 44:27).

Isaiah 37:26

I planned ... that you should crush ... into piles of rubble: Assyria was God's agent of destruction, but the Assyrians did not understand they were just a tool in God's hand (see Isaiah 10), carrying out what God had planned long ago (Isaiah 14:24–27).

Isaiah 37:28

your raging against Me: Assyria was completely hostile to the Lord, which led to even greater condemnation for them.

Isaiah 37:29

My hook ... My bit: The Assyrians would be taken away like animals, just as they had done to many of their captives.

Isaiah 37:30

This year ... the second year ... the third year: Due to the Assyrian siege and its impact on farming, the people of Judah could not plant and harvest as usual. The promise that life would return to normal after the siege reassured them that God was with them and would provide for their daily needs. They needed to build their trust in God over three years, believing that God's word would come true (see Isaiah 30:15, 18).

The idea was that after escaping the Assyrians, it would be too late to plant in the current year. They would have to wait until the fall of the second year to plant again and would harvest their first crop in the spring and summer of the third year.

Isaiah 37:30–35

In this prophecy of salvation, Isaiah assured Hezekiah that Jerusalem would be spared and that the remnant was under God's protection.

The names of Isaiah and his sons anticipated God's rescue (see Isaiah 7:1–11:16). The book's record of God's presence and rescue provided assurance that the Lord would always have a remnant that he will protect and rescue.

Isaiah 37:32

The passionate commitment of God includes his energetic zeal to keep his promise, the best guarantee his people could ever have (see also Isaiah 9:7).

Isaiah 37:33

He will not enter ... arrow ... shield ... siege ramp: Despite their advanced military technology and great power, the Assyrians did not succeed against Jerusalem.

Isaiah 37:35

for the sake of My servant David: God had made a promise to David. He said that David's royal family would continue forever (see Isaiah 9:6–7; 2 Samuel 7:8–17).

Isaiah 37:36

- The angel of the Lord was a special heavenly messenger through whom God acted on earth. Often, he delivered important messages (see Genesis 16:7–14), but sometimes he brought judgment (see 2 Samuel 24:16).
- struck down 185,000 men: The Lord began to fulfill his repeated promises: rescue of Jerusalem and judgment of Assyria (see Isaiah 10:16, 33–34; 30:31; 31:8).

Isaiah 37:38

- One day: Sennacherib was likely killed in 681 BC, about twenty years after he left Jerusalem.
- Esarhaddon ruled Assyria from 680 to 669 BC. It is ironic that Sennacherib, who mocked the Lord, was killed by his sons in the temple of his own god.

Isaiah 38:1

In those days: This is a very general time statement. Hezekiah's illness and healing likely happened before Jerusalem's rescue (Isaiah 36–37), even though Isaiah mentions it afterward. Merodach-baladan's rule in Babylon (Isaiah 39:1) ended before Sennacherib's invasion in 701 BC. The text order suggests a link between these events (see Isaiah 38:6).

Isaiah 38:1–9

The story of Hezekiah's healing connects two events. It links the extension of Hezekiah's life with Jerusalem's rescue from the Assyrians.

These events happened before Jerusalem was saved. However, the book places them in this order because of their theme, not their time sequence. One main theme is the power of prayer (see Isaiah 37:14–20; 38:2–3). The Lord truly listens.

Hezekiah learned to trust God. His father, Ahaz, had refused to trust the Lord. Because Hezekiah trusted God, Judah and Jerusalem were spared complete destruction by the Assyrians.

Still, Hezekiah was not the promised Messiah, the Son of David (Isaiah 7:14; 9:1–7; 11:1–16; 16:5; 32:1; 33:17–22). He was a faithful king, but he was also human and would die. His failures and his sickness (chapters 38–39) prepare the reader for the coming of the true Messiah described in chapters 40–66.

Isaiah 38:3

I have walked before You faithfully: Hezekiah's heart (his inner attitude and will) was right with the Lord for most of his reign (2 Kings 18:1–5). However, Hezekiah showed weakness when he relied on Egypt and did not act faithfully (Isaiah 31:1–9).

Isaiah 38:5

the God of your father David: Hezekiah followed David's example with faithfulness (see Isaiah 37:35; 38:1–22).

Isaiah 38:6

I will deliver you ... I will defend this city: This promise refers to saving Jerusalem (Isaiah 36–37). It also helps us understand Hezekiah's illness and recovery. Just as Hezekiah gained 15 more years, Jerusalem also received a temporary relief (see Isaiah 39).

Isaiah 38:9–20

Hezekiah's poem includes both lament (Isaiah 38:9–14) and praise (38:15–20). The praise remains restrained until the final verse.

Isaiah 38:10

go through the gates of Sheol: This image comes from an ancient belief that people enter death through gates (see Isaiah 14:9). Old Testament believers did not understand the afterlife as the New Testament describes it. They saw it as a shadowy place where all the dead gathered, and where no one praised God (see Isaiah 38:18; Psalms 88:10; 115:17).

Isaiah 38:11

Hezekiah was very sad when he thought he might die. He believed that death would separate him from fellowship with God. He also feared losing time with his family and friends.

Isaiah 38:12

These images show how short human life is (compare 2 Corinthians 5:1). They remind us that life on earth does not last long.

Isaiah 38:15

I will walk slowly: Hezekiah might have once taken his life and health for granted. Now he understood that God could take these gifts away at any time.

Isaiah 38:16

God's restoration of Hezekiah's health also symbolized the restoration from exile that Judah would experience in the future.

Isaiah 38:21–22

Hezekiah received a sign from the Lord. This sign reminds us of another sign that the prophet had offered to Ahaz (Isaiah 7:11).

Ahaz and Hezekiah stand at the two ends of a long story in Judah's history. Ahaz represents the ungodly king. Hezekiah represents the godly king.

Ahaz brought disaster on his people through his choices. Hezekiah, in contrast, brought deliverance to his people. However, Isaiah 39 shows that even Hezekiah's story includes warning and future trouble.

Isaiah 38:22

Hezekiah could not visit the temple with an infection (see Leviticus 13). So, going to the temple means he is healthy again.

Isaiah 39:1

Merodach-baladan, the king of Babylon from 722 to 710 and 704 to 703 BC, planned to rebel against Assyria. He sought help from Hezekiah. His envoys visited after Hezekiah recovered from a serious illness but before Sennacherib's final attack in 701 BC.

Isaiah 39:1–8

Hezekiah was an example of godliness, prayer, and care for the people of Jerusalem. However, he disappointed the Lord by showing off his wealth and military power to the envoys from Babylon.

Isaiah 39:2

silver ... precious oils ... his entire armory: By showing these treasures, Hezekiah demonstrated to Babylon's envoys that he had the resources to be a valuable ally.

Isaiah 39:6–7

carried off to Babylon: This prophecy came before the prophecy about saving Jerusalem (Isaiah 37:35). Although this judgment and exile seem like a surprising end to Hezekiah's story, the exile of Israel and Judah was always a possibility (Isaiah 10:3–4, 20–23).

The Lord promised to protect Judah and Jerusalem from the Assyrians in 701 BC, but he warned Isaiah that worse would happen if they did not change. God showed his power and reliability by defeating the Assyrians, but the people did not change. The promises of Isaiah 2:1–5 and 4:2–6 would only come true through judgment (4:4).

Until the exile cleansed the nation's wrongdoings (Isaiah 6:5–7), their mission to other nations would not succeed.

Isaiah 40:1–31

This chapter introduces chapters 40–66. In this section, comfort means the result of God's merciful actions toward people in the future. It includes encouragement, strength, and acceptance.

God wants to rescue his people (Isaiah 40:1–11) and is fully capable of doing so (40:12–26). The exiles needed to trust God's promises and wait for their rescue (Isaiah 40:27–31; see also 30:15–18).

Isaiah 40:1–55.13

This section shares the good news of God's coming salvation. The Lord will support his people and judge His enemies. Salvation will occur through the arrival, suffering, and exaltation of the Lord's servant, the Messiah, Jesus Christ.

Isaiah 40:1–66.24

The rest of Isaiah offers a message of comfort and reveals God's character and his plans for Israel. As Isaiah 39:6–7 predicted, Judah would face judgment and exile after Isaiah's time. Throughout Isaiah 40–66, Isaiah prophesied as if the exile in Babylon had already occurred. Thus, the Babylonian exile is the context for understanding these chapters.

Isaiah 40:2

- Speak tenderly: The prophet's message was to encourage Jerusalem with the good news of God's forgiveness, reconciliation, and restoration.
- From the prophetic perspective, Israel's sad days are gone because the exile has ended.

- she has received from the hand of the LORD double for all her sins: Israel faced the full force of God's wrath (Isaiah 51:19–23; compare 61:7).

Isaiah 40:3

- A voice of one calling: In Malachi 3:1, this person (possibly the Elijah of Malachi 4:5) was God's messenger who prepared the way for God's coming. In the Gospels, people identified this announcer as John the Baptist (Matthew 3:3; Mark 1:3; Luke 3:4; John 1:23).
- Prepare the way ... make a straight highway: The announcer's message would speed up God's coming (see Isaiah 35:8). As God made a way for Israel through the Red Sea (Isaiah 43:16), a way would also be opened for the Lord (see 52:11–12).

Isaiah 40:3–5

There is now a shift from announcing the good news to expecting God's arrival. The good news (Isaiah 40:1–2) is based on God himself.

Isaiah described the Lord as coming on a highway through the desert (see Isaiah 35). However, the imagery is reversed here: In Isaiah 35, the people traveled to Zion, toward the Lord. Here, the Lord is coming toward his people (see also Isaiah 52:8, where both images are combined).

Isaiah 40:5

- The future display of God's glory would include Judah's return from exile but extend beyond that. The New Testament confirms that God's glory was revealed in Jesus Christ (John 1:14; Hebrews 1:3).
- the mouth of the LORD has spoken: The promised salvation and judgment will surely happen because the Lord, who keeps his promises, has declared it (see Isaiah 1:20; 58:14).

Isaiah 40:6

- Cry out: So that everyone can hear.
- People are not worthy of the revelation of God's glory because they are mortal.

Isaiah 40:6–8

All humans are mortal and temporary. In contrast, God continues with his plans and succeeds. Time does not stop him from doing what he wants (see Isaiah 14:24).

Isaiah 40:7

The breath of the LORD refers to God's spoken words of judgment (see Isaiah 4:4).

Isaiah 40:8

the word of our God stands forever: All of God's words, including his plans and the written word, will succeed. God might change human expectations, but everything will follow his wise plan (see Isaiah 14:24; 55:8–11; see also Matthew 25:34).

Isaiah 40:9

God is coming to save and restore human beings (see also Isaiah 35:4; Revelation 22:12).

Isaiah 40:9–11

God is the good news. He comes as a warrior to rescue his people with power, yet he also holds them gently like a shepherd.

Isaiah 40:10

- The Lord's rule is different from that of unjust and weak rulers, whom he will judge. His rule is compassionate, just, righteous, and powerful.
- His arm establishes His rule: God showed his power in events such as:
- the defeat of the Egyptians (Isaiah 63:12),
- the judgment of his enemies (Isaiah 30:30; 48:14; 51:9), and
- the rescue of his people (Isaiah 59:16).

Isaiah 40:11

Isaiah used the well-known biblical image of a shepherd to describe God's care for his people (see also Isaiah 49:10; Psalm 23:1; Jeremiah 3:15; 23:4; Ezekiel 34:11–17; Matthew 2:6; John 10:1–18).

Isaiah 40:12–13

These rhetorical questions suggest the answer, "No one!" God alone created everything. He will judge creation (Isaiah 24:17), and only he can and will restore it through his salvation.

Isaiah 40:12–17

In response to Israel's questions (spoken by the prophet), the Lord declared that he is the unmatched God, a wise and sovereign creator who governs the nations.

Isaiah 40:15

God rules over all nations and their power structures. Compared to God, they are almost nothing. This includes the Babylonian Empire, which was just a tool in God's hand.

Isaiah 40:16

People valued Lebanon for its plentiful wood and wildlife (see Isaiah 2:13–16; Psalm 104:16–17).

Isaiah 40:17

The nations, including their leaders (Isaiah 40:23), pagan structures (41:24, 29; 44:9–11), and all enemies of God's people (41:11–12), are worth nothing apart from God.

Isaiah 40:18

- To whom ... what image: Earlier in the book, Isaiah showed that idolatry is foolish and empty (Isaiah 16:12; 37:16–19). Isaiah 40–48, he gives a much longer argument against it.

An idol is an object that people make to represent a god or a religious idea. But these objects are made by human hands. Those who worship them do not see that they are only things people have made.
Idols have no power (Isaiah 41:7, 22–24; 48:14). They give people a false feeling of safety (Isaiah 42:17). They mislead people and cause deep disappointment (Isaiah 44:20; 42:17; 45:16, 20). They cannot save or protect anyone.
In fact, idols are so weak that they can fall over (Isaiah 40:20; 41:7). They compete with God's glory (Isaiah 42:8). They also lower human dignity, because people bow down to things they have made (44:9; see also 41:21–29).

- The Lord, the true God, is not like idols. No one can compare to him (see Isaiah 40:25; 46:5; Psalms 86:8; 89:6). He is completely unique and without equal.

Isaiah 40:20

an idol that will not topple: This is a sarcastic remark. It would be embarrassing if the idol could not even stand (see Isaiah 40:18; 41:7; 1 Samuel 5:4).

Isaiah 40:21

Idol worshipers do not recognize God or respond wisely to him. The faithful in Israel understand and see God's role in the story of redemption, which includes both exile and restoration (Isaiah 41:20).

Isaiah 40:22

- God rules as king over the entire earth (see Isaiah 6:1; Psalms 2:4; 80:1; 99:1; 102:12; 113:5). God is so vast and powerful that humans seem like grasshoppers in comparison.
- Believing in God as the creator of the heavens and earth opposes the common Babylonian and Egyptian belief that the sun, moon, and stars are gods.
- like a curtain...a tent: See also Psalm 104:2.

Isaiah 40:23

princes: God is not impressed by human power or fame. Human strength and reputation do not change who God is.

Isaiah 40:25

The Holy One is a shorter form of the Holy One of Israel. This is a common name for God in the book of Isaiah (see also Isaiah 10:17; 43:15; Psalm 22:3).

Isaiah 40:26

Lift up your eyes on high: Just as God told Abraham to look into the sky (Genesis 15:5), he also told Israel to look to the stars for encouragement (see also Isaiah 51:2–3). The cosmos shows God's great power and unmatched strength. The Strong One can strengthen the weak (Isaiah 40:27–31; see Psalm 147:5).

Isaiah 40:27

My way is hidden ... ignored by my God: The coming exile, a time when God's powerful presence and rescue would not be visible, would prompt questions (see also Isaiah 49:14; 54:7; Lamentations 5:20–22).

Isaiah 40:28

- know ... understood: Compare Isaiah 40:21.
- the everlasting God, the Creator of the ends of the earth: Creation shows God's power and wisdom. He is also the Creator of the future world, a place of righteousness, justice, and peace (Isaiah 45:8; 48:6–7; 65:17–18).
- He will not grow tired or weary: God does not have human limitations.

Isaiah 40:29

In this context, the weak are those who face persecution or oppression, like during the exile in Babylon. The Lord is their only help (see Isaiah 49:4–5; 50:4; Psalms 68:9; 119:28).

Isaiah 40:31

- wait upon the LORD: See Isaiah 33:2; 49:23; 51:5.
- like eagles: This strong image of rescue reminded readers of the exodus event from long ago (Exodus 19:4; Deuteronomy 32:10–12; see also Psalm 103:5).

Isaiah 41:1

- The nations gathering for a trial must listen quietly to God's arguments.
- Let them come forward and testify: Literally let them find new strength, which is a reference to Isaiah 40:31.
- God invited the nations to come and speak, challenging them to counter his case.

Isaiah 41:1–7

The Lord invited the nations to a trial to show that he alone is God. They could not defend themselves as he announced that a king from the east (Isaiah 41:2) would defeat Babylon, allowing Israel to return.

Isaiah 41:2

- The king from the east was Cyrus, the Persian king who conquered Babylon in 539 BC. He allowed the Jews to return to their land and rebuild Jerusalem in 538 BC (Ezra 1:1–4).

Isaiah's prophecies about Cyrus (Isaiah 44:28–45:13; 48:14–15) encouraged Israel to see the Lord as the ruler over all human history, including the actions of great kings.

- He hands nations over to him: As victorious as the conquering Cyrus was, he was still subject to the Lord.

Isaiah 41:4

- the generations from the beginning?: God rules over everything. From the very beginning, he has guided each stage of history according to his plan.
- In the book of Revelation, Jesus calls himself the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End (Revelation 1:8, 17; 2:8; 21:6; 22:13).
- I am He: The Lord alone is God (see also Isaiah 43:10, 13; 46:4; 48:12; Deuteronomy 32:39). Jesus used similar expressions for himself (see John 6:35; 8:12, 24; 9:5; 10:7, 9, 11, 14; 11:25; 14:6; 15:1, 5).

Isaiah 41:5–7

This taunt against idol worship responded to God's raising up Cyrus. The nations hoped their idols would protect them.

Isaiah 41:6

Be strong!: The nations put their hope in things that have no strength, objects made by human craftsmen.

Isaiah 41:8

- The servant, representing the nation of Israel, was God's chosen one, with a purpose based on God's plans.
- Abraham My friend: In Hebrew, this phrase could mean Abraham who loves me or Abraham whom I love. (See also James 2:23).

Isaiah 41:8–16

These two prophecies about salvation for God's servant Israel (Isaiah 41:8–13, 14–16) prepare for the first of the suffering servant songs (see study note on Isaiah 42:1–4).

Isaiah 41:9

- I have chosen you restates Isaiah 41:8 to emphasize God's commitment and faithfulness to the people of Israel, even though they had not been faithful to him.
- not rejected you: During the exile in Babylon, the people felt that God had rejected them (see Isaiah 49:21; 54:6). However, God had good plans for them.

Isaiah 41:10

- I am with you: God's promise of presence (see Isaiah 7:14) is central to the Bible. Because God is present, his people do not need to fear (see also Isaiah 43:1–2, 5).
- I am your God: The Lord uses covenant language to affirm that he is their God and they are his people (see also Jeremiah 7:23; 31:1, 33; Ezekiel 14:11; 36:28; 37:27; Zechariah 8:8).
- uphold you with My righteous right hand: The Lord uses language similar to the exodus (compare Exodus 15:6) to encourage Israel (see also Isaiah 41:13; 63:12).

Isaiah 41:14

- In exile, Israel was in a lowly state.
- God is the Redeemer. He works powerfully to rescue and restore people from sin and its consequences (for Israel, it was the exile; for an application to Jesus, see Luke 2:38; 21:28; Romans 3:24; 1 Corinthians 1:30; Galatians 4:5; Ephesians 1:1–14; Titus 2:14; Hebrews 9:12).

Isaiah 41:16

When the grain is thrown into the wind, the chaff is blown away. Likewise, Israel's enemies appeared to be strong but would easily be driven off.

Isaiah 41:18

rivers … fountains … a pool of water … springs: These pictures would have been very meaningful to people who lived by farming and raising animals. In an agrarian culture (a farming society), water meant life. Rivers, springs, and pools were signs of safety, blessing, and hope. These images also suggest that rescue from the exile in Babylon would be like a second exodus (compare Exodus 15:27; 17:6).

Isaiah 41:21

the King of Jacob: See Isaiah 6:5; 43:15; 44:6.

Isaiah 41:21–29

This trial scene develops the Lord's case against idolatry. Idols are nothing but a human creation, whereas God is the Creator of all things. Idols cannot speak, act, accomplish anything, or save their worshipers.

Isaiah 41:25

- I have raised up on: The God who planned the exile through Babylon also planned Israel's return from exile through Cyrus (see Isaiah 41:2; see also 13:17).
- Although Persia is to the east, travelers to Israel and Judah had to enter from the north due to rough terrain.
- He will march over rulers … treads the clay: Just as Babylon trampled Assyria, Persia would trample Babylon.

Isaiah 41:26

Idols and false gods could not predict the future.

Isaiah 41:27

The messenger with good news announced that God would come to save his people (see Isaiah 40:9).

Isaiah 42:1

- in whom My soul delights: God used similar words at the baptism of Jesus (Matthew 3:17).
- I will put My Spirit on Him: Any leader might be called a servant, but the Spirit's presence suggests a king from David's line or a prophet like Moses (see Numbers 11:17, 24–29).
- Establishing justice is a king's duty (see Isaiah 9:6–7; Psalm 72:1).
- This king's mission will extend beyond governing Judah to a greater mission for the nations.

Isaiah 42:1–4

The servant here is not the people of Israel (as in Isaiah 41:8–28 and elsewhere in chapters 41–48; see 49:5–6). Instead, the servant is a royal figure who accomplishes his mission with care for people, especially for those who are hurting. The passage is the first of four songs about this servant (Isaiah 42:1–4; 49:1–13; 50:4–11; 52:13–53:12). He brings in an era of universal justice. For the connection of the servant with Jesus Christ, see Matthew 12:18–21.

Isaiah 42:2

cry out or raise His voice: The royal servant will speak with calm confidence in his message and calling from God (see also Isaiah 11:1–5).

Isaiah 42:3

The royal servant will be gentle with the oppressed and discouraged (see Isaiah 3:15; 41:17).

Isaiah 42:4

the islands: The nations want justice and guidance on how to achieve it. The servant is like Moses, who received the law. However, the servant is greater because he brings justice to all nations, not just Israel.

Isaiah 42:6

- I will keep you … to be a covenant for the people: The people might refer to all the nations of the earth (see Isaiah 49:6).
- a light to the nations: See also Isaiah 51:4; Acts 13:47.

Isaiah 42:7

The servant will help the spiritually blind see (see Isaiah 6:10; 29:18) and free spiritual captives from sin. This is in addition to freeing those held captive during the exile in Babylon (see Isaiah 61:1 with Luke 4:18).

Isaiah 42:8–9

I am the LORD: God created the world and only God can make predictions come true. God alone deserves glory and praise.

Isaiah 42:10–11

- Different geographical regions show the extremes of where people live. The entire earth is invited to praise God for his promise to save humanity.
- Kedar and Sela were examples of desert locations (Isaiah 42:11; see also 16:1; 21:16–17).

Isaiah 42:13

- a mighty one ... a warrior: This theme comes from God's victory at the Red Sea during the exodus (Exodus 15:3).
- God will defeat all his enemies to save his people (Isaiah 51:9; 63:1–6; see also Psalms 54:7; 108:9; 112:8).

Isaiah 42:14

I have kept silent ... and restrained: Israel felt God's absence during the exile in Babylon, which happened due to their idol worship (Isaiah 57:11–13; 2 Kings 17:6–24). The faithful will pray for God's presence and renewed involvement in their lives (Isaiah 64:12), and the Lord will answer their prayers because he is committed to their redemption (62:1, 6).

Isaiah 42:18–20

The Israelites who ignored God's words and actions became spiritually blind and deaf (see Isaiah 6:9–10). They knew the truth from God's word and the prophets, but their closed minds refused to respond.

Isaiah 42:21

magnify His law and make it glorious: God's word is a witness to his righteous rule (see Isaiah 1:10).

Isaiah 42:22–25

Throughout its history, Israel's sins (Isaiah 42:24) made it vulnerable to foreign oppressors. Many nations, especially Assyria and Babylon, became tools God used to express his anger (Isaiah 42:25) toward his rebellious people.

Isaiah 42:25

Generation after generation of Israelites did not learn their lesson, even when God disciplined them through military defeat.

Isaiah 43:1

- the LORD ... who created you: The idea of creation (see study note on Isaiah 40:28) now refers to God forming the nation of Israel.
- He who formed you: During the exodus, God freed his people from slavery. Similarly, God planned to bring his people back from exile to their land. Ultimately, Jesus gave his life as a ransom for all humanity (Matthew 20:28; 1 Timothy 2:6; Hebrews 9:15).
- I have called you by your name; you are Mine!: Despite having faced his wrath, the people of Israel are still God's chosen people.

Isaiah 43:1–7

In this promise of salvation, the Lord spoke directly to his people.

Isaiah 43:2

- Conquering forces are compared to flooding rivers (see Isaiah 8:8).
- I will be with you: God promises to stay with his people to protect and care for them (see Isaiah 7:14; 41:10; 43:5; 45:14).
- Israel faced God's judgment as the fire of oppression during the exile in Babylon.

Isaiah 43:7

One of God's purposes in restoring his people was to display his glory to the watching world.

Isaiah 43:8–13

The Lord here called on Israel, his blind servant, to be his star witness in a mock trial against idols and false gods. Israel knew that the Lord alone is God, and the people had experienced his salvation.

Isaiah 43:10

You are My witnesses: By their very presence in exile, Israel was evidence that God is truly God. He predicted the exile long beforehand, and now it had come to pass. God alone is the true God because he speaks and acts and controls all of history. Idols and false gods could do none of these things. Israel would later become even greater evidence because God had also predicted their redemption (Isaiah 43:11–12).

Isaiah 43:14–21

The Lord promised Israel that it would be freed from Babylon. This redemption would be similar to Israel's past freedom from Egypt but even greater in some ways (Isaiah 43:18).

Isaiah 43:18

God wanted the Israelites to remember the exodus from Egypt. However, they needed to focus on the amazing event that was about to happen, instead of staying stuck in the past.

Isaiah 43:21

One purpose of redemption is to honor God through the praises of the redeemed (see 1 Peter 2:9).

Isaiah 43:22

Israel's history of rebellion led them into many crises. Their rebellion was so strong that they refused to ask God for help. When they did pray, their wickedness often caused God not to hear their prayers (Isaiah 1:15).

Isaiah 43:25

God alone can blot out sins. This means he completely removes and forgives them.

It does not matter how many sins a person has committed or how serious they are. God has the power to forgive them all (see also Isaiah 44:22).

Isaiah 43:27

spokesmen: God held the kings of Israel and Judah especially responsible for leading the nation into sin (see 2 Kings 21).

Isaiah 44:1–5

The promise of salvation gave Israel a future. Even though the people had sinned, God would still use them to bless the next generation (Isaiah 44:3).

The past had been dark because of their sin (see Isaiah 43:22–28). But the future would be different. God would begin a new time of blessing. His Spirit would change the people and make this new beginning possible.

Isaiah 44:3

- The restoration theme is connected with God's promise to pour out the Spirit (see also Isaiah 32:15–17; Joel 2:28–32; Acts 2:16–18).
- on your descendants ... your offspring: The next generation of Israelites offered hope.

Isaiah 44:6–20

This passage uses the form of a trial speech to press God's argument that disgrace comes to all who trust in idols and false gods.

Isaiah 44:15–17

He takes some of it to warm himself ... He also fashions it into a god and worships it: This description of making an idol is full of sarcasm and mocks the foolishness of idol worshipers (see also Isaiah 44:19).

Isaiah 44:18–19

closed their minds: Idol worshipers do not see the irony in using one part of a log for warmth and another part as their god.

Isaiah 44:21–22

The Lord promised to forgive the sins of Israel.

Isaiah 44:23

All creation is called to celebrate God's redemption of Israel (compare Isaiah 1:2).

Isaiah 44:24–45.8

The Lord alone is sovereign over history. He raised up Cyrus of Persia to execute judgment on Babylon and restore Israel to the Holy Land.

Isaiah 44:25

False prophets and diviners used forbidden methods to predict the future. Eventually, God would reveal them as liars who believed something that is not true (see Isaiah 3:2; 9:15; 47:13; Deuteronomy 18:10–11).

Isaiah 44:27

The sudden loss of natural resources sometimes shows divine judgment (see Isaiah 42:15; compare 43:20). Here, however, God's ability to dry up streams with only a word shows his power to fulfill his promises through Cyrus of Persia.

Isaiah 44:28

My shepherd: Cyrus did more than just allow the Jews to return home. He led a major project to rebuild Jerusalem and restore the temple (see Isaiah 45:13; Ezra 1:2–4; 6:3–5).

Isaiah 45:1

- His anointed: This title, usually for David or the Messiah, is used here for Cyrus. Cyrus was anointed because he was chosen for a special mission. No other foreign ruler received this title (compare 1 Samuel 10:1; Romans 13:1).
- whose right hand I have grasped: The Lord would help Cyrus defeat Babylon (see Isaiah 43:14).

Isaiah 45:3

so that you may know: Cyrus's victories show that the Lord can fulfill his plans. Idols and false gods cannot do this (see Isaiah 41:21–29).

Isaiah 45:4–5

I call you by name: Cyrus did not know the Lord, but the Lord knew him. Isaiah predicted the rescuer Cyrus by name 150 years before he was born. This prophecy would show the exiles that the Lord is truly God and that he knows the future.

Isaiah 45:7

light ... darkness ... prosperity ... calamity: Everything is under God's control.

Isaiah 45:9–11

pot ... the potter ... him ... his father: It is foolish for a creature to question the wisdom of its creator.

Isaiah 45:9–13

The Lord addresses those who doubt his decision to use a non-believing king for his plans. As the Creator, he is free and has complete authority. He promised to return his people to their land and would use anyone he chooses to fulfill that promise.

Isaiah 45:14

Egypt ... Cush ... Sabeans: Israel's restoration would give them new sovereignty. Foreign nations would honor God. Recognizing God's blessing on His people, they would also honor them.

Isaiah 45:17

Israel will never again face humiliation, disgrace, oppression, harassment, or abuse. These declarations suggest this promise will be fulfilled at the end of time.

Isaiah 45:18

Ancient pagan people saw the world as a place of empty chaos. However, God's plans are good. He created the world from the start to live in harmony with him.

Isaiah 45:18–25

Salvation comes only from the Lord. He is the creator, the revealer, and the one who carries out his will in human history. He promised to start a new era of salvation and righteousness (see Isaiah 45:8). Every person will submit to God, either by choice or not (Isaiah 45:23–24).

Isaiah 45:22

- Turn to Me ... all the ends of the earth: All people need to seek the Lord, the true God who created everything, while he is available (Isaiah 55:6).
- In God there is salvation, the only hope for all people (Isaiah 45:8).

Isaiah 45:23

- God's words are always true. When God swears by his own name, it shows he will never break his promise (see also Isaiah 14:24; 54:9; 62:8; Hebrews 6:13).
- Every knee ... every tongue: At the end of time, all nations will accept his authority, either willingly or unwillingly (see Romans 14:11; 1 Corinthians 15:25–27; Philippians 2:10–11).

Isaiah 45:24

In this context, the people include everyone who seeks salvation from the Lord, even those from other nations (Isaiah 45:22).

Isaiah 45:25

justified: Literally righteous (see also Isaiah 45:8, 24).

Isaiah 46:1

- Marduk-bel was the most important god in the Babylonian group of gods. Bel, similar to Baal, meant lordship.
- Nebo (Nabu, Nebu), the patron god of Babylonian scribes, was believed to be the son of Marduk-bel.
- Instead of being celebrated at a Babylonian festival, people would transport these gods on ox carts and discard them, as the Babylonian people rejected them.

Isaiah 46:1–2

This taunt was against the self-contradiction of Babylonian religion.

A taunt is a mocking song or speech. In this passage, the prophet makes fun of Babylon's beliefs. The message shows that their religion does not make sense.

Isaiah 46:3

- the remnant of the house of Israel: This refers to the survivors after Jerusalem's destruction in 586 BC.
- The Lord, the Creator of humanity, cares for and carries his people, unlike the Babylonian idols that need carrying.
- sustained from the womb, carried along since birth: The Lord chose Israel even before it became a nation (see also Isaiah 49:5).

Isaiah 46:8–13

Many exiles felt hopeless and doubted God's promise to rescue them. God addressed this doubt.

Isaiah 46:10

God knows the future before it happens; he controls all events, and his actions match his words (Isaiah 41:4, 26). He is the first and the last (Isaiah 44:6; 48:12).

Isaiah 46:11

The swift bird of prey from the east refers to Cyrus, the Persian king (see study note on Isaiah 41:2).

Isaiah 46:12

Formerly, Israel cared little for doing right (literally righteousness; see also Isaiah 58:2; 59:9).

Isaiah 46:13

- The good news for Israel was that God was coming to make things right (literally I will bring my righteousness near; see Isaiah 40:9; 51:5).
- adorn Israel with My splendor: Unlike a craftsman who gives material splendor to an idol (Isaiah 44:13), the Lord gives true dignity to his people.

Isaiah 47:1

To sit in the dust was a way of expressing humiliation.

Isaiah 47:1–4

In this taunt against Babylon, the nation is described as a proud queen.

But she is brought low and humiliated. Instead of ruling, she is forced to work like a servant girl.

Isaiah 47:1–48.22

We can draw two conclusions from the earlier evidence that the Lord alone is God:

1. Babylon's great pride is foolish (Isaiah 47:1–15);
2. Israel should listen to the word of the Lord (Isaiah 48:1–22).

Isaiah 47:3

God will bring justice to the world by punishing those who oppose him and oppress his people (see Isaiah 34:8). This will remove wickedness.

Isaiah 47:5–11

Babylon was known for its confidence and arrogance (see Isaiah 14:13–17; Daniel 4:30). The nation's charms, magic, and wisdom could not stop the disaster planned for it.

Isaiah 47:6

The people of Israel had provoked God's wrath, prompting him to use Babylon to punish them. Now wicked Babylon itself would be punished.

Isaiah 47:8

- I am, and there is none besides me: This was a claim to divinity (compare Isaiah 45:5; 47:10). Only the Lord can make such a claim. It is extremely arrogant for any created thing, including a nation, to say this.
- Being a widow or losing one's children was considered a disgrace.

Isaiah 47:9

People often used witchcraft and magic to protect themselves from evil and ensure a happy future.

Isaiah 47:10

Here, wisdom and knowledge likely refer sarcastically to the false knowledge from occult practices. This false knowledge led Babylon away from the truth and into disaster (Isaiah 47:11).

Isaiah 47:12–15

When disaster struck, Babylon turned to occult practices for help, but found none.

Isaiah 47:13

Babylon was advanced in astronomy, which the astrologers and stargazers used as a form of divination (see Daniel 2:2, 10; 5:7).

Isaiah 48:1

Jacob ... Judah: Isaiah usually focused on Judah, but here he spoke to all the tribes of Israel.

Isaiah 48:1–2

Israel was religious but not truly committed to the Lord.

Isaiah 48:1–11

This prophecy is a disputation, a speech in which the prophet argues a set of points against his audience.

Isaiah 48:1–22

The Lord urges Israel to abandon its long history of rebellion and pay attention to his words. In Hebrew, the word for listening often means the same as obeying or acting on what is heard.

Isaiah 48:3

The Lord had warned Israel about what was going to happen in the exile.

Isaiah 48:6–7

Although Israel often did not believe God's past predictions, God revealed new things they had not heard. Specifically, God revealed that Babylon would fall and Israel would be restored.

Isaiah 48:10

The exile in Babylon was a period of intense suffering (compare Deuteronomy 4:20) that God used to purify Israel.

Isaiah 48:11

For My own sake ... I will act: Israel's exile made other nations question the Lord's character and reputation. These nations did not see that Israel's wickedness caused the exile. Instead, they saw it as a failure of Israel's God to protect his people and their land (see Isaiah 36:19–20; 37:12; Ezekiel 36:19–26).

Isaiah 48:12–22

This final trial speech reviews the arguments of Isaiah 40–48 and presents the final conclusion.

Isaiah 48:14

chosen ally: See Isaiah 44:28; 45:1–2.

Isaiah 48:15

I have brought him, and he will succeed in his mission: Cyrus would humiliate Babylon and liberate Israel (Isaiah 45:1–4).

Isaiah 48:16

- I have not spoken in secret: God's promises are clear, though they do not always specify how or when they will happen.
- And now the Lord GOD has sent me, accompanied by His Spirit: The identity of the one sent is unclear. Isaiah might be referring to himself as a prophet inspired by the Spirit, speaking God's words to Israel. The connection with the spirit suggests it refers to the promised servant, the Messiah.
- The presence of the Spirit ensures the servant's success.

Isaiah 48:18

- Peace and righteousness will be established when the kingdom of God fully comes (see Isaiah 66:12).
- like a river ... like waves of the sea: There will be abundant peace and overflowing righteousness (compare Amos 5:24). Israel could have had this if its people had listened to God.

Isaiah 48:19

Your descendants ... as the sand: This fulfills God's promise to Abraham (see Genesis 22:17). In contrast, the Israelites were almost destroyed during the exile in Babylon (see Isaiah 44:26).

Isaiah 48:20

Leave Babylon: See also Isaiah 52:11–12; 55:12.

Isaiah 48:21

not thirst ... rock ... water gushed out: These reminders of God's provision in the exodus provide a fitting summary of what he would do to rescue Israel from captivity in Babylon (see Numbers 20:11).

Isaiah 48:22

This phrase, There is not peace ... for the wicked (also Isaiah 57:21), highlights the clear difference between the godly and the wicked (see 66:24). Peace represents God's kingdom, which does not include the wicked.

Isaiah 49:1

- O distant peoples: The servant's work would not be limited to Israel. His ministry would reach people in faraway nations (see Isaiah 42:4, 10, 12; 51:5; 60:9; 66:19).
- called Me from the womb ... He named Me: The promised servant's prophetic call was like Jeremiah's call (see Jeremiah 1:5; see also Galatians 1:15). It was not a general call but a very specific, personal one (see also Isaiah 43:1; 45:3–4).

Isaiah 49:1–13

This is traditionally seen as the second of four songs about a suffering servant (see study note on Isaiah 42:1–4). The servant's role in suffering becomes clearer (see also Isaiah 50:4–9; 52:13–53:12).

Isaiah 49:1–55.13

God planned to rescue the Israelites from exile. But an important question remained. How could sinful Israel serve the Holy One again?

God would make a way to remove Israel's sin. He would restore their fellowship with him. This means he would bring them back into a right relationship with himself.

The way would be through the promised Servant. This Servant would come for Israel and for all nations. He was first introduced in Isaiah 42:1–9. n this passage, he becomes the main focus.

Isaiah 49:2

My mouth: The servant's mission would be prophetic (see Isaiah 11:4; Ephesians 6:17; Hebrews 4:12; Revelation 1:16; 2:12, 16; 19:15).

Isaiah 49:3

The suffering servant would emerge from Israel (see Isaiah 41:8) and would be the true Israel. He would serve as both king (Isaiah 42:1) and prophet (Isaiah 49:1). He would be anointed with the Spirit of God (Isaiah 61:1). God would appoint him (Isaiah 48:16) as a faithful witness to God's plans (43:12; 48:20).

In his mission to both Israel and other nations (Isaiah 49:6), the suffering servant would face rejection and disgrace while remaining faithful, unlike the nation of Israel (see Isaiah 50:4–9). His suffering would be for the sake of God's chosen people.

Jesus became the ultimate fulfillment of the suffering servant (see study note on Isaiah 52:13–53:12).

Isaiah 49:4

- I have labored in vain: Even though people stubbornly refuse his message, the servant will still reach out to them.
- My vindication is with the LORD: Despite discouragement and suffering, the servant will continue to perform his duty faithfully, trusting God for the outcome. God promised to reward the servant's faithfulness (see also Isaiah 40:10; 50:8).

Isaiah 49:6

a light for the nations: As the Messiah (God's chosen one), the servant's mission would reach the entire world (see Isaiah 11:10, 12; 42:6). The apostle Paul explained his mission to the Gentiles based on this prophecy (Acts 13:47; 26:23).

Isaiah 49:7

- The promised servant will be disliked and rejected by the nations (see Isaiah 52:14–53:5) and by his own people (see also 50:6–7; 53:8–9).
- Kings and princes will bow low to show respect and humility to the servant (see also Isaiah 52:15). God will lift him up after he suffers. God is loyal to his servant.

Isaiah 49:8

God acts at the right time to achieve his goals (Acts 1:7; 2 Corinthians 6:2). Israel returned to rebuild the land of Israel after the exile in Babylon. The land was restored, and the city was rebuilt, starting with Cyrus's decree (Isaiah 44:26–28).

Isaiah 49:10–11

- Like a shepherd, the Lord in his mercy will guide the returning exiles beside cool waters. He promised to comfort them and meet their needs (see also Isaiah 40:11; Psalm 23:1).
- roads ... highways: The Lord would open up the way of salvation.

Isaiah 49:12

The remnant would come from the north (that is, Babylon and Persia), from the west by sea, and from as far south as Egypt.

Isaiah 49:13

This hymn of praise is in response to the salvation that the servant would make possible.

Isaiah 49:14

The prophet gave reasons to rejoice (Isaiah 49:8–13), but the exiles still thought about the disaster. Babylon invaded, destroyed Jerusalem, and took the people of Judah into exile. There, they felt abandoned and forgotten.

Isaiah 49:18

as jewelry and put them on like a bride: Just as a wedding is festive and public, God's restoration of Israel would be visible to everyone (see also Isaiah 61:10).

Isaiah 49:19–21

- The population growth would extend beyond Israel to include people from other nations who turn to the Lord (see Isaiah 56:6–8; Revelation 7:9).
- make room: The increased population would need space far beyond Israel's traditional borders (see also Zechariah 2:4).

Isaiah 49:22

bring your sons ... carry your daughters: The powerful rulers of the nations, some of whom had once harmed children in Israel, would help them return to Zion (see also Isaiah 60:3–9). In other parts of Isaiah, he imagined people from foreign nations coming to Zion to worship the Lord (see Isaiah 2:2–4).

Isaiah 49:23

- you will know that I am the LORD: The surprising role reversal, with kings and queens serving the humble

exiles upon their return, will show God's power to do the unimaginable (see also Isaiah 60:16).
- The godly will face temporary disgrace during the exile in Babylon but would not ultimately be put to shame, as the idolaters and ungodly were.

Isaiah 49:24

be snatched ... be delivered: The people considered it nearly impossible that they would be rescued from their oppressors.

Isaiah 49:25

The Lord is like a warrior who fights to protect his children, as promised to Abraham (Genesis 12:3; see also Isaiah 54:15).

Isaiah 50:1

- God was not responsible for the people's problems; their sin caused their exile (see also Isaiah 59:1–15).
- Jerusalem, the main city of Judah (Psalm 87:5–6), was destroyed, and the people of Judah went into exile in 586 BC.

Isaiah 50:1–3

This argument shows that God was not forced to abandon Israel. Therefore, he could choose to accept the nation back as his people if he wished.

Isaiah 50:2

- Why did no one answer: The people did not respond to God's repeated call to trust him and repent of their sins. They were deaf and stubborn (see Isaiah 6:9–10; 29:18; 35:5; 42:18–19).
- The Lord came and called the people through the prophets (see also Isaiah 65:1–3).
- do I lack the strength to deliver you?: God could rescue Israel and Judah from the Assyrians and Babylonians, but he first had to address his people's sinfulness (see Isaiah 59:1).
- My rebuke dries up the sea: This refers to the parting of the Red Sea during the exodus from Egypt (Exodus 14:21–22).

Isaiah 50:3

People connected events like darkness and wearing mourning clothes with the day of the Lord (Isaiah 13:10; see study note on Isaiah 2:5–22). The mention of darkness might refer to the plague of darkness in Egypt (Exodus 10:21).

Isaiah 50:4

The Lord, who never gets tired (Isaiah 40:28), sends the servant with good news (see 40:28–31) to comfort those who are tired (see study note on Isaiah 40:1–31).

Isaiah 50:4–11

This is the third of four servant songs (see study note on Isaiah 42:1–4). The loyal and suffering servant represents an ideal Israel. This image came true in Jesus Christ.

Isaiah 50:6

struck Me ... tore out My beard ... scorn and spittle: These connections with the experience of Jesus at his crucifixion are too close to not be intentional. Jesus is the true suffering servant (see Matthew 27:27–31).

Isaiah 50:7

- Externally, the servant would be disgraced and shamed by others. However, inside himself he would wait calmly for God to prove that he was right (see Isaiah 29:22; 54:4; 61:7). He trusted that God would defend him and clear his name.
- set My face like flint: The servant would be determined to follow God's will (see Luke 9:51).

Isaiah 50:8

- The One who vindicates Me is near: God defends those who suffer for following his will. Vindication is an act of God where he lifts up those wrongly shamed and punishes the wicked, proud, and arrogant (see also 2 Thessalonians 1:6–9).
- confront ... a case against Me: Trust in God's vindication removes fear and strengthens faith (see Romans 8:31–34).

Isaiah 50:9

Who is there to condemn Me?: This question expects the answer, "No one!" The servant is confident that no one can prove him guilty.

This statement points forward to the New Testament teaching about justification (God declaring a person to be right with him). Paul speaks about this in Romans 8:31–35).

Isaiah 50:10

- To see if someone respects the Lord, observe how they treat God's righteous servant. This idea is similar to the statement Jesus made that no one can reach the Father except through him (John 14:6).

- Those who trust in the Lord have strong hope for the future (see Isaiah 12:2).

Isaiah 50:10–11

This is a call for response to the servant's ministry.

Isaiah 50:11

all you who kindle a fire: Spiritually complacent people do not respond to God. They may feel comfortable and secure now, but they will soon experience great suffering (see Isaiah 66:24).

Isaiah 51:1

The rock and the quarry represent Abraham and Sarah (Isaiah 51:2).

Isaiah 51:1–8

This prophecy urges trust in the Lord. Each of its three parts starts with the phrase Listen to Me (Isaiah 51:1, 4, 7).

Isaiah 51:2

Abraham ... I blessed him and multiplied him: The exiled community had decreased in number. They needed to have faith that God could restore them again to a healthy and thriving population.

Isaiah 51:3

Eden ... the garden of the LORD: God's salvation will one day reestablish conditions like those in which human beings first lived (see Genesis 2–3).

Isaiah 51:4

- a law ... My justice: The servant's work will succeed because justice will guide God's kingdom on earth (see Isaiah 42:1–4).
- a light to the nations: The nations will accept the Lord and his revelation (see also Isaiah 42:6; 49:6; 60:1–3; 66:19–23; Matthew 4:15–16; Luke 2:32; John 1:4–9; 12:35–50; Acts 13:47).

Isaiah 51:5

God is strong enough to crush his enemies and rescue his people, such as when he rescued Israel in the exodus (see Isaiah 51:9; Exodus 6:6; 15:16).

Isaiah 51:6

die like gnats: Many wicked people will die on the day of God's judgment.

Isaiah 51:7

- My law in your hearts: The Lord wants his people to understand, value, and follow his word (see also Psalm 37:31; Jeremiah 31:33).
- Those who follow the Lord often face ridicule and insults (see also Matthew 5:10–12).

Isaiah 51:9–10

- Awake, awake: God does not sleep. This prayer asks God to act immediately to save his people (see Isaiah 52:1; see especially God's military clothing in 59:17).
- in generations of old: The exodus from Egypt was an act of redemption. It showed God's power as he made a path of escape (Isaiah 51:10) for his people (see also 11:15).

Isaiah 51:13

- you have forgotten the LORD: The Lord will never forget Israel (see Isaiah 44:21; 49:15), so they should remember him.
- The Creator of the world also created the nation of Israel.

Isaiah 51:14

The exile in Babylon brought harsh conditions like imprisonment, starvation, and death.

Isaiah 51:15

I am the LORD: The Lord uses this phrase to show he is the covenant God. It assures his people that his words are true and his actions are reliable (see Isaiah 27:3–4).

Isaiah 51:16

- My words in your mouth: The focus shifted back to the servant.
- You are My people: Israel was the covenant community.

Isaiah 51:17

- Awake, awake!: Israel used these words in a prayer to the Lord (Isaiah 51:9). Israel's problems were not because God was slow to act. Instead, the people were slow to believe God's promises.
- the cup of His fury: The Lord will give judgment in a just and measured way. He will judge in the right amount and at the right time.

Those who come under his judgment are described as drinking from a cup of his wrath. This is a picture that shows they must fully experience the results of their sin (see also Matthew 26:39).

Isaiah 51:17–23

The prophet called the people of Israel to be done with their past and to anticipate God's future for them.

Isaiah 51:20

Your sons have fainted: This phrase shows how terrible Jerusalem's destruction was. Even children became weak and collapsed from hunger and suffering.

The book of Lamentations also describes this deep sorrow and pain (Lamentations 1:13, 22; 2:11–12, 19).

Isaiah 51:22

God will defend Israel, just as he did when Assyria attacked Jerusalem (Isaiah 38:6).

Isaiah 51:23

The Babylonians were the ones who caused destruction, war, and famine (Isaiah 51:19).

Isaiah 52:1

- This second call to wake up (see Isaiah 51:17) was in preparation for a glorious future.
- holy city: The new city would be holy because its citizens would be holy (see Israel 4:3).
- will no longer enter you: Things that are unclean will not be permitted to enter the holy city (see Revelation 21:27).

Isaiah 52:3

You were sold for nothing ... you will be redeemed: The Lord was in control when he allowed his people to be captured by their enemies. He stayed in control and could save them if he wanted to.

Isaiah 52:4

went down to Egypt to live, then Assyria oppressed them: The exodus from exile would resemble Israel's past exodus from Egypt.

Isaiah 52:5

- The oppressors would shout with joy because they thought they had defeated both Israel and its God.
- My name is blasphemed continually all day long: The state of God's people influences God's reputation in the eyes of the world (see Isaiah 37:6, 23; 48:11).

Isaiah 52:6

Just as God revealed himself to Moses before the exodus (Exodus 3:15), he will reveal himself in the future rescue from exile.

Isaiah 52:7

- How beautiful on the mountains: See Nahum 1:15; Romans 10:15.
- The good news is more than ending the exile in Babylon. It also points to the peace and salvation of the age to come (Isaiah 54:13–14; see 40:9–10; 41:27).

Isaiah 52:7–12

This passage uses poetry to describe God's promise to save his people. Their sin had separated them from God (it had broken their relationship with him). God promised to remove that separation and bring them back to himself.

The picture is of a city surrounded by enemy armies. The people inside the city are waiting for news. They hope to hear that their hero has defeated the enemy and won the battle.

Paul uses these words to speak about the good news of the Lord Jesus Christ (Romans 10:15). He shows that this promise is fulfilled in the message about Jesus.

Isaiah 52:8

- The watchmen were those seeking news of Zion's redemption.
- the LORD returns to Zion: The sin of those who lived in the city had driven God away.

Isaiah 52:10

the salvation of our God: God saving his people from shame hints at a greater victory. God will rule triumphantly everywhere (note the similarities with Psalm 98:1–3).

Isaiah 52:11

Here the imagery of leaving the unclean enemy city encourages the people to purify themselves by turning away from all known sin. Those who carry home the sacred objects of the Lord need to be pure.

Isaiah 52:11–12

This is a call to escape the captivity of sin (see Isaiah 48:20 on leaving physical captivity in Babylon). See also 2 Corinthians 6:17; 2 Timothy 2:19.

Isaiah 52:12

- you will not leave in a hurry: At the time of the exodus, the people had to leave quickly (see Exodus 12:11, 31–36). Isaiah highlighted this difference to emphasize the newness of God's plan.
- your rear guard: See Exodus 13:21; 14:19–20.

Isaiah 52:13

prosper ... highly exalted: The servant will be wise and successful, standing with the great and noble. Similar terms describe God in Isaiah 6:1 and 57:15.

Isaiah 52:13–53.12

This is the fourth of four passages that speak about the promised servant (see study note on Isaiah 42:1–4). The Hebrew poem is carefully constructed in five three-line stanzas.It begins with the servant's exaltation (52:13), proceeds to his humiliation (52:14–53:9), and ends with his exaltation (53:10–12).

The faithful servant's suffering would bring reconciliation between God and humans. The Lord Jesus perfectly fulfilled this prophecy (see Isaiah 40; Matthew 8:17; Acts 8:30–35; Romans 10:15–17; 15:21; 1 Peter 2:24–25).

Isaiah 52:14

many were appalled: No one expected that the rescuer would suffer and die.

Isaiah 52:14–15

Despite the servant's greatness, the actual way he would appear on earth would surprise people.

Isaiah 52:15

- sprinkle many nation: They will be amazed that a rescuer appears weak and helpless, leaving them speechless.
- What they will see and what they will understand will be in complete contrast to anything they had previously imagined.

Isaiah 53:1

- our message: Scholars have debated who the speaker could be. The main possibilities are:

1. a faithful remnant of Israel, and
2. Isaiah himself.

Most likely, Isaiah the prophet was speaking for and with Israel.

- the arm: This refers to God's strength, vividly described in the previous chapters (see Isaiah 50:2; 51:5, 9; 52:10). It would show itself in weakness and apparent helplessness through the servant's humiliation and exaltation (see 1 Corinthians 1:27–30).

Isaiah 53:2

- a tender shoot ... out of dry ground: Such a plant is at risk of dying out (compare Isaiah 37:27). It struggles to survive, much less offer anything to others.
- no stately form or majesty: The servant seemed to lack greatness or obvious royal splendor (see Isaiah 52:13–15).
- to attract us: People prefer leaders who are good-looking and charismatic. The servant would be neither.

Isaiah 53:3

- a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief: The servant would suffer deeply. He would know pain and sadness from personal experience.

He would fully experience the results of human sin and the fall (the time when the first humans disobeyed God and brought suffering into the world).

- we esteemed Him not: People would not see how someone weak and insignificant could help them, so they would ignore his suffering.

Isaiah 53:4

- The uncaring world might think the servant caused his own suffering, not realizing he suffered for them.
- infirmities ... sorrows: These descriptions of the servant's humiliation contrast with those of his exaltation.

Isaiah 53:5

- He was pierced: See also Zechariah 12:10.
- crushed ... punishment ... stripes: These were typical punishments for crimes. Sin is a crime against God.
- brought us peace: The Hebrew word shalom is usually translated as "peace." Shalom means experiencing wholeness in body, mind, and relationships with others. The servant would be injured so humanity can be whole and healthy in all aspects of life (see also Isaiah 57:18). We do not need to suffer divine punishment for our sins because the servant has already done so (see Galatians 1:4).

Isaiah 53:6

gone astray ... turned to his own way: These phrases are metaphors for sin (see also Romans 3:10–18).

Isaiah 53:7

See 1 Peter 2:21–25 to see how Jesus Christ fulfills this prophecy.

Isaiah 53:7–8

The Ethiopian eunuch was reading this passage when Philip met him (see Acts 8:32–33).

Isaiah 53:8

- By oppression and judgment: The servant will not receive legal protection or a proper defense.
- cut off from the land of the living: To die in midlife was understood to be God's judgment.

Isaiah 53:9

- no violence, nor was any deceit: See 1 Peter 2:21–25.
- with a rich man in His death (see Matthew 27:57–61): Although the Bible often views riches as a blessing from God, it frequently condemns the rich as dishonest and oppressive. The point here might be ironic: This good man would be buried with oppressors.

Isaiah 53:10

- The servant's grief would lead to a greater good: the forgiveness and reconciliation of sinful humanity. Note also God's good plan to prosper and exalt the servant.
- when His soul is made a guilt offering: The servant's suffering served as a substitute for others, similar to animal sacrifices in the Temple.
- Having many descendants and enjoying a long life are rewards for living wisely and righteously (see Proverbs 3:2; 17:6; 20:7). Because the servant trusted his fate to God, he would receive eternal rewards from God, who vindicates the righteous (see Philippians 2:9–11).

Isaiah 53:10–12

The final stanza of the poem first explains why the servant suffered and was treated unjustly in the place of others; it then explains what the result of that obedience would be.

Isaiah 53:11

- His knowledge: This does not mean knowledge in the sense of ideas in the mind. It refers to everything the servant would live through. It includes his obedience, his suffering, and his close relationship with God.
- Because the servant obeys God fully, many people can be put right with God. This is called justification (God declaring a person to be right with him). He can do this because he will carry and bear their sins (see Genesis 15:6; Romans 5:18–19).

Isaiah 53:12

- a portion: See Philippians 2:9–11.
- He was numbered with the transgressors: Transgressors (Hebrew poshe'im) is a stronger word than sinners and is important in Isaiah. It refers to those who defy lawful authority, in this case, God.
- intercession for the transgressors: The servant would pray for sinners while suffering (see Exodus 32:30; Luke 23:34).

Isaiah 54:1

In the ancient world, a woman who had not given birth after marriage would feel ashamed. Isaiah compares Jerusalem to a woman without children who celebrates when she finally has them (see Galatians 4:27).

Isaiah 54:1–3

The prophet encourages Jerusalem, likened to a barren woman, to rejoice because its fate was changing very quickly. She would have so many children that she would outgrow her home (see Galatians 4:27).

Isaiah 54:1–17

Salvation flows from the vindication of the suffering servant. The promises mentioned here go beyond the return from Babylonian exile and apply to the coming of Jesus Christ, the extension of the kingdom to the church, the benefits of the second coming of Jesus Christ as the bridegroom of the church, and the new Jerusalem.

Isaiah 54:1–55.13

This is an invitation to participate in the restoration to God's favor made possible through the ministry of the promised servant.

Isaiah 54:3

- The descendants of Israel (compare Isaiah 53:10) would take over other nations, fulfilling God's promise to Abraham (Genesis 22:17) and Jacob (Genesis 28:14).
- As desolation occurred (Isaiah 6:11; 14:21), God's people would inherit the earth and rebuild the ruined cities (51:6; 52:10; 65:17; see also Matthew 5:5; Romans 4:13).

Isaiah 54:5

- husband ... Maker: The Lord committed to the abandoned woman (his people in exile) as her maker (Isaiah 44:24) and husband (see also Isaiah 62:4–5; Hosea 2:19–20).

- The Redeemer transforms misery into freedom and fulfillment (see also Isaiah 41:14).

Isaiah 54:7–8

- The pain of separation would be brief compared to the depth of the renewal of love and compassion.
- The Lord abandoned Israel in exile for a little while because of the people's sins.
- everlasting kindness: The Lord is always committed to his people, making the 70-year exile seem brief (see Isaiah 25:1; Hosea 2:1).

Isaiah 54:9

The exile was similar in both drama and trauma to the flood in the time of Noah. In both instances, people sinned grievously against the Lord, but the Lord renewed his commitment to creation (after Noah's flood) and to his people (after the exile).

Isaiah 54:10

- God's faithful love for his people continues even when they are unfaithful.
- God's covenant of blessing assures his presence, bringing wholeness, blessing, and protection. It replaces the shame and disgrace of the exile in Babylon (see Ezekiel 34:25; 37:26).

Isaiah 54:11

- The Lord himself would rebuild the city (see Hebrews 11:10).
- Sapphires are a semi-precious stone.

Isaiah 54:11–17

This describes a vision of Jerusalem renewed as a city under God's protection, a place of peace and righteousness (see Isaiah 59:21–60:22). This section provides the background for John's vision of the new Jerusalem (Revelation 21:10–21).

Isaiah 54:13

- will be taught: Jesus alluded to this verse in John 6:45.
- They will experience great peace, along with the benefits of God's presence and protection (Isaiah 53:5; see 48:17–18; 54:10).

Isaiah 54:14

Jerusalem would again be a righteous city, secure under a government that is just and fair (see Isaiah 1:26).

Isaiah 54:15

God assures that no nation can defeat his people. The Lord promises to protect them, just as he promised Abraham (Genesis 12:3; see Isaiah 49:25).

Isaiah 54:17

- No weapon ... shall prosper ... accuses ... vindication: God will protect his people in war and in the courtroom.
- This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD: Only the true children of God, from Israel and other nations, will enjoy the promised blessings of the future age that God establishes.

Isaiah 55:1

- thirsty ... wine and milk: The invitation to eat and drink is like Wisdom's call in Proverbs 9:5. This image promises to quench thirst not only with water but also with more expensive items like wine and milk.

John applied a similar theme to Jesus Christ (John 4:14; 6:27, 35; 7:37; Revelation 21:6; 22:17).

- without cost: Reconciliation with God is for anyone and has no cost.

Isaiah 55:1–13

This final chapter of the prophecies of comfort (Isaiah 40–55) summarizes the section's main themes:

- Blessing
- Covenant
- Witness
- Word
- Nations
- Glory
- Forgiveness
- Joy

Isaiah 55:2

Listen carefully to Me, and eat what is good: Responding positively to God satisfies one's spiritual, social, and physical being (see 1:19; 58:13–14; Proverbs 4:10).

Isaiah 55:3

- come to Me; listen, so that your soul may live: Those who obey God's word find eternal life (see also Isaiah 55:11).
- an everlasting covenant ... promised to David: God gave King David a special promise to preserve his royal line (see 2 Samuel 7:15–16). God promised that David's family line would continue forever. This promise is fulfilled in the kingship of the Messiah

(God's chosen king), Jesus Christ (see Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–16; Acts 2:22–36; 13:34).

Isaiah 55:6

while He is near: When God kindly offers an invitation to salvation, people must respond (Isaiah 65:1; Jeremiah 29:13–14; Hosea 5:6; 10:12). Those who do not seek him during these times may never have another chance.

Isaiah 55:6–9

The prophet calls for a response while the time is right.

Isaiah 55:7

- Let the wicked man forsake his way and ... return to the LORD: True conversion means changing how we live to follow God's rules (see Isaiah 1:16–17; 30:15; 59:20).
- have compassion: God's compassion reaches those in need, wherever they are.
- He will freely pardon: Forgiveness of sin is key to the good news of redemption (see Ephesians 1:7; Colossians 1:14; see also Psalms 32:1; 86:5; 99:8; 103:2–5).

Isaiah 55:8–9

My thoughts are not your thoughts: God's plans are wonderful (Psalm 92:5; compare Psalm 94:11). God's creations, including humans, cannot fully understand the Creator's thoughts. However, his messengers reveal insights and knowledge about some of his actions.

Isaiah 55:10–11

The Creator sends rain, snow, and his word (Hebrew dabar). Here, dabar means his will or plan (see Isaiah 14:24; 40:8). God's written word expresses his plan and achieves his goals. God is successful in all his actions (see Isaiah 14:26–27; 46:10).

Isaiah 55:12

- Joy is found in being redeemed from bondage.
- Godly people experience an inner peace not known to the wicked (Isaiah 48:22).
- mountains and hills ... trees of the field: Creation participates in the freedom of the children of God (Isaiah 44:23; 49:11, 13; see Romans 8:19–23).

Isaiah 55:12–13

The prophet tells the people not to focus on the past. He urges them to leave Babylon and return home. He also calls them to see things from the viewpoint of the coming age (the new time of salvation that God is about to bring).

Isaiah 55:13

- Redemption is like the transformation from desert to forest (see also Isaiah 35:1; 41:19; 60:13).
- this will make a name for the LORD: God's glory will become increasingly visible to people as his redemption takes effect.

Isaiah 56:1

- Maintain justice and do what is right: Isaiah 1–39 emphasize the importance of justice in relationships with others and God. True godliness comes from having a character shaped by God's character, achieved by understanding and consistently applying God's word.
- My salvation is coming soon: This summarizes the message of Isaiah 40–55, where the Lord is creating a world of harmony, peace, restoration, vindication, and the removal of enemies (Isaiah 46:13).

Isaiah 56:1–8

This section summarizes chapters 1–55 with an invitation to the outcasts to participate in God's redemption.

Isaiah 56:1–66.24

This last major division of the book of Isaiah brings together themes from chapters 1–39 (sin, justice, righteousness, responsibility, vengeance, and vindication) and chapters 40–55 (salvation and the age to come).

Isaiah 56:2

- Blessed: Compare Isaiah 30:18; 32:20; see also Psalms 1:1; 119:1; Matthew 5:3.
- The Sabbath is a sign of the covenant (Exodus 31:13–17), and is God's gift to his people. It applies to both the present age and the age to come (Isaiah 56:4, 6; 58:13–14; see Hebrews 4:1–13).

Isaiah 56:3

- Foreigners who commit themselves to the Lord would become full members of his covenant community. In earlier times, their participation had strict limits (Deuteronomy 23:3, 7–8).
- eunuch: In the past, a man who had been emasculated was not allowed to take part fully in the community (Deuteronomy 23:1). Both eunuchs and foreigners were seen as outside Israel's holiness. They were considered on the edge of God's people.

But in the age to come, God would bring those on the margins to the center. Those who were once excluded would be welcomed and honored (Matthew 20:16).

Isaiah 56:3–7

The blessing (56:2) would extend to eunuchs and to the Gentiles.

Isaiah 56:4

The Sabbath is a sign of the covenant (Exodus 31:13–17). It shows the special relationship between the Lord and Israel.

Isaiah 56:5

- in My house and within My walls: Those once excluded will have a place with God.
- a memorial and a name: Everlasting existence in God's presence is better than the blessing of physical descendants.

Isaiah 56:6

- The essential thing required for covenant fellowship is love for God (Deuteronomy 6:5; 30:20; Matthew 22:34–38).
- Keeping the Sabbath is a sign of keeping the covenant itself (see Exodus 31:13–17).

Isaiah 56:7

- burnt offerings and sacrifices: In the past, God rejected Israel's offerings when the people were living sinful lives (Isaiah 1:11–13). Their worship did not please him because their hearts were not right.

But God would accept offerings from righteous gentiles, that is, people from other nations who truly follow him. Being part of a certain nation does not matter if a person does not truly honor God.

- a house of prayer for all the nations: The Lord would open the temple to all nations (see Isaiah 2:2–4). Jesus criticized the people for disrespecting the temple and preventing it from being a house of prayer (Matthew 21:13; Mark 11:17).

Isaiah 56:8

- The outcasts of Israel were people scattered among other nations due to the exile in Babylon (see also Isaiah 11:12).
- The others included eunuchs and non-Jews (Isaiah 56:3–7; see also 57:19; John 10:16).

Isaiah 56:9

Wild animals are here a metaphor for the hostile nations surrounding Judah.

Isaiah 56:9–57.13

This passage reflects on how common evil had become among God's people. Many of them were greedy and wanted more and more for themselves (Isaiah 56:9–12). They treated righteous people with hatred and violence (Isaiah 57:1–2). They also worshiped idols instead of the true God (Isaiah 57:3–13).

Isaiah 56:10

- The leaders of Israel failed to guide and protect God's people from the sins that led to the exile in Babylon.
- dreamers ... loving to slumber: See Isaiah 29:10.

Isaiah 56:11

- shepherds with no discernment: Israel's leaders did not know how to rule in a godly way (see also Ezekiel 34:1–6). In contrast, the Lord is the faithful shepherd of his people (Isaiah 40:11).
- they all turn to their own way: They did not care about God or his standards for leadership (see also Isaiah 53:6).
- his own gain: Compare Isaiah 33:15.

Isaiah 57:1

- the presence of evil: Judgment that would come on the wicked nations.
- taken away: At times, God allows the godly to die in order to protect them from harsher times to come.

Isaiah 57:1–2

This is a lament for the righteous who suffer in a wicked society.

Isaiah 57:2

The wicked would not be able to rest in peace (57:21).

Isaiah 57:3

sons of a sorceress ... offspring of adulterers and prostitutes: Baal religion, which flourished in Israel before the exile (see Isaiah 1:21–23), included immoral sexual practices.

Isaiah 57:4

mocking ... stick out your tongue: The wicked oppressed the righteous by their insults (Isaiah 57:1–2; see also 28:9, 14).

Isaiah 57:5

- among the oaks, under every luxuriant tree: People often used groups of trees as places to worship false gods. These tree groves were common sites for pagan worship (see Isaiah 1:29–30).
- slaughter your children: Some people in Israel practiced the terrible act of child sacrifice. They offered their children to false gods. This happened at certain times in Israel's history (see Psalm 106:37–38).

Isaiah 57:6

People believed that liquid offerings and grain offerings would meet the basic needs of their gods. They thought these gifts would please the gods and cause them to show favor.

Isaiah 57:8

uncovered your bed: This phrase refers to sexual sin connected with idol worship. The people of Israel were deeply committed to fertility religions. These religions included sexual acts as part of their worship ceremonies.

This behavior showed how far they had turned away from the Lord.

Isaiah 57:11

The people were living in fear of false gods instead of fearing the Lord (see Isaiah 8:12–13).

Isaiah 57:12

The Lord did not see the people's righteousness (Isaiah 59:16) as truly righteous.

Isaiah 57:13

- Your companies of idols ... take them away: See study note on Isaiah 40:18.
- inherit the land: The Hebrew word translated land can also refer to the whole earth (see Psalms 25:13; 37:9, 11, 22, 29, 34; Matthew 5:5).
- My holy mountain: God's servants will enjoy his presence in Zion (see Isaiah 2:2; 56:7).

Isaiah 57:14–21

The Lord promises to be with the humble, heal them, and give them peace. This promise is for all citizens of Zion, both Jews and non-Jews. The holy one offers salvation to the humble and deals fairly with the wicked.

Isaiah 57:15

God is high and lifted up, yet he promises to live with the humble.

Isaiah 57:18

but I will heal him: Salvation is by God's grace (see Isaiah 19:22; 30:26; 53:5).

Isaiah 57:19

- praise to their lips: Those who experience God's redemption should respond with praise.
- those far and near: This includes both Gentiles and Jews (see Isaiah 56:3; John 10:16; Ephesians 2:17).

Isaiah 57:20

- storm-tossed sea ... it cannot be still: People who constantly oppose God (see Psalms 46:3, 6; 93:3–4) do not find inner peace because they are not at peace with God (Isaiah 30:15; 32:17).
- churn up mire and muck: Their actions are often unproductive (see Psalm 40:2).

Isaiah 57:21

no peace: Compare Isaiah 57:2; see also 48:22.

Isaiah 58:1–4

This is a charge against religious Israelites who were pleased with themselves because of their religious activities.

Isaiah 58:2

they seek me: They may have been truly committed to a religious form, but they failed to truly meet God in their religious activities.

Isaiah 58:3

Fasting should be a time of self-deprivation in order to focus on God and pleasing him (Leviticus 16:29; see Zechariah 7:5). However, these people were only interested in pleasing themselves and continuing in their sins.

Isaiah 58:5

- This passage uses strong language to show the problem with the people's fasting. Their fasting was only outward religious behavior. They did not truly repent or do what is right.

Fasting without sincere hearts and righteous actions is empty. It is only for show.

- People wore sackcloth and put ashes on their heads to show sorrow and mourning.
- acceptable to the LORD?: The people wrongly believed that God would bless them if they performed the correct rituals. They thought the actions themselves would bring blessing.

Isaiah 58:6–7

True fasting makes people aware of injustice and oppression. It encourages them to help those in need (see Isaiah 42:7; Matthew 25:35–36; James 1:27).

Isaiah 58:8

- your light: The light of the age to come will shine on those who fully turn to the Lord (see Isaiah 42:6–7; 60:1–3). The time of divine judgment and oppression will end.
- your healing: The nation of Israel was wounded when they were conquered and sent into exile.
- your rear guard: See also Isaiah 52:12.

Isaiah 58:9

- the LORD will answer: Compare Isaiah 1:15; see also 19:22.
- remove ... the pointing of the finger and malicious talk: God asks us to stop actions and words that harm relationships (see Proverbs 6:12–14).

Isaiah 58:10

your light ... will be like noonday: God would soon rescue and defend his people (see Job 11:17; Psalm 37:6).

Isaiah 58:12

Repairer of the Breach: Nehemiah would later fulfill this promise (see Nehemiah 2:17).

Isaiah 58:13

Like the practice of fasting, the Sabbath was intended to be an expression of self-denial and worship. It consists of delighting in the Lord, trusting him to provide for one's needs while abstaining from work, and living in obedience to his will.

Isaiah 58:14

- As people honor God through obedience, they themselves will be honored by God
- the heritage of your father Jacob: This includes living with many descendants in the holy land and enjoying God's presence, blessings, and protection (Genesis 31:3; 35:9–12).

Isaiah 59:1

not too short: The delay in their rescue was not due to any weakness in the Lord.

Isaiah 59:1–8

The people said the Lord could not rescue them, but the real issue was that they had not repented (Isaiah 59:20) and were still sinning.

Isaiah 59:1–20

The Lord alone will bring salvation. Like a warrior, he will enter the world to defeat his enemies and protect his holy people.

Isaiah 59:2

your sins have hidden His face from you: The Israelites, like all people (Romans 3:15–17), had sinned. This led to separation from God, who turned away.

Isaiah 59:4

calls for justice: Israel did not practice these qualities that are part of God's nature and that he expects from people (Isaiah 1:21; see 25:1).

Isaiah 59:5–6

The images of deadly snakes and spiders' webs represent plans designed to destroy others' lives and relationships.

Isaiah 59:7–8

- Paul quotes these verses when he describes the sinfulness of all people. He shows that everyone has turned away from God and does what is wrong (Romans 3:15–17).
- ruin and destruction: The people complained that others were treating them unfairly (Isaiah 51:19). They said they were suffering under oppression.

But they were also treating other people unfairly. They had become oppressors themselves.

Isaiah 59:9–15

Israel had a long history of turning away from God. The people often rebelled against him.

In this passage, the prophet speaks for the nation. He admits their sins and expresses deep sorrow. He says they could not grasp the light of God's salvation (they could not understand or receive the rescue God offered).

Isaiah 59:10

the blind: See Isaiah 6:10; Deuteronomy 28:29.

Isaiah 59:11–14

The people growl and moan with longing for redemption, finally coming to terms with their sinfulness.

Isaiah 59:15–17

The Lord acts like a warrior, determined to win against evil (see Ephesians 6:14).

Isaiah 59:18

He will repay according to their deeds: The Lord will give fair punishment to the whole earth. His justice requires judging people for the wrongs they have done (see also Isaiah 3:9–11; 13:9).

Isaiah 59:19

where the sun sets ... where it rise: That is, in all parts of the world.

Isaiah 59:21

The new community members have the Spirit and follow God's word (see also Ezekiel 36:24–28). The Lord promises to renew the children through his Spirit. He will bring them into a covenant of obedience and love for the Lord (Joel 2:28; Acts 2:39).

Isaiah 60:1–3

God will come to be with his people and will transform Zion's destiny from the darkness as black as night caused by sin and judgment.

Isaiah 60:3

The transformation of all nations and mighty kings will be so radical that all kingdoms will take notice and be drawn to God through his people (see also Revelation 21:24).

Isaiah 60:5–7

Zion will recover its losses from war through the wealth of many lands. Foreign nations will eagerly contribute (Isaiah 60:11; 61:6; 66:12; see Revelation 21:26).

Isaiah 60:6

- Midian and Ephah were Midianite tribes located southeast of Israel.
- Sheba was a region in southern Arabia (see 1 Kings 10:1–2). It was known for its frankincense (Jeremiah 6:20).
- These were real nations, and their restoration would be a historical reality, not just an idealistic vision. Many nations would submit to and worship the Lord.

Isaiah 60:7

- Kedar was a tribe in Arabia (Isaiah 21:16–17).
- Nebaioth was a tribe of Ishmael's descendants.
- I will adorn My glorious house: God's glory will be more evident than in Solomon's Temple (see Isaiah 6:1–5; Haggai 2:9; Revelation 21:11, 22).

Isaiah 60:9

He has glorified you: See Revelation 21:26.

Isaiah 60:10

their kings will serve you: God's people, once humiliated (Isaiah 2:11), will be honored.

Isaiah 60:10–16

Those who previously oppressed the people of God will one day participate in restoring the holy city (see Isaiah 2:2–4; 19:18–25; Nehemiah 2:8; Amos 9:12).

Isaiah 60:11

There are two likely reasons why the gates remain open at night (see also Revelation 21:25):

1. A lot of people will enter the city (Isaiah 60:8–10), so the gates must stay open.
2. The citizens of Zion will not fear enemies because the Lord protects them (Isaiah 60:18); the remaining nations will serve the Lord and his people (60:9, 12).

Isaiah 60:12

In the coming age, nations that refuse to obey God will be destroyed.

Isaiah 60:13

The temple was God's sanctuary, the symbol of his presence on earth. Believers now are the temple of God by the indwelling Spirit (1 Corinthians 3:16). We still await the fullness of God's presence (Revelation 21:22).

Isaiah 60:15

an everlasting pride, a joy from age to age: This would be a major change from the exile in Babylon. Fulfillments of this prophecy include:

- the return of the jews from exile,
- the arrival of Jesus Christ, and
- the inclusion of non-Jewish people in the church.

The final fulfillment awaits the glorious second coming of Jesus Christ, which will bring in the new Jerusalem.

Isaiah 60:17

- gold ... silver ... bronze ... iron: People use these metals for decoration and strength (compare Isaiah 54:11; Revelation 21:15–21).
- Peace and righteousness will create harmony and blessings among people and with God.

Isaiah 60:17–20

These verses describe the future greatness of Zion (compare Revelation 21:10–22:4).

Isaiah 60:18

you will name your walls Salvation and your gates Praise: People will enter the city of salvation through gates of praise to the Lord for his great salvation.

Isaiah 60:19–20

The sun and moon will seem dull compared to the brightness of God's presence (see also Isaiah 9:2; 30:26; Zechariah 2:5; Revelation 21:23–24).

Isaiah 60:21

- The citizens of Zion will be righteous, enjoying a right relationship with God and with others (Revelation 21:27).
- the land: Or all the earth (Isaiah 54:5; 62:7; 65:17; 66:22).

Isaiah 60:22

I am the LORD: The Lord reveals himself as the covenant God of Israel. His identity guarantees he will fulfill his promises (see Isaiah 27:3–4).

Isaiah 61:1

- The presence of God's Spirit guarantees the servant's mission will succeed (see Isaiah 11:1–5; 42:1).
- The servant will help and heal the marginalized, the poor, and those with broken hearts (see Isaiah 25:4).

Isaiah 61:1–3

The servant announces the good news that his work will restore Zion. The Lord Jesus used these words to describe his own mission (Luke 4:18–19).

Isaiah 61:2

- The time of the Lord's favor is the day of God's salvation (see Isaiah 49:8).
- the day of our God's vengeance: God turns his wrath against the enemies of his people. It will be a day of righteous vengeance (see Isaiah 34:8; 63:3–4).

Isaiah 61:3

- Putting ashes on one's head showed mourning (note the change from the judgment in Isaiah 3:16–25). Mourning would turn into joy. In Hebrew, the words for crown of beauty and ashes form a wordplay.
- oil of joy: A face covered with oil showed blessing and well-being (see Psalms 45:8; 133:2).
- The remnant would begin as small shoots. They would seem weak and unimportant at first.

But over time, they would grow strong and large, like great oak trees (see Isaiah 60:21).

Isaiah 61:6

priests ... ministers: The nation would fulfill its original calling (Exodus 19:6).

Isaiah 61:7

The people had faced God's wrath for their sins (Isaiah 40:2). Now, they would receive a double share of God's blessing.

Isaiah 61:8

Those who belong to the community of God's people are to imitate the character of God. God loves justice (see Micah 6:8) and hates wrongdoing (Isaiah 33:15).

Isaiah 61:9

- Their descendants: The agreement will be effective for all future generations.
- The Lord has blessed them to keep his promise to Abraham (Genesis 12:1–2; see Isaiah 65:23).

Isaiah 61:10

garments of salvation ... robe of righteousness: God will joyfully clothe his people with the gifts of salvation and righteousness (see Isaiah 51:5; 56:1), like a bridegroom or a bride (see 49:18; 62:5; Jeremiah 2:32; 7:34; 16:9; 25:10; 33:11).

Isaiah 62:1–12

The servant here commits himself to proclaiming the good news continuously until the glory of Zion is realized.

Isaiah 62:2

- The true beauty and glory of God's people would not be in earthly treasures or a rebuilt city. Instead, it would shine from their righteousness. Others would be attracted by this divine gift.
- A new name shows the change in Zion's status (see Isaiah 62:4).

Isaiah 62:4

- Forsaken: During the exile in Babylon, the Lord left his people to face the judgment they deserved (Isaiah 54:7).
- His bride: The people will be "married" to the Lord, symbolizing a close covenant relationship (Isaiah 54:5; Hosea 1–3).

Isaiah 62:6–7

- The watchmen probably represent the prophets.
- they will never be silent day or night: They will continually seek the full restoration and blessing of Zion, unlike the destructive watchmen of Isaiah 56:10.

Isaiah 62:8

- The Lord swore an oath just as he did when he had sworn an oath:
- to Noah (Genesis 8:20–9:17),
- to Abraham (Genesis 22:16; see also Luke 1:73; Hebrews 6:13), and
- to David (Psalm 89:3).
- Never again will I give: To punish and cleanse a small group of his people, God allowed the Assyrians and Babylonians to destroy them (see Isaiah 6:12–13). He promised not to do this again.

Isaiah 62:9

The people would enjoy the results of their work (Isaiah 65:13, 22; see Leviticus 23:39–40; Deuteronomy 14:22–26). This is the opposite of what happened when God judged them (see Deuteronomy 28:38–40; Amos 5:11; Micah 6:14–15).

Isaiah 62:10

- highway: See also Isaiah 40:3; 57:14.
- A banner for all nations to see serves as a signal. It directs foreigners to come to Zion for God's salvation. Earlier, a similar signal called for the nations to attack Judah (Isaiah 5:26).

Isaiah 62:10–12

This call to prepare for God's coming salvation combines elements from all parts of Isaiah:

- the proclamation (the banner, see Isaiah 5:26),
- the preparation of the road (Isaiah 40:3; 57:14),
- God's arrival with his reward (Isaiah 40:5, 9–10), and
- the holy and redeemed people (Isaiah 35:8–10).

Isaiah 63:1

- The Lord's robes are red with blood (Isaiah 63:3; compare Revelation 19:13).
- The name Bozrah (Hebrew botsrah) is a play on the verb batsar, which means "gather grapes."

Isaiah 63:1–6

The judgment of Edom serves as an example of how God judges all nations (see also Isaiah 34:5–15).

Isaiah 63:2

The term red (Hebrew 'adom) is a wordplay on the name Edom.

Isaiah 63:4

- the day of vengeance: See study note on Isaiah 34:8.
- redemption: See study note on Isaiah 43:1.

Isaiah 63:6

made them drunk: This phrase describes God's judgment. The wicked nations are pictured as people who drink strong wine and cannot stand straight.

They are forced to drink from the cup of God's wrath (his anger against sin). This image shows that they cannot escape his punishment (Isaiah 49:26; 51:17, 21).

Isaiah 63:7

loving devotion ... His praiseworthy acts ... the many good things: The whole history of God's care for his people demonstrates his compassion, provision, and protection.

Isaiah 63:7–14

The prophet reflects on Israel's past, how God showed his unfailing love and how his people alternatively rebelled against him, suffered hardship, returned to the Lord, and experienced his blessing.

Isaiah 63:8

- They are surely My people: God's ownership and commitment to his people were central to the agreement (see Isaiah 43:1).
- who will not be disloyal: The Lord expected his people to honor their relationship with him, unlike other nations, whose history is full of betrayal (Genesis 3–11). But Israel also betrayed their God (Isaiah 63:10).
- their Savior: God saved and protected his people (see Isaiah 43:3).

Isaiah 63:9

- He too was afflicted: God felt the pain of his suffering people, and their suffering caused him grief. Later, Jesus suffered for all humanity.
- He redeemed them: For example, see Exodus 12:25–33; 14:10–31; 23:20–23.

Isaiah 63:10

- But they rebelled: See also Isaiah 1:2, 4; 59:1–15; Psalms 78, 106.
- Persistent disobedience and unbelief grieved God's Holy Spirit (Psalm 106:33; Matthew 12:32; Mark 3:29).
- became their enemy: Examples include Israel's period of wandering in the wilderness (see the book of Numbers), the period of the judges (see the book of Judges), and the period leading up to the exile (see the book of Jeremiah).

Isaiah 63:14

God provided his people with rest after leading them into the promised land (see Isaiah 63:9; Joshua 1:13; 22:4; 23:1).

Isaiah 63:15–64.12

The prophet's reflections on the past (Isaiah 63:7–14) inspire him to pray that God would now rescue his people as he has done before.

Isaiah 63:16

our Father: God is described as a Father to his people. His care and faithfulness to his children are stronger and more secure than their family or national ancestry.

Their true identity does not depend only on being descendants of Abraham. It depends on belonging to God as his children (see Isaiah 9:6; 64:8; Deuteronomy 32:6; Psalm 68:5; Malachi 2:10; Matthew 6:9–15; Romans 8:15–17).

Isaiah 63:17

- The prophet understands that God has the power to keep his people faithful and asks why God has allowed them to stray from His path.
- Return, for the sake of Your servants: God also has the power to bring his people back to him (Ezekiel 36:25–27) and to defeat all their enemies.

Isaiah 63:18

- The people were supposed to be holy, but their lack of holiness had led to destruction.
- The holy place was the temple, which the Babylonians destroyed in 586 BC (Isaiah 64:11; 2 Kings 25:1–21).

Isaiah 63:19

Israel was constantly turning from God and then being punished by him.

Isaiah 64:5–6

we remain in our sins ... like something unclean: See also Isaiah 59:1–15. The only hope for salvation and transformation is through Jesus Christ (see Romans 7:25–8:11).

Isaiah 64:7

- You have hidden Your face from us: See Isaiah 1:15; 30:20; 59:2.
- delivered us into the hand of our iniquity: Because the people insisted on sinning, God left them to perish in their sinful ways (see Romans 1:24).

Isaiah 64:8

clay ... potter: See also Isaiah 29:16; 45:9; Romans 9:20–21.

Isaiah 64:10

holy cities: All the cities of Judah were considered holy to God. However, the temple in the host city of Jerusalem was the most holy place.

Isaiah 65:1–2

The Lord gave the people of Israel many chances to seek him (Isaiah 55:6; 58:2), but they did not do so.

Isaiah 65:1–66.24

Here, the Lord responds to the prayer in Isaiah 63:7–64:12.

Isaiah 65:3

Sacred gardens were a part of the fertility religion of Baal.

Isaiah 65:4

- spending nights in secret places: God had banned the practice of necromancy (consulting dead spirits; see Isaiah 8:19–22; 47:9; Deuteronomy 18:9–11).
- the meat of pigs and polluted broth from their bowls: See Isaiah 66:3–4; Leviticus 11:7; Deuteronomy 14:3, 8.

Isaiah 65:5

do not come near me, for I am holier than you!: The people of Israel used the words of ritual purification found in the law of Moses. They spoke as if they were clean and obedient to God.

But they also practiced worship influenced by pagan religions. Their actions did not match their words.

Because of this hypocrisy, God was deeply displeased. The text says they were like a bad smell in his nostrils. This image shows how offensive their behavior was to him (see Isaiah 1:10–15).

Isaiah 65:6

- Behold, it is written before Me: God is fully committed to carrying out his plan.
- The godly asked if the Lord would remain silent forever (Isaiah 64:12). God answered that he would not stay silent. He would address the wicked before restoring the righteous remnant.

Isaiah 65:7

The people of Israel practiced their pagan religion at sacred shrines on mountains and hills (see 1 Kings 14:23; Hosea 4:13).

Isaiah 65:8–16

The Lord planned to spare and reward a remnant of righteous people.

Isaiah 65:10

Sharon was a fertile and beautiful marshy region southwest of Mount Carmel (see Isaiah 33:9). The valley of Achor in the vicinity of Jericho was associated with the curse on Achan (Joshua 7:24–26). It would become a place of blessing (Hosea 2:15). These western and eastern regions might represent the renewal of the whole land.

Isaiah 65:11

Fortune and Destiny are names of pagan gods (Gad, Meni) believed to bring good luck and decide a person's future.

Isaiah 65:12

destine: This verb (Hebrew manithi) is a wordplay on Meni (see study note on Isaiah 65:11). Only God controls human and national destinies.

Isaiah 65:13–15

The difference between the wicked and God's servants affects all parts of life. God punishes the wicked but blesses those who truly serve him (see Isaiah 65:17–25).

Isaiah 65:15

The new name given to the faithful symbolizes a new identity and a closer relationship with the Lord (see also Isaiah 62:2).

Isaiah 65:16

the former troubles: Compare Revelation 21:4.

Isaiah 65:17

The new heavens and new earth will be a place of righteousness (see also 2 Peter 3:13; Revelation 21). Paul described believers in Christ as already being part of the new creation (see 2 Corinthians 5:17; Galatians 6:15).

Isaiah 65:18–19

Jerusalem here symbolizes God's eternal kingdom (Revelation 21:1–4).

Isaiah 65:24

God will be present with his people (see also Isaiah 19:22; 30:19; compare 1:15; 59:2).

Isaiah 65:25

The snakes represent evil (Isaiah 27:1; Genesis 3).

Isaiah 66:1

- My throne ... My footstool: God's kingdom extends over all creation (see Isaiah 40:22; Matthew 5:34–035).
- house ... place of repose: The entire universe is God's home, so humans cannot confine him to a building (see 1 Kings 8:27).
- Stephen quoted Isaiah 66:1–2a in his final sermon (Acts 7:49–50).

Isaiah 66:2

- God is pleased to live with people who are humble and have contrite hearts. A humble person does not think too highly of themselves. A contrite heart is a heart that is truly sorry for sin (Isaiah 57:15; Psalm 51:17).
- who trembles at My word: The humble and contrite submit themselves to God's will, but the proud resist it.

Isaiah 66:3

- delighted in their abominations: This refers to pagan worship practices.
- slaughters an ox ... blesses an idol: Some wicked people offered sacrifices as the law of Moses required. But they continued to sin and worship idols. Because of this, their sacrifices were no better than pagan offerings in God's sight (see Isaiah 1:11–17).

Isaiah 66:6

- listen to the voice from the temple: This is similar to the situation in Ezekiel 9 when God's executioner began to destroy the wicked people of Jerusalem.
- repaying His enemies what they deserve!: God would punish the members of his own people who refused to obey him. He would give them the judgment they deserved.

Because they continued in sin and rejected God, they had become his enemies.

Isaiah 66:7

in labor ... delivered a boy: See Isaiah 9:6–7; 54:1–3.

Isaiah 66:8

Can a country be born in a day or a nation be delivered in an instant?: Zion is pictured as a woman giving birth to many children. This image shows that the city will quickly grow in population (see Isaiah 49:19–20; 54:1–3; compare 1:8–9).

Isaiah 66:9

The Lord promised that he would surely recreate his holy nation.

Isaiah 66:12

a river: The people who lost peace and prosperity during the exile in Babylon will receive it back in abundance (see Isaiah 48:18).

Isaiah 66:13

will I comfort you: Compare Isaiah 40:1.

Isaiah 66:14

- flourish like grass: Contrast Isaiah 40:7; 64:6.
- God's enemies included disobedient people from foreign nations and from within Israel (see Isaiah 61:2 and 66:6).

Isaiah 66:15–16

- the Lord will come with fire: God will appear with furious judgment against his enemies (see Psalm 7:13). By contrast, he will reveal his glory to his people (see Isaiah 40:5, 10).
- God will judge all creation as a part of the process of renewing the earth (see Isaiah 24:1–4; 65:17).

Isaiah 66:17

People who dedicate (consecrate) and cleanse (purify) themselves through idol worship are offensive to God (see Isaiah 1:28–31; 65:4).

Isaiah 66:18–23

When God reveals his glory to all people, the nations join in God's plan of redemption. They can even serve as priests and Levites before him. The godly from all nations last from generation to generation as they serve the living God.

Isaiah 66:19

The sign announces God's glory to all nations (Isaiah 66:20). God will establish a righteous and faithful new people made up of godly Gentiles together with faithful Israelites (Revelation 15:3–4; see also Acts 2).

Isaiah 66:21

That some of the Gentiles would serve as priests and Levites shows the removal of God's distinction between Hebrews and Gentiles (see Isaiah 56:7; see also Galatians 6:15; Ephesians 4:11–13).

Isaiah 66:22

- will endure before Me: God's promise to Abraham was certain (Genesis 17:7; see also Galatians 3:8, 14).
- your name will endure: The identity of this new people will last forever (see Isaiah 59:21).

Isaiah 66:24

- Isaiah gives a final warning of the severity of God's judgment. The book begins and ends with the condemnation of those who have rebelled (see Isaiah 1:2–4).
- God's judgment on wicked people will cause extreme fear because they will have no hope or relief from suffering (see also Matthew 5:22; 25:41; Mark 9:47–48; Revelation 20:11–15).